there are bridges you cross

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/29615475.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Memory Alteration, Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Canon up to episode 7 of season 1 and diverges after that, POV Catra (She-Ra), Role Reversal, sort of? catra's the one wanting to leave the horde and adora's the one who wants to stay, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner's A+ Parenting, catra accidentally develops a conscience and hates every second of it, rated t for swearing bc catra and glimmer should get to swear tbh, title is from wicked because i have no shame anymore

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there are bridges you cross

by ariesnoctua

Summary

"No, I've taken care of the issue myself. Adora won't be going back to the Rebellion. She won't even try."

"And why's that? Sudden change of heart? Another morality crisis?"

"Because she won't remember them."

Or: Shadow Weaver's plan in Mystacor actually succeeds, and she makes sure Adora won't ever want to leave again.
Or: Catra gets everything she's ever wanted.
Or: Does she?

(or: AU where Shadow Weaver gets Adora back early s1 and wipes her mind of She-Ra and the rebellion)

Notes

sometimes you just gotta write a season 1 AU a year after the show ended, yk?

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The summons comes unexpectedly, taking today from shitty to exponentially shittier.

Not that anything in particular happened –it's just what days are like, lately. Part of it's the way the others freeze up whenever she shows up, now that she's Force Captain. It *should* be satisfying, but instead it just feels kinda hollow. Probably because she always thought that there'd be two of them being Force Captains, instead of just being stuck on her own –but that's not something she lets herself dwell on too much.

She's in the middle of a training session when the guard appears, voice metallic and flat through his helmet as he tells her Shadow Weaver is expecting her in the Black Garnet chamber, *immediately*. Like he's telling her about the weather, or something, instead of the complete ruination of her already pretty goddamn terrible day.

For a moment, she stands there, and considers not going. Thinks about Shadow Weaver's face as she waits for Catra to show up; whatever boring, grandiloquent speech she's prepared –or maybe she just improvs them, who knows– forever stopped before it can begin. The thought *is* pretty satisfying.

And then she sighs and heads to the locker room to change.

She's learnt to know what to expect, in the Chamber. The most likely is probably some kind of long, dramatic diatribe about her own incompetence. Maybe worse, if Shadow Weaver's plan to get her prized Force Captain back failed especially spectacularly.

What's she's *not* expecting, however, is to find herself staring at said Force Captain in person.

Adora's passed out, on a low table that could pass as a cot if you were blind and also didn't know what a cot was. There's a nasty looking bruise on her temple, her uniform's ragged and torn in places, and her hair is a mess, but it's unmistakably, definitely *her*.

A lot of emotions rush through Catra at once. She barely has the time to make sure any trace of *relief* is stamped out before Shadow Weaver melts out of the shadows, voice dripping with sarcasm. "Ah, Catra. How kind of you to join us."

For once, she's too gobsmacked to come up with a smart-ass reply.

Then again, it's not like Shadow Weaver needs much prompting. She drifts over to Adora's side, head tilted as she looks down, one hand smoothing over the flyaways that have escaped the girl's ponytail. "You'll notice we have a returning element."

Catra finds her voice, but she's still too taken aback to school her tone, be it into snark or respect. "How did you–"

A dismissive handwave interrupts her. "Well, as always, I have found the old adage to be true: if you want something done *properly*, then you ought to do it yourself. My shadow spies proved remarkably more efficient than your attempts." Even with the smooth, impassible metal of the mask, the disdain in her expression is perceivable. "Then again, that was to be expected."

Catra clenches her fists but doesn't take the bait.

Shadow Weaver's tone softens, losing the hard edge as she strokes a light, gloved finger against the bruise at Adora's temple. "They caught up to her in Mystacor, just as planned. Unfortunately, some… complications arose, making it so her removal from the situation ended up necessitating a bit of unpleasantness." The finger lingers on the bruise for a moment, before lifting. "But it's for the best, in the end."

So she sent her spies to trail Adora, knocked her out, and dragged her back the Fright Zone. Talk about unoriginal. Catra'd have

succeeded too, if she'd had *magical shadow spies that could go anywhere*.

She crosses her arms, trying to regain a bit of composure. "Congrats," she says, a corner of her mouth lifting sardonically. "I'm sure Adora's going to be so touched. *Oh, wow, you sent your creepy shadow spies after me and clubbed me over the head? Well, of course* now *I'm going to leave the rebellion and come back to the Horde*." Catra shakes her head. "She'll be gone as soon as she wakes up if you don't lock her up, and I'm guessing that's not very Force Captain duties compatible."

She's expecting some kind of telling-off –Shadow Weaver rarely appreciated being reminded of the flaws in her plans, after all. To her surprise –and uneasiness–, the woman only laughs, the sound grating.

"Oh, that won't be a problem." She turns back to Catra, and she *hates* how she feels herself stand up straighter in response. "Which is why you're here."

She still manages an eyebrow raise. "Thought we'd established I really wasn't the right motivation to keep Adora around." The words are full of sarcasm, but the truth beneath them stings.

"Do you really think I'd rely on *you* for anything, much less something important as this?" She lets out a dismissive breath that could almost have been a laugh. "No, I've taken care of the issue myself. Adora won't be going back to the Rebellion. She won't even try."

"And why's that? Sudden change of heart? Another morality crisis?"

"Because she won't remember them."

The quick, snarky retorts die in Catra's throat, along with her bravado. "What?"

Shadow Weaver shakes her head, almost indulgently. "You always did underestimate the extent of my abilities, Catra. I don't know why –it's hardly as though I gave you reason to." She sighs, turning to look at Adora over her shoulder. "I removed all memory of her interactions with the Rebellion. Anything that happened over the past couple of weeks, since the day before she left."

Catra's throat is drier than sandpaper, and there's a weight crushing her chest, and she can't *breathe*– "You can't do that."

She can *hear* the smile under the mask, the mix of pity and genuine amusement. "Oh, Catra. Do you really think there's anything I *cannot* do?"

There's always been rumors, of course. Shadow Weaver can be in several places at once. Shadow Weaver can see through walls. Shadow Weaver melts like old plastic in direct sunlight and that's why she always wears a mask –okay, that one she'd made up to make Adora laugh.

But of all of them, all those stupid rumors, *Shadow Weaver can get into your head and do what she wants* had always been the worst, to Catra. The woman was everywhere already, seeping into every corner, every minute of her existence, with a sharp word or a glacial reminder of all the ways in which Catra was a disappointment. The idea that she could get into her head not just metaphorically, but physically? That there was really nothing that would be safe from her grasp? It had struck home, creating a twist of fear at the pit of her stomach that she'd never quite managed to shake off. She'd grown up, relegated the idea to stupid childhood belief, but never really managed to completely ignore the cold, awful feeling of *what if*.

The confirmation that it is real is about as welcome as a baton hit to the face. Cuts off her breathing like one, too.

"With the memories gone, Adora will have no reason to go back to the Whispering Woods," Shadow Weaver continues. She flicks her hand, and the shadows at her feet grow tangible, twisting up into

the air, finally parting to reveal that stupid sword. In the dark red light, it looks washed out, fragile. "And even if she *were* to go back, there'd be nothing for her to find."

Another flick of the wrist, and the sword is gone. She turns back to Adora, head tilting.

"It's a shame. She was gone so long; there was a lot to take away. The aftereffects might be much worse than what they'd have been if you'd brought her back when I asked you to." A despondent shake of the head. "Just one more of the many ways in which you've made her life worse."

"It won't work." In her panic, she's forgotten to paper her words over with cool indifference or disrespectful mockery. Her tone is far too close to *desperate* for comfort, but she can't help it. "Okay, yeah, you take her memories. You take her magic sword, whatever. But she's a Force Captain now. You're going to have to send her into the field eventually, and then she'll see. She didn't leave because of the Rebellion or the stupid sword. She left because she saw what the Horde was doing. She saw–" *People being hurt, the same way Catra had been getting hurt, all her life.*

It'd never been enough, when it had just been Catra, though.

"She'll leave again," Catra finishes, voice firmer to silence the thought.

But Shadow Weaver isn't angry –she keeps that same, pity-filled calm that is setting every nerve Catra has on edge. "Everything has been taken care of," she simply says, with her usual level of annoyingly cryptic.

Before Catra can ask –not like she would give the woman the satisfaction anyway–, Shadow Weaver continues, her usual authority seeping back into her voice: "When Adora wakes up, she'll remember having been attacked by rebels during your little… outing." The word carries all the weight of the punishments Catra's had to endure for it. "As far she'll be concerned, she'll have

spent the following two weeks at their mercy, until the Horde led a successful operation to retrieve her. I've given her mind suggestions of what could have happened, but her recollections will be blurry at the most, gaps filled in by her own mind. *You* are not to contradict any part of that story."

The threat isn't even veiled, but Catra's still reeling, trying to see how Shadow Weaver can think *any* of this could ever work, and battling with the very strange feelings that come with the idea that it *might*. "But the others–"

"All rumors to the contrary, any word of Adora having *defected*, have been taken care of." With the new knowledge of Shadow Weaver's abilities, the words carry more meaning than they ever have. "I hope you realize that I would not be pleased to hear any more of that nonsense whispered amongst the cadets."

Threat, again. "If you're worried I'm going to blab, why aren't you taking my memories too?" The very idea makes her blood run cold, second only to the thought that, for all she knows, Shadow Weaver's done it before –how would she know any different?

She's almost expecting her to reveal that it's what comes next, that it's the real reason Catra was summoned here.

But no. She's much crueler than that.

She scoffs. "Why would I?" Slowly, she lifts a hand, and Catra feels her muscles lock into place as the first tendrils of magic wrap around her ankles, drifting up. "No, I *want* you to remember. I want you to remember how *kind* I was to you."

The black shadows are ice cold as they wrap around her ribcage, but it's not why she freezes up when Shadow Weaver takes a step forward and delicately brushes her gloved fingers against her cheek. "After all, this is what you wanted, isn't it? Adora, back with the Horde. Everything as it should be. You should be thanking me."

The shadows tighten suddenly, turning into ice cold iron around her, and Shadow Weaver's fingers close into a hard, tight grip around her jaw. "*However*. I am not prone to giving second chances. Should I find myself in the position of having to reprogram Adora again, I might find myself being a lot more *thorough*."

She lets go, but black shadows take up residence around Catra's throat instead, unyielding. Shadow Weaver tilts her head. "Adora's attachment to you has always held her back. I'm sure she could achieve so much more if it were to be… removed."

She *can't* do that– there's no way she could do that. They *grew up* together; removing Catra would mean removing Adora's entire childhood, and Catra *knows*, she's *sure* that even Shadow Weaver couldn't do that–

"And *then*," Shadow Weaver continues, as Catra struggles to breathe through the unbreakable hold –or maybe just through the words–, "who knows what'll happen to you? Stars know you're only here because Adora cares to keep you around. You're nothing if not for her, not to anyone here. So I strongly suggest you keep my instructions in mind, for *both* your sakes."

But what if she can?

Satisfied with Catra's silence –even if she wasn't struggling to breathe enough to stay conscious, she doubts she'd find anything to say–, Shadow Weaver taps a gloved finger to her Force Captain insignia. "As for *this*, with Adora's return, there's no need of your keeping it. The Horde has quite enough Force Captains to–"

A small, pitiful groan echoes from the cot.

Instantly, the tendrils fall away, dissolving into nothing. Catra gasps for air, hands falling to her knees for support, as Shadow Weaver turns around. "*Adora*." Her tone has lost all the sharpness, instead turning so syrupy sweet it almost makes Catra gag.

Adora blinks a few times, expression hazy and confused. She attempts to sit up, one hand immediately flying to her temple with another groan of pain. "What– Where am– What happened?"

"You'll be confused for a little while, it's perfectly natural," Shadow Weaver continues, fake concern lacing the edges of the words like barbs along a wire.

But Adora's shaking her head now, heel of her palm digging into her eye as she mumbles. "No, this isn't– I'm not… Why am I…"

For one *glorious* moment, Catra thinks she's about to witness Shadow Weaver *fail*.

And then, Adora glows. Not the blinding, headache inducing way she does when she uses her sword –no, this is the dim, dark red glow that suffuses every one of Shadow Weaver's tricks. Feeling vaguely ill, Catra watches as the light recedes and Adora's expression relaxes, her hand dropping. "Shadow Weaver," she says, like this is *normal*, "ma'am, I'm so–"

But the woman interrupts the budding apology with a wave of the hand. "We'll discuss this later. We're only happy to have you back with us, Force Captain."

Adora nods, wincing a little as she brushes a finger against the bruise. "The rebels–"

"–were taken care of," Shadow Weaver completes, and when Adora nods again, it's more resolute.

"Good. I–" She looks up, and her sentence trails off when her gaze falls on Catra.

For one irrational second, she thinks Adora's about to *pounce*.

Instead, the girl breaks into a wide, happy, fucking *dazzling* smile. "Catra!" she exclaims, like she's so happy to see her –and, well, she probably is.

It's almost worse than if she'd attacked.

Shadow Weaver's eyeroll is almost audible. "Catra," and she says it like you'd talk about a slug you accidentally stepped on, "will take you back to your quarters to rest–"

But Adora's not listening, instead struggling to right herself, eyes wide and happy. "You're okay! I'm *so* sorry, I didn't mean for you to be in danger like this, I should have been more careful in the first place–"

The barrage of apologies is very Adora-like, but its contents don't make any sense. "What," Catra says, a bit blankly, because, well, *what*?

Adora pauses, cocking her head to the side like *duh*. "Well, the operation, obviously! I can't believe your first Force Captain job was to retrieve *me*, ugh, I'm such an idiot." She winces for a bit, but it softens back into a proud, happy smile. "Congrats on a job well done, though."

It takes a while to click in Catra's head –and, from her baffled silence, in Shadow Weaver's too.

Adora thinks *Catra*'s the one who rescued her from the clutches of the Rebellion.

Catra briefly considers knocking Shadow Weaver's mask off, just so she can see her *face*. Adora's brain would fill in the gaps, *in-fucking-deed*. If she wasn't so on edge, she'd probably have started cackling. Shadow Weaver's orders are simple –no contradicting whatever story Adora comes up with. *That* means that, as far as everyone is now concerned, Catra is the Force Captain who's managed to bring Adora back to the Horde.

Shadow Weaver, who, after all, had been in the midst of trying to demote Catra, takes a second to respond. When she does, it's with a deliberate slowness that implies that every single word is causing her physical pain. "Force Captain Catra," she grits out,

"take Force Captain Adora back to her quarters to rest. Immediately."

Unable –and not wanting– to suppress the smirk pulling at her lips, Catra flips a lazy salute and heads for the cot. Reflexively, Adora reaches for her and stumbles to her feet. For a moment, Catra wants to freeze at the contact, expects Adora to recoil. But the girl only leans against her, just enough to be able to stand up straight without her knees giving in, as they start towards the door. The same way she's always done.

So why does it feel so *wrong*?

Once they're out of the Chamber, and out of Shadow Weaver's sight, Adora lets herself rest on Catra a bit more, slouching forward with a groan.

The mess of emotions inside Catra's chest is *much* too tangled to begin to unravel. Instead, she tightens her grip around the other girl's shoulder, and tosses a quick: "You okay?"

Adora only nods, which Catra knows means she probably really isn't. She leads them to a stack of crates, a bit out of the way of the main hall, and Adora all but collapses on it, forehead coming to rest on her knees. "I'm sorry," she mumbles, a bit miserably, and doesn't it pull something in Catra's chest to hear her say those words so easily, when they're all she's wanted to hear for two weeks.

She stamps out the feeling, crossing her arms as casually as she can. "You got kidnapped by rebels and knocked over the head. You get a pass for a little while."

Adora lifts her head just enough to toss her a quick look from between her arms. "How long?"

"Like, a day."

She does that little snort-giggle thing Adora always does, and *why* is it so surreal? She was only gone for *two weeks –this* is normal.

It shouldn’t feel as weird as it does.

“Thank you.”

Catra jumps. “What?”

“For coming to get me.” Her eyes are wide and so *earnest*, and something twists in her stomach. “And I *am* sorry I put you in danger. All of you. So, you know. Thank you.”

The twist pulls tighter. She shrugs, looking away. “Well, you know. If you’re not around, I’m the one that’s going to have to do your job. Can’t have that.”

Out of the corner of her eye, she can see a bit of that earnestness melt back into amusement. “Riiight,” Adora says. “You sure it’s not because you like me?”

“It’s *not* because I like you.”

Adora hums like *yeah, sure*, before breaking into laughter. It’s tired, a bit weak, but it’s Adora, laughing with her. Like it’s happened millions of times. Like Catra’s been wishing it would happen again, ever since that stupid day in the woods. Part of her relaxes at the familiarity.

Another part of her says *this is what you wanted,* in a cold, metallic voice, and all hint of warmth flees her immediately. She straightens up, swallowing hard. “Come on, let’s get you back to the barracks. You need to sleep.”

Adora nods, apparently missing the shift in tone, and she lets Catra pull her to her feet with no resistance. They start again on their slow, laborious march to the barracks, Adora’s head gradually lowering to Catra’s shoulder as they cross empty corridors. Catra thinks she might have fallen asleep, or near enough, but she speaks again, words slow and the tiniest bit slurred. “I’m glad they didn’t get you, too.”

Catra almost trips, regaining her balance just in time to avoid sending the both of them crashing to the floor. “What?”

“The rebels. I’m glad you got away.”

“Oh.” Right. As far as Adora’s concerned, they were both attacked, and Catra managed to escape, letting Adora get captured. How very Shadow Weaver.

Honestly, she’s almost offended that *this* isn’t enough to get Adora to see that the whole memory is fake. As if Catra ever would – *she*’s not the one who leaves people behind.

Before it can make her bitter enough to do something really stupid, that train of thought gets completely derailed by Adora’s next few words: “I did miss you, though.”

Now *that* doesn’t sound like Shadow Weaver. “Do you even remember any of it?” she asks, managing to land on casual even though her stomach’s flipping all over itself.

Adora lets out a breath of a laugh –Catra feels it against the side of her neck more than she hears it, and she reflexively bites her own cheek, hard. “Maybe not *all* of it,” she admits. “It’s kinda… blurry. But I remember that.”

Catra doesn’t respond, because what the *fuck* is she supposed to say to that, but Adora isn’t done, apparently. She taps a finger against the insignia Shadow Weaver tried to take back barely a few minutes ago. “Congrats on the promotion by the way. I’m glad at least *some* good came out of this mess.” Her hand drops, and Catra feels her lean against her a bit more. “Shadow Weaver can’t deny how good you are now that she’s seen you in action.”

“She definitely can, and she definitely will.”

Adora scrunches her face a little –Catra sees it out of the corner of her eye, even though she’s trying to focus on literally anything else. “Okay, yeah, she might. But everyone *else*’ll know at least. And we’re both Force Captains now; just like we always wanted.”

You should be thanking me.

Catra's saved from having to come up with an answer by their arriving at the door of the sleeping quarters. They stumble through, and Adora crashes face first onto her bed, face smushing into her pillow with a low groan.

Déjà vu floods Catra, endless occasions where they'd taken each other back to the barracks after a training incident flashing through her mind. She clears her throat. "You should, uh, sleep. I'll– get you something to eat, or whatever."

She's already backing up, but before she can get out, Adora's hand shoots out, grasping her wrist. "Wait," she says, head lifting, revealing wide, panicked blue eyes. She blinks a few times, looking lost. "Can you… Can you stay?"

The irony almost kills her on the spot.

Why should I? You didn't.

"Please?" Adora adds, voice softening into a barely audible whisper.

She swallows against a dry, scratchy throat, and, reflexively, starts to take a step forward.

I'm not coming back, Catra.

She jumps back, breaking Adora's hold. The girl's reaction is immediate, expression falling, and Catra swallows down the guilt. "I– I can't right now. I'll come back round later."

"Oh." It's like everything about her has just deflated –she's hunched over, eyes looking down in an –unsuccessful– effort to hide the hurt shining in them. "Yeah. Okay."

Catra bolts. She's pretty sure she doesn't even *breathe* until she's out of that room, the door safely shut behind her. Only then does she let herself fall back against the wall, breathing ragged.

This is what she wanted. Everything is back to normal.

So why does it feel like anything *but*?

Chapter End Notes

This was originally going to be a one-shot, and then it was going to be 3 chapters, and then chapter 1 ended up being 10k, so now it's 4 chapters. If the other chapters end up the same way (which they really might, lol), the count might go up a bit.

Thank you for reading, and I'd love to hear what you thought!

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Everyone is *thrilled* to have Adora back.

At first, Catra doubted that Shadow Weaver had really managed it. After all, she knows firsthand how quickly rumors spread in the Fright Zone, and how hard they are to stamp out. Word of Adora's switching sides had been gaining traction over the past few days. No way, she thought, had Shadow Weaver managed to track down every whisper of it.

But either it wasn't as largely spread as she thought, either Shadow Weaver did some kind of mass mindwipe, because there isn't even a shifting glance or a hint of a whisper. No, all Adora gets are congratulations and enthusiastic welcomes. It's not *that* surprising, because Adora's always been liked.

What's much more bizarre, is that Catra gets her own share of it too. Apparently, word has gone around that she's the one who led the operation to get Adora back. The fact that there never was an operation isn't a problem, somehow –suddenly, everyone knows about it, even if no one seems to remember the details.

But, as weird as they are, the congratulations and admiring smiles aren't really the problem, right now. She wishes it were that easy.

She hoped, at first, that it was just the shock; that things would feel like normal soon enough, because, well, on the outside at least, they were. Better than normal, even; she and Adora, both Force Captains, working together, fighting together. It was what they'd always wanted.

Unfortunately, even now, days later, everything is still tinted with that off, unsettling haze. It takes her a little while to put her finger on it.

She’s waiting for the other shoe to drop.

For all the time she’s spent hoping Adora would come back and that things would get back to normal, the fact that they just *have* feels too simple. Catra’s known Adora a long time, and she’s by far the most stubborn person she’s ever met. Deep down, Catra knows that when Adora said she wouldn’t be coming back to the Horde, she meant it.

So the fact that she *is* here now, like none of it ever happened… It feels wrong. Temporary. Like a dream that’ll dissolve any minute.

And then she’ll leave again.

And so, Catra keeps her distance. Adora’s noticed, because even if Catra teases her for her lack of observation skills, it’d be pretty hard not to. But every time she looks like she might bring it up, Catra's gone before she can. Every time, Adora looks like a kicked puppy, hurt and confusion flashing across her features, but Catra can’t help it. Any moment now, the veil will lift, and Adora’ll be gone again.

But days pass, and that moment never comes. Adora recovers and gets back to training –not necessarily in that order–, and basically acts like nothing has changed. And of course she does; nothing *has*, as far as she’s concerned. It’s just another day in the Horde, another day working towards what they’ve worked for all their lives.

There’s no dramatic moment where Shadow Weaver’s spell suddenly fails; no morning where she wakes up and stares at Catra with that same, hard look she had at Salineas. There's no sudden princess invasion from her new best friends to get her back, either –and Catra finds herself thinking even less of them than she already did for that one, before she manages to suppress the thought.

And even in the moments when it feels like everything is about to shatter, like there’s no way the smoke won’t clear and reveal the

mirrors, it holds.

One of those moments comes in Force Captain orientation –"there's a Force Captain orientation?" Adora asks, eyes wide with panic at the idea of having missed some classes–, when the sergeant starts talking about reviewing the records of a previous invasion. Catra instantly freezes, muscles locking into place as her mind battles *fight or flight*.

This is it. Adora is going to see what the Horde does, actually *see* it, and the spell is going to break. Shadow Weaver might think she has everything under control, but she hasn't seen it like Catra has. She hasn't seen the way Adora looked at Thaymor, the panic and the hurt in her eyes. The way she cared about these people, even though she'd never even met them.

But the screen starts showing footage, of tanks descending on a village, of buildings set on fire, of green weapon blasts and Adora doesn't blink. She watches, like it's any other lesson. Takes notes. Asks a couple of questions at the end.

The class can't last more than hour, and yet it feels like a year to Catra. She doesn't take in anything, too busy cataloguing the slightest shift, the smallest twitch that might mean Adora's about to remember. Or hell, that she's just going to switch sides all over again –seeing all this did the trick once, after all. There's no reason why it wouldn't again.

Except there is a reason, and that reason is apparently whatever Shadow Weaver did to Adora. The attack gets deconstructed, analyzed, and critiqued, and Adora doesn't so much as frown once.

Eventually, the class ends; people stand up and gather their things to leave the room, but Catra stays rooted to the spot, disbelief freezing her into place.

By the time Adora realizes, they're the only ones left in the room. She stops at the door, frowning as she looks over her shoulder.

“Catra? You coming?”

“You’re okay with this?”

The words are insane –the opposite of what Shadow Weaver’s told her to do. Pushing is the last thing she should be doing. But she can’t help it –the contrast between Adora’s calm, studious demeanor and the desperation that was etched on her face at Thaymor is giving her freaking *whiplash*.

Adora frowns, not understanding. “Okay with… What?”

She should brush it off. Instead, she stands and gestures towards the now switched off screen. “All of it. Any of it. What the Horde did to that village?”

Adora blinks. Looks at the screen like the images are still there, then back at Catra, that frown in the middle of her forehead showing that the words aren’t making sense to her. “The rebel outpost, you mean?”

Catra needs to shut up. What is she even *doing*? She should be happy; if anything, this proves that Adora’s here to stay, that she’s not going to change her mind. So why is she pushing her luck like this? “It’s a village full of civilians.”

Adora just shrugs. “Sure, if you want. Civilian rebels.” Catra just gapes at her, and her confusion starts to turn into something closer to concern. “Catra, are you okay? You’ve been acting kind of weird these past few–“

“I’m not acting weird,” she says immediately which, of course, makes it very clear that she’s been acting weird.

Adora sighs, and Catra expects her to walk away. Instead, she makes her way over, hesitating for a second before setting her hands on Catra’s shoulders. It’s the closest they’ve been physically since Adora’s come back, and it makes Catra’s mouth run a bit dry. “Catra… You know you can talk to me, right? If something’s wrong?”

"What makes you think anything's wrong?" It comes out defensive, but she doesn't shrug out of Adora's grip either.

Adora lifts one eyebrow. "Apart from literally everything, you mean?" Catra rolls her eyes and starts a step back, but Adora reaffirms her hold. "It's just… You act strange, and now you're, what, questioning what we're doing? Doesn't sound like you."

"I'm just surprised, I guess. That you're–fine with this." She needs to be *quiet*.

The confused frown makes a comeback. "Why wouldn't I be? Catra, it's what we've been working for our whole lives. Why would I suddenly not be okay with it?"

I don't know, why were you?

Before she can voice the thought and ruin this completely, Adora's gaze grows a little vacant, and she continues speaking. "I mean… Of course, if there was another way… I mean, if it didn't have to be like this, then it'd– it'd be better if we didn't have to…" She winces, for the shortest of seconds, and then when she speaks again, it's firmer. "But this is the way things are. The rebels are a threat. I'd know. What we do, we do for the good of Etheria."

On that, she drops her hands and smiles. "Now come on. We need to go, or we'll be late."

Catra follows without a word as they head out, mind reeling. Adora isn't going to change her mind. She's here to stay, there's no doubt anymore. It should fix things –should finally uncoil that twist that's been making it hard to breathe right for days.

But it doesn't –the feeling remains, sharp and suffocating. Because, yeah, Adora is staying.

But the words that confirmed that? Catra's heard them all her life. Enough times, in fact, that there is absolutely no doubt in her mind.

They were Shadow Weaver’s words, in Adora’s mouth.

*

Adora’s been having nightmares.

It’s impossible not to notice. Well, the others haven't noticed, probably, because Adora’s long learned to be quiet with that sort of thing –displays of weakness aren’t exactly an advantage while growing up in the Horde; why give anyone free ammunition against you?–, but Catra’s too attuned to her not to know. That’s what 17 years of sleeping near someone will do to you.

And so, whenever Adora’s been jolting awake with a suppressed gasp, Catra’s been waking up too, same as she always has.

Unlike how she always has however, instead of tossing her a word, or wrapping her tail around the girl’s ankle, she’s been gritting her teeth and burying her face into her pillow.

That first night after she came back, Adora had been asleep when Catra had crawled into bed, so she’d not immediately reacted to the fact that she’d gone to her own bunk instead of her usual spot at the foot of Adora’s bed. She’d just looked a bit confused in the morning. The following nights, however, well… The hurt, confused look in the bright blue eyes had almost been enough to get Catra to relent and pretend everything was fine.

Almost.

But she hadn’t wanted to take the risk. Getting used to this, only to lose it again? Yeah, no thanks.

But even now that she’s reasonably convinced Adora’s not about to bail again, she’s still refusing to sleep anywhere that’s not her

own bunk. Just like she’s refusing to help Adora out with her nightmares, against every instinct she has.

The worst part is that she's not even really sure *why* she's doing it.

This time, Catra’s awake before Adora, and it’s not even because of the noise. Some of her nightmares are the tossing and turning kind, the tangling of bedsheets and thumps of Adora’s fists against the mattress snapping her out of sleep, but it’s not one of those tonight. Instead, it’s one where she goes completely still – tense, muscles locked, breath shallow. They’re the worst ones, Catra knows from long years of experience, and she’s gotten used to waking up to the sudden silence, the stillness where Adora’s peaceful breathing should be.

It's one of the many reasons why sleeping had been tricky, after she left.

Stubbornly, she keeps her eyes shut, hoping against hope she’ll manage to fall back asleep before Adora wakes up.

The silence below her is suddenly broken by one short, gasping inhale, which quickly trails off into a choked sob.

Catra squeezes her eyes shut tighter, and digs her claws into the flimsy mattress.

She doesn’t need to see it to know what’s happening. Adora’s lying still, eyes wide, unblinking, staring at the underside of Catra’s mattress. Her fists are clenched, nails digging into her palms, maybe even hard enough to draw blood, if the dream was bad enough. All her efforts are channeled into keeping her breathing quiet, into making sure no one hears, be it the people sleeping around them or whatever lurked in her dreams. And if no one intervenes, she’s going to stay like that a while.

Catra grits her teeth, and waits. She has a feeling tonight’s going to be long, that this was a particularly bad one. She just hopes it’s not as bad as she thinks, because if it is–

The sheets rustle, and Catra knows what's coming.

"Catra?"

It's barely a whisper –nothing anyone would hear. Anyone but Catra, which Adora knows, because that's how it's always been.

More rustling, as Adora stands, and when the whisper comes again, it's from higher up, spoken between the horizontal metal bars that line the edge of the top bunk. "Catra."

She doesn't want to respond, but the edge of desperation flicks on an instinct that's been forged over too many years to be ignored –the same way she's learned to dodge an oncoming quarterstaff, or jump out of the way of a laser blast, she's learned to react to that tone coming from Adora.

She's pretty sure that even if Adora had been gone for years instead of weeks, she still wouldn't be able to suppress it.

She lifts her head from her pillow, and for a second almost wishes her vision wasn't as good as it is. If it was just a little bit worse, then maybe she wouldn't have to see the trembling of her mouth, pressed into a flat, tight line, or the tears still leaking at the corner of her eye.

Catra doesn't say anything, knows her eyes glowing faintly are enough to tell Adora she's listening.

For a moment, Adora just stands there, staring at her, staring *through* her, until she manages to choke out: "Please?"

Catra knows what she's asking, and part of her wants to say no, so, *so* badly. Turn her back on Adora. Ignore her entirely.

Instead, she sits up with a sigh, pushes off her sheets, and goes over the railing, landing noiselessly on her feet next to the other girl. "Come on," she mumbles, and leads the way out of the barracks, sensing more than hearing Adora trailing after her.

Most of the time, after a nightmare, Adora would just fall back asleep. Sometimes it'd take a while. Sometimes it'd take a few whispered words between the two of them, a reminder that this was real, that whatever her mind had come up with wasn't.

But sometimes, that wasn't enough. And so, sometimes, they did this.

The halls are deserted, and they've done this enough time to know how to avoid any patrols. They sneak their way from shadow to shadow, passing behind crates and metal piping, and soon enough, Catra pushes the door to one of the small sparring rooms crammed at the back of the training zone.

Adora has, after all, always been a *punch your feelings out* kind of guy. When everything else failed, this usually did the trick, draining her enough to let her get back to sleep. They'd started when they were ten.

Already, Adora's breathing better. She winces against the flood of white light when Catra flips the light switch, but her shoulders relax a fraction as she takes in the familiar bare space. She runs her hands over her face, smoothes out her ponytail, and steps onto the thin mat after Catra. For one second, they stand still, taking each other in.

And then Catra pounces.

She goes flying forward, aiming a precise hit towards Adora's jaw. She's blocked easily, the other girl bringing an arm up and deflecting. Adora's leg shoots out to swipe Catra's from underneath her, but she sees the move coming from a mile away and jumps out of reach. She's about to send a kick flying in retaliation when Adora suddenly charges at her, forcing her to twist out of the way to avoid getting pinned down.

Adora rains down hit after hit towards Catra, but they're easily avoided –she's still half asleep, still half stuck in her nightmare, and her moves aren't as coordinated and precise as they would

usually be. But then again, landing hits isn't the point; it's not like at Salineas.

Unfortunately, that's something Catra's still fuzzy mind is having a hard time remembering. She's not supposed to land too many hits either; her attacks are mostly about giving Adora something to fight back against. But she keeps catching herself right before doing actual damage –sharp claws extended further than she'd meant, hits flying through clumsy defenses more precisely than they should.

They've spent their whole lives fighting together, with only a two-week blip where they fought against each other, and yet, Catra realizes with a cold twist in her lungs, it is *so* easy to fight against Adora.

When Adora's blows start growing clumsy enough that she looks like she's more likely to hurt herself than anything else, Catra ends it. Almost delicately, she ducks out of the way of a punch, grabs Adora's shoulder, and pulls, while bringing one of her legs behind the girl's knees. Adora goes down, her back crashing into the thin mat, and Catra brings one knee over her thigh, one arm across her shoulders to keep her down. "Better?"

Adora's face is flushed, her breathing ragged, but she's lost a bit of the haunted look. She nods. "Yeah." Her head drops back against the mat with a dull thud. "Yeah. Thank you."

Catra only nods, stepping off and rising to her feet, before offering a hand to Adora, who takes it to stand. She does look better, most of the tension having left her. Unfortunately, it seems to have made its way to Catra instead. The fight's left her restless, and she steps back, rocking back on her heels, and forward to the balls of her feet. She can already tell she's not going to sleep again tonight, but still, she tilts her head towards the door. "We should go before the next patrol–"

"Did I do something wrong?"

Shit.

The restlessness increases tenfold. "What are you–"

"Cause you've been avoiding me, like, a lot, and I keep racking my brain trying to figure out what I did wrong and I really can't place it and now I'm just–"

"You didn't do anything wrong," Catra interrupts, the lie bitter on her tongue. But it's not like she can call out Adora on something she doesn't even *remember* doing.

Adora lets out a little laugh, but it's nervous, not amused. "So, what, you're just giving me the cold shoulder for no reason?"

"I'm not giving you–"

"Catra." The look on her face is *come on*, and *I might not be the smartest person that's ever lived but I'm not that stupid*, and *don't lie to me*, and *stars* does Catra hate how easy it is to read her right now –or maybe she just hates how it should be just as easy for Adora to read her back and yet she can't seem to.

She scrubs her hands against her face, the lack of sleep suddenly dropping on her like lead. "Look," she starts, with absolutely no idea where she's going, "it's not–"

"Is this about Thaymor?"

Catra's hands and heart both drop. "What?"

Adora shuffles on her feet, awkward. "Well, it's the only thing there is, isn't there? You're mad at me about Thaymor."

Catra can barely hear her over the blood rushing in her ears. "You remember Thaymor?"

She scoffs, a bit of ease returning in her tone. "I told you, I wasn't *that* out of it."

“What do you remember?”

“Well.” More shuffling, shifting from one foot to the other. “You, rescuing me. Obviously.”

Oh. Of course. Filling in the gaps –Adora’s brain had used real things and twisted them into a version that fit what Shadow Weaver had convinced it to be the truth. And so now, instead of what it actually was –aka the biggest fucking mess Catra had ever seen–, the invasion of Thaymor is now where the Horde rescued Adora. It’s where Catra succeeded.

Where Adora came home.

Something bitter and scalding floods Catra, and she stands up straighter. “What else?”

“Huh?”

“What else do you remember, about Thaymor?”

“Oh.” She takes a second to think about it, gaze growing a little vacant. “Uh. Well. I *was* kinda out of it, I guess, but–“ She catches Catra staring at her, and now she’s the one standing up straighter, chin jutting out a bit. “Fighting. There was fighting.”

Catra cocks an eyebrow. “Wow, so descriptive. It’s like I’m there all over again,” she drawls, sarcasm masking over the way her heart is pounding in her chest.

Adora rolls her eyes and continues. “Tanks. Bots. *Lots* of them. The rebels never saw you coming.”

Catra starts pacing. Slow, leisurely, and, she knows, infuriating, as she makes her way closer to Adora, in circles that get narrower on each pass. She hums noncommittally and Adora clenches her fists, her awkwardness melting into real annoyance.

“There were princesses there,” she says, brow furrowing –in frustration or concentration, Catra can’t really tell.

“Oh, really? What kind of princesses?” There’s playing with fire, and then there’s whatever the hell she’s doing right now. But this is proof; the memories are still within reach, and if they come back, then Adora will leave again. And if that’s going to happen, well– better now, at Catra’s hand. She’s not going to sit around and wait for it to happen on its own.

But the question seems to stump Adora. “I–“ She shakes her head, lost. “I don’t– Just princesses, that’s all I–“

“Crystal clear recollections, I see." Her voice is way too hard for this to just be dumb teasing, and Adora notices.

“Why does it even matter?”

She manages a shrug that could maybe pass as casual –not with Adora though. “It doesn’t.”

“It clearly does! Ugh, Catra, I just–“ She digs her fists into her eyes for a moment, the angry energy leaving her in one, quick breath. Her shoulders drop, and when her hands fall away, she looks so scared that Catra feels her own anger leave her, too. “*What* is going on?”

She looks away, uncomfortable. “Nothing’s going on.”

Adora blows out a long breath. “Look, it’s just– Everything’s been weird, since I got back, okay? *Don’t* tell me it hasn’t been,” she says quickly when Catra opens her mouth to do just that. “You’re avoiding me, and, I don’t know, even the others, it’s– different.”

“You’re a Force Captain now,” Catra interjects, hoping the nervous energy buzzing through her isn't too obvious. “It can’t be the same.”

But Adora only shakes her head. “It’s not that. And then– And then those dreams, it’s just…”

It’s like time freezes for a moment. “What dreams?” she asks, against her better judgement.

Adora hesitates. “It’s stupid.”

“So stupid it’s got us both in a sparring room in the middle of the night. What dreams?”

The other girl shakes her head, sending tendrils of hair that have escaped her ponytail drifting over her face, but eventually she relents. “It’s like… It’s nothing clear, it’s all… muddled. But– there’s something I have to do, and it’s so, so important, but I can never remember it.”

“Figures you’d dream about deadlines.”

“But to do it,” Adora continues, looking like she hasn’t even heard Catra’s interruption, “I have to do something else. I have to– go somewhere.” All the good the fight did is long gone; she looks just as haunted as she did when they first walked in here, or maybe even worse. “And… you’re there.”

Catra jumps, not having expected the address. “I’m where?”

“Here. The place–“ Her voice trails off, and she swallows hard, looking down at the floor. “The place I have to leave. And I *have* to go, but I don’t want to, because you’re still there, but it’s like… I try everything, to stay with you, and I try to get you to come with me, but it always ends the same way.”

Catra knows how it ends. “How does it end?” she asks anyway.

Adora looks back up at her, eyes wide and lost. “I leave,” she says simply. “And you watch me. And I think… I think you might hate me.”

Catra’s pretty sure she’s stopped breathing a full minute ago. It takes her another to get herself together enough that she’s sure her neutral mask won’t drop. “You’re right.”

Adora startles, mouth dropping into an o. “What?”

“You’re right. That is stupid.” Adora lets out an incredulous huff of laughter, and Catra shakes her head, distantly surprised that she can still stand there when the ground has apparently vanished under her feet. Stars, figures that Shadow Weaver would be *shit* at this memory wipe thing. “Look,” she says, “you’re here. I’m here. No one’s leaving anyone. And you might not be the smartest person around–“

“*Hey*–“

“–but I don’t hate you.”

But she doesn’t relax, hands twisting together nervously, clearly unconvinced. “Okay.”

Catra makes a snap decision. Yes, the past few days have been weird. Yes, clearly, Shadow Weaver fucked up somewhere, and Adora still dreams about the memories that were supposedly removed. Yes, she can’t be sure what’s going to happen.

But it’s *Adora*, and more than that, it’s an upset Adora, and Catra can fix that. They can figure out the rest later. Together.

And so, she pushes down the last remaining doubts, and steps forward until she can put her hands on Adora’s upper arms. “Hey,” she says, meeting the girl’s gaze head on –something she’s been carefully avoiding doing over the last few days. “I promise, okay?”

And that, more than all the sparring, does the trick: the tension drains out of Adora as she breathes out, long and slow. “Okay,” she says with a small smile. “Okay.”

And Catra breathes better, too. She wasn’t lying, she realizes, and the relief that brings almost makes her knees buckle.
She *doesn’t* hate Adora. She’s pissed off, and unsettled, and this is still a really weird situation, but she doesn’t hate Adora.

Adora's smile becomes softer, and she gently knocks her arm into Catra's. "And you know I'm never going to leave you, right? I promise."

Even a few minutes ago, the words would have been a slap in the face –instead, they're like a burst of fresh air, because Catra *believes* them. "Yeah," she says, and it's sincere. "I know."

She doesn't hate Adora, and Adora doesn't want to leave her. Last time was… a blip. A freak accident. It's never going to happen again.

She grins, feeling lighter than she has in days. "Even if you spend major battles passed out."

Adora laughs at that, shaking off Catra's grip and starting towards the door, Catra in tow. "I wasn't out for the whole thing, you ass."

Catra only hums, and Adora lets out a groan of annoyance, but it's amused now, too. "I wasn't!"

"Of course."

"If I was out for the whole thing, how could I remember your stupid boat?"

The laughter dies on Catra's lips as the floor seemingly vanishes under her feet for the second time that evening. "What?"

Adora's kept walking, a triumphant tilt to her grin, even as Catra's stopped in place. "See? I notice stuff."

The sparring room is so, so cold, suddenly. "There's no sea in Thaymor, Adora."

She finally stops walking. When she spins on her heel, she's frowning confusedly, a ghost of her smile still on her face. "What? No, it's–"

"No sea. No river either." She can taste metal.

"No, no, but–" She smiles –hollow, fake. When she speaks again, it's almost frantic. "No, but I remember… There was a boat, I remember. A boat, and, and, and a door and–"

But whatever Adora is about to say is lost when she suddenly collapses to her knees with a cry of pain. The sound, together with the dark red glow that suddenly suffuses her skin, snaps Catra out of her shock, and she bolts to Adora's side reflexively. "Adora!"

The light recedes as quickly as it came, leaving her friend hunched over, one hand braced against the floor for support, one hand grasping at her temple. "I'm fine," she gasps out, eyes still screwed shut. "I'm fine, it'll be over in a minute, it's–"

Catra's blood ices over, even as she puts one hand on the girl's shoulder for support. "This has happened before?"

Adora's wince is answer enough. "Not a lot," she tries to amend, features slowly relaxing. She drops her hand, and eases her eyes open.

"But it's happened before."

"Not rea–" She trails off when she sees Catra's face. "A few times. Kind of. Maybe. But it's fine! Seriously. It's probably just– leftover stuff from the princesses. It'll be gone in no time, nothing to worry about."

Adora continues her litany, clearly aiming for reassuring, even as she struggles to her feet, but Catra's stopped listening.

She'd known, deep down, of course, that this is all Shadow Weaver's work. It's the reason they got Adora back, after all.

But it's like it didn't really sink in just how much of this is Shadow Weaver. Because maybe, just maybe, a stupid, *childish* part of Catra hoped that it wasn't just that; that Shadow Weaver had given the impulse, but that the rest had been Adora. Adora choosing to fight for the Horde. Adora choosing to stay.

Adora choosing her.

But no matter how hard she tries to ignore the signs, she can't will them out of existence. The red light, and the dazed looks, and the smiles while she stares at destroyed villages are reminders enough; it's not just an impulse, or a one time thing. It's probably not just a few days' worth of memories erased, either –whatever Shadow Weaver's done, it reaches further than that, Catra's sure of it. Whatever it is, she's still doing it, still influencing Adora now.

No, no matter what Adora says, no matter what she *thinks*… Right now? Everything is Shadow Weaver's work. When she talks about their future in the Horde –Shadow Weaver. When she says the words they've been saying to each other since they were kids – Shadow Weaver. When she talks about never leaving Catra – *Shadow fucking Weaver*.

Maybe it shouldn't be as surprising as it is; after all, the woman's always been in control of every aspect of Catra's life. But somehow, it is. Maybe because Catra never expected to see it happen to Adora. Adora, who was always so perfect, who was always the favorite... Why would Shadow Weaver bother to control her every move so directly when everything Adora did was perfect in her eyes anyway?

But regardless of why, the idea that *she's* the one making Adora say these things, that she's controlling everything about her down to her thoughts… It's making Catra feel sick.

Sure, maybe the spell will hold, and maybe Adora will stay. Maybe she won't ever leave Catra again, won't ever try.

But if Shadow Weaver's the reason she's staying, Catra realizes, her chest cold and hollow, then–

Then she'd rather Adora left.

And so, Catra begins planning.

Chapter End Notes

i know that technically force captains have individual bedrooms, but i'm making an Artistic DecisionTM for the sake of drama, so don't come for me kdfjhg

also! i wanted to give a big thank you to everyone who left kudos and/or commented on chap 1! yall really brightened my week 💕

Thanks for reading!

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora takes a while to wake up.

Then again, Catra *did* go kinda heavy on the tasering

In her defense, she really couldn't risk Adora waking up until they were far out of the Fright Zone. Leaving undetected was enough of a challenge –it would have been much, *much* harder with the Horde's poster child struggling the whole way. And Catra doesn't even want to think about the kind of punishment that would've gone with getting caught; not that her defecting would have been that much of a blow, but taking Adora with her? Yeah, she's pretty sure Shadow Weaver would not have been a fan –which is only part of why she did it at all.

The skiff's already covered most of the ground between the Fright Zone and the edge of the Whispering Woods by the time Adora starts stirring at the back. Catra keeps her gaze focused on the deserted expanse ahead, lit only by the low moons and the slowly lightening sky. She cuffed Adora tight, anyway.

"Ugh, what's– Catra?"

She clenches her hands around the skiff's tiller, sending the ship smoothly rising over a rocky outcrop.

"Catra, what's–" She trails off, and when she speaks again, the panic's starting to break through the confusion. "Wait, am I cuffed?" The panic becomes *offense*. "Hey, hang on, did you *taser* me? Catra, what's–"

Her voice is replaced by the sound of vague struggling, presumably as she tests out the restraints and tries to break out of them. Catra still doesn't look back –she knows this conversation

will have to happen, most likely pretty soon, but she'd really like it if they were closer to the woods and, mostly, farther from the Fright Zone.

Plus, she also tied Adora's ankles together, so she's not too worried about keeping an eye on her.

That, as it turns out, ends up being her second mistake.

The first being: not going way, *way* heavier on the tasering.

One second of silence is the only warning she gets; one moment, she's standing upright, staring ahead, and the next, Adora's tackled her to the metal floor. She crashes, hitting her chin on the flooring in a way that sends stars dancing in front of her eyes and pain radiating down her jaw. Adora's weight on top of her back is crushing, and the breath rushes out of her in a painful gasp, the parcel strapped to her back digging painfully between her shoulder blades.

"What are you doing?" Adora demands, trying to keep Catra pinned in place –the fact that she's succeeding despite her hands apparently still very much being tied behind her back would be impressive if it wasn't so goddamn annoying.

Catra sends an elbow jutting back, catching Adora in the stomach. The girl lets out an *oof*, but doesn't let off. "What does it look like?" she grits out. "We're going to the Woods."

Before Adora can come up with a response, Catra finds purchase against the slippery metal. Using her new found leverage, she twists around, enough to destabilize Adora and finally dislodge her. With no way to right herself, she crashes to the floor, as Catra stands in one fluid, rapid motion.

Her eyes are wide, and still a bit dazed as she responds. "*What*? Why?"

Catra rubs a hand against her aching jaw –that is *so* going to bruise–, using the other one to reach for the steering lever behind

her back and ensure they've not been knocked off course. It'd be better if she could *look* where they're going, but it'd mean turning her back on Adora, and she's not making that particular mistake twice. "Berry picking," she says flippantly. "Heard it's the right season for it."

Adora's managed, stars know how, to wriggle herself into a mostly upright position, back against the side of the skiff. "Catra–"

Catra readjusts the bag strapped to her back. "Look, it's kinda a long story, and if you don't mind, it'd *really* be better if we didn't get into it right now–"

"Catra–"

"–also *no*, you're probably not going to be a fan, but–"

"*Catra*!"

It finally clicks that Adora's wide blue eyes aren't fixed on her but very much *behind* her. She spins on her heel, and barely has the time to clock the massive rocky spear the skiff is about to splatter against before Adora lunges at her for the second time.

This time, they both crash into the lever, sending the skiff almost flipping over as it violently lurches, trying to keep up with the command. Up becomes down becomes nothing but a distant memory as the ship spins through the air, and it's all Catra can do to cling on to the lever, trying to right it again –something that's made considerably harder by the way Adora's leaning against it from the other side.

It's doomed from the start, and it becomes even worse when they make it through the edge of the woods. By some kind of miracle, they manage to avoid crashing into the first tree they see, but it's not long until the inevitable happens: after one particularly nausea-inducing looping, the nose of the skiff slams into a thick, low branch, sending the two of them flying overboard.

There’s no time to brace herself before the grassy ground of the Whispering Woods comes to meet her head on.

Head spinning, body aching, and mouth full of grass, Catra takes a second to wonder how she ended up here. Really, couldn’t she have befriended literally *any* other cadet as a kid? It *had* to be that one?

Once her head clears and the ground stops spinning under her, she sits up, only to consider just flopping right back down when her gaze lands on the skiff –or what’s left of it which, really, isn’t much. Their transport is now mostly smoking, scrunched up scrap metal, bunched up around the trunk of a particularly imposing tree.

She sighs. She hoped to make it a bit further into the woods before they’d have to start walking but, well, when does anything go according to what she hoped anyway?

A scan of the rest of the clearing reveals a tangled heap of red and white lying in the grass a few feet away. Vague worry squeezes Catra’s throat as she limps her way over, but that promptly melts back into *are you fucking kidding me*, when a touch to Adora’s shoulder sends her twisting around and headbutting Catra right under the jaw –precisely where she hit the flooring earlier.

The waves of pain send a few spots dancing in her vision, but she recovers enough to avoid Adora’s next assault –a double legged kick from the ground, which makes sense considering her ankles are still tied together. “*Adora*!”

But the girl is *determined*; she manages to wriggle herself into a kneeling position, and from there, jumps to her feet, only wobbling a little. And from *there*, she lunges for Catra again.

Adora’s an excellent fighter, but there’s only so much even she can do with her wrists and ankles bound, which means that Catra has her backed up against the nearest tree in a few seconds, one arm

across her collarbones to keep her still. "Adora, *stop*!" she tries again. Her hand is *itching* to reach for the stun baton that's still strapped to her hip but she'd really like not to have to drag an unconscious Adora through the Whispering Woods.

Thankfully, it doesn't come to that. Adora stops struggling, at least a little, but she's still pissed when she speaks: "Catra, *why* are we here? The rebels could find us any minute."

"Well, I sure hope so." The words are met with baffled silence, and she scrubs the heel of her free hand into her forehead, dislodging a bit of dirt from their rough landing. "Okay, fine, I'll explain." She eyes Adora for a second. "Can I let go of you *without* you going all berserk on me again?"

Adora ignores her. "*Why* would you want the rebels to find us? What, got a sudden burning desire to get yourself kidnapped and held hostage for two weeks? I promise, it's not as cool as it sounds, and honestly, it doesn't even sound *that* cool in the first place."

"That's not what happened."

Silence.

"What?"

She decides to risk it and takes a step back, giving Adora space, and breathing a sigh of relief when her friend doesn't immediately launch into another attack. "You didn't get kidnapped. Well, you *did*, I guess, but you weren't held hostage."

"What are you *talking* about? Of course I was."

"Nope."

The incredulity on her face would probably be funny in literally any other circumstances. "I'm the one who was actually *there*? Hello?"

As it is, however, it mostly means that this is going to be a long conversation.

Except that suddenly, Adora's eyes go wide with recognition. Something thuds in Catra's chest. "Oh."

Well, that was easier than she thought it'd be. She clenches her fists to stop herself from twisting her hands together, as Adora's expression fills with horror.

"Oh no, Catra, I'm—" And suddenly Catra can't bear to hear it. She can't look at her, even, and she turns her head towards the woods, not really seeing them.

"Yeah, save it." She's heard the speech at Thaymor –she's not interested in hearing it again. It's not like this changes anything, after all. She opens her mouth, ready to take her leave, but Adora speaks again.

"They got to you."

Huh?

When Catra turns back towards her, Adora looks close to tears which, what the *fuck*. "The rebels. They got you too, and they messed with your head and— This is all my fault, if you hadn't come to get me at Thaymor they never could have hurt you, I'm so—"

Her words aren't computing. "Wait, hang on, back up. What?"

But Adora's forehead has that crease that means the pieces of the puzzle have clicked in her head and that they're not about to move again –never mind that they apparently clicked on fucking *backwards*. She nods determinedly. "Catra, I swear to you, whatever they've done to you, we'll reverse it. Shadow Weaver has to know how princess magic works, and she can fix it for sure."

Oh *no*. “Adora, what the hell are you talking about?” she asks, even though she has the sinking feeling she already knows.

At least the girl doesn’t look pissed off anymore, just concerned. “Catra, it’s okay. I know this is going to sound weird, but I think some of the princesses used their magic on you and messed with your head. Oh, *that’s* why you’ve been so off these past few days!” She looks like she’d smack herself on the forehead if her hands weren’t tied behind her back. “I should have noticed, I should have done something, I’m so sorry.”

For a second, Catra just stands there silently and ponders the concept of irony. And then she blows out a long, long breath. “I’m not under a spell.”

Adora’s face is so transparent that she doesn’t even need to say *that’s exactly what you would say if you were under a spell* for Catra to hear it.

Stars, today is already *way* too long, and the sun hasn’t even finished rising yet. “I’m not under a spell,” she repeats, as calmly as she can, “you are.”

Adora’s eyebrows rise almost all the way to her hairline. “That’s– what?”

She’s about to start explaining when she remembers that that explaining is plan B. She reaches behind her, and shrugs off the bag that’s been digging into her shoulder all night. With one sharp motion, she unzips it, reaches inside, and tosses the contents onto the ground at Adora’s feet.

The sword glitters in the light of the rising dawn, looking deceptively harmless.

It wasn’t easy getting it, but it wasn’t as hard as it could have been, either. Catra has in-depth, firsthand experience of Shadow Weaver taking things that matter to her away, after all. Getting the sword had just been a matter of picking the right moment to

sneak into the small room next to the Garnet Chamber. It wasn't even warded, which had made Catra roll her eyes.

Honestly, she'd been tempted to leave the sword there altogether –getting it was a big risk, after all, and it's not like she missed Adora's glowy persona– but, well. Plan A kinda relied on it.

Plan A being, let Adora interact with the sword and hope that it would do its magic thing and undo Shadow Weaver's work.

Considering the way Adora's staring blankly at it, said plan doesn't seem to be shaping up to be a massive success.

"What's that?" she asks eventually.

Catra feels one corner of her mouth quirking up without being able to do a thing about it. "It's a sword."

"Well, *obviously* it's a sword, *thanks*, I meant–"

"Yeah, I know what you meant." The smile melts away as her amusement at seeing Adora all huffy is replaced by something much colder. She juts her chin out towards the sword in brief acknowledgement. "It's *your* sword."

The blankness doesn't lift. "My sword," Adora repeats.

Catra briefly hesitates. Last time, Adora started getting her weird vision things only once she'd touched the sword directly, so it'd make sense that she'd need to actually grab it for this to work.

On the other hand, she's *really* not super keen on giving Adora access to any kind of weapon, right now. There'd be a very special kind of irony in Adora using her own magic sword to bring the two of them back to the Fright Zone.

She sighs. Right. Plan B it is.

Catra does her best to summarize the princess thing –something that's made harder by the fact that she doesn't strictly know how

any of it works. All she has to go on is what she saw at Thaymor and Salineas, after all. It's not like Adora gave her a rundown of how the whole tiara thing came about.

As she talks, Adora's expression changes. Soon enough, she doesn't seem to be so much concerned as to just think that Catra's simply gone completely batshit.

Then again, Catra can't really blame her. There's just no easy way to make "you occasionally turn into an eight-foot tall, tiara-wearing lady when you use a sword and yell something about a skull" sound sane.

Once Catra's done, the silence holds for a bit. Adora's the one to break it, brow furrowed –which, to her credit, means she's at least trying to process what Catra's saying, instead of just dismissing her out of hand. Catra's pretty sure that if their situation were reversed, she would not have done Adora the same courtesy.

"So this is a magic sword," Adora summarizes, slowly.

"Yep."

"That only I can use."

"Yeah."

"And when I do, I– get taller?"

"That's right."

"And… my hair gets shiny?"

"Obnoxiously so, yes."

Adora blinks. "Right."

Yeah. Their situations *aren't* reversed, and it still sounds ridiculous to Catra.

"And I somehow just… forgot about that," Adora concludes, badly concealing her disbelief.

The cold twist that's been living in Catra's stomach for the better part of two weeks makes itself known again. "That would be where the spell part comes into play."

"The rebels wiped my memory of the sword?" She tilts her head. "I mean, I guess it'd make sense, but why wouldn't–"

"Not the rebels. Shadow Weaver."

Adora's eyebrows rise again, all traces of confusion gone, replaced by flat disbelief. "Shadow Weaver?" Catra only nods tersely, and Adora's expression softens a little at the edges. It makes her look younger. It makes Catra *feel* younger, like she's six years old and hiding somewhere and Adora's the only one who knows where to find her.

It makes Catra want to *scream*.

"Catra… You know Shadow Weaver can't actually do that, right? It's just a rumor. She can't… erase memories, or whatever. I'm not saying she doesn't want us to think that, or that she wouldn't do it if she could, but she can't."

Yeah –Catra misses when she thought that, too. She lets out a short, sharp bark of laughter, and it's anything but humorous. "She can. She really, *really* can."

Adora leans back against the tree trunk with a sigh. "Okay, fine, let's assume she can. But even if she could, don't you see that it doesn't make sense? Why would she wipe my memory of *that*?" She shakes her head. "Look, I'm good in a fight, but I'm pretty sure I'd be even *better* if I was eight feet tall and had a… magic sword, or whatever." She shrugs. "It'd be an asset, for the Horde, so she'd have no reason to take away the memory. Which, for the record, she can't do anyway."

Right, then. Moment of truth. “The sword isn’t the problem,” Catra says slowly. “It’s not what Shadow Weaver– Well, it *is*, but…” The words are tangling together, refusing to come out, and she lets out a noise of frustration before just *saying it*. “You defected.”

“I wouldn’t do that.” The response is immediate, automatic even. Like the possibility isn’t even on the table, like there *isn’t* even a table for it to be on.

Catra knows better. “You did.”

“Why *would* I?”

“You had your reasons.”

“*Which are*?”

Catra just shakes her head. She’s certain there’s no point getting into it, if what she saw in Force Captain orientation is any indication. “Shadow Weaver’s made it so they won’t mean anything to you, right now.”

Adora lets out a groan of frustration and her head drops backwards briefly, her eyes closing. “Fine. Whatever. I leave the Horde because of unknown, mysterious reasons. I turn into a glowy tiara-wearing, sword-wielding person. Sure. Let’s pretend any of that makes sense.” She straightens up, and looks Catra in the eye. “It still doesn’t work. Shadow Weaver wouldn’t–”

“What, play creepy mind games?” The fact that Adora’s *defending* her, even if it’s a mind-controlled Adora, is making her taste blood. “Wake *up*, Adora.”

“–make a *mistake*,” Adora finishes instead, tone hard. “Shadow Weaver’s *smart*. If we defected, and she managed to get us back, then why the *hell* would she let you keep your memories and only take mine? It’s just plain stupid, you could take me back at any time! Which, by the way, is apparently exactly what you’re doing right now. So, *no*, it doesn’t make–”

But all of a sudden, Adora's voice sounds like it's coming from very, *very* far away, as something Catra can't quite name rushes through her. "You," she says eventually, interrupting her mid-sentence.

Adora stutters to a stop, clearly thrown. "Me?"

"*You* defected. Not me."

It's like the woods around them grow silent at the tension. Or maybe Catra's too focused to hear the noises.

Adora mostly just looks confused. "But– where were you, then?"

The question is completely, utterly genuine, and it makes Catra *itch* to claw something open. Possibly something like Adora herself. "Where was– The Fright Zone? Obviously? Where *else* would I be?"

"But–" Adora's arms strain against the cuffs, but it's not an aggressive gesture –more like she's forgotten she's wearing them. "But that's ridiculous, I mean, if I'd left, then I'd have gone back for you, I would've *explained*, I–"

The feeling is getting stronger, rolling in hot, suffocating waves. "You did."

"I did what?"

For some reason, the words feel like they weigh five tons each. "Explain. You asked me to come with you."

Adora's eyes light up. "*See*? So what you're saying doesn't–"

"I said no."

Adora stops. For the first time since she woke up on that skiff, she stills completely. After what feels like years, she just says. "Oh."

At the sound, the waves recede, letting through a sharp, searing stab that's so unexpected Catra almost recoils. *That* feeling she knows.

It's guilt. Horrible, choking *guilt*.

Which, what the *hell*? Adora's the one who left –*she*'s the one at fault here! Catra has *no* business feeling guilty *at all*. She squares her jaw, and clings to the red hot wave still churning in her gut instead. "What, just because you do something stupid means I *have* to do it, too?"

And suddenly, the feeling has a name, brought to light by the sheer *déjà vu* the topic is creating –anger bordering on rage, building and building, because the fact that even when *mindwiped*, Adora still expects her to have dropped everything just to follow her is driving her out of her *mind*.

"That's not what I mean–"

She takes a step forward. "I'm my own *person*, Adora. Believe it or not, I don't actually *have* to follow everywhere you go."

"That's not what I'm *saying*!" Adora explodes. She stumbles forward a little, catching her balance just before she can tumble down, but her gaze remains focused on Catra, wild and lost and a little desperate. "You *know* that's not it, it's just–"

"Just what?"

But Adora scrunches her face. "Ugh, this is so *stupid*. We're arguing about something that didn't even happen!"

"It's just *what*, Adora?"

"It's just that we *promised*!"

And just like that, it's like Adora's the one who's clawed her open.

Adora lets her head drop with a sigh before continuing, the anger gone from her voice. "Look, however stupid this is, there's two options right? Either I left for a bad reason, in which case you should have taken me back to the Fright Zone, either I left for a good reason, in which case…" She doesn't say *you should have come with me*, but Catra hears it all the same. "In both cases… We're together. Just like we said we would be. So *this*" –she gestures vaguely in Catra's direction with her chin– "doesn't make sense."

It sounds so simple, when she says it like that.

The waves of fury, so all-consuming barely a few seconds ago, are snuffed out. All that's left is the sharp searing guilt, and bone-deep exhaustion, and Catra is *done* with this conversation. There's no point to it anyway –this isn't even the real Adora. Nothing she says is actually *from* her; it's all Shadow Weaver.

Catra gives herself a few seconds, repeating the thought to herself long enough for it to solidify into something she can almost actually believe, before speaking again: "Whatever. We need to move. The Horde can probably track the skiff, and we're still too close to the edge of the Woods."

For a moment, Adora looks like she's going to argue. The real Adora would have, probably. But this isn't the real Adora, and so she only ends up tilting her head, shooting her a curious look. "Move where?"

"You'll see."

A clearly unconvinced eyebrow raise answers her. "You don't have a map," Adora points out. "What's the plan, walk until the rebels find us?"

That's exactly the plan. "No."

Adora breathes a huff that's half laughter, half exasperation. "Great."

Catra ignores her, eyeing her ankle restraints. It's going to take them ages to cover any sort of ground if she leaves them on her, but on the other hand, the pain still radiating along her jaw tells her she might not have a choice.

"You can take them off." Adora blows out a breath when Catra shoots her a quizzical look. "The ankle cuffs. I'm not going to run."

"And I'm supposed to take your word for that?"

She shakes her head. "I'm not going to ditch you while you're under a princess spell."

Meaning, she won't run away but will definitely attempt to drag her back to the Horde at the first sign of distraction. Great.

But Catra still has the stun baton, and Adora's not an idiot. It's a risk worth taking, if it means the Horde won't catch up to them before the rebels find them. And so, almost reluctantly, she undoes the cuffs at Adora's feet, and signals for her to start walking, which she does with only an eyeroll. Catra'll walk behind, to at least try to keep an eye on her.

All she's got left is the hope the rebels aren't as useless as they look and track them down quickly.

*

The rebels do not track them down quickly.

The sun's pretty high in the sky by the time either of them speaks again. It sends speckled light dancing all round them, making the shadows move in a way that has Catra on edge. Or maybe it's just the knowledge that she's willingly walking into enemy territory, *trying* to get captured. Who knows.

Adora's been walking without complaining, which is good, but with a crease in the middle of her forehead that means she's thinking, which is very bad. That intuition is confirmed when she speaks again, gaze trained on the ground to avoid tripping. "So if I defected and you didn't," she says, like there hasn't been a gap of several hours since they spoke about that, "why are you bringing me back?"

"Doesn't matter," she lies, even though she knows it won't be enough to deter her.

It isn't. "It's got us both in the middle of the Whispering Woods *trying* to get captured by rebels," she says with a pointed glance over her shoulder. "I'd say it matters."

This is not a conversation she wants to be having, much less with a brainwashed, Shadow Weaver-Ed Adora. "I thought you didn't believe me anyway."

Adora's tone is annoyingly perky. "Oh, I don't. I'm just hoping I can figure out a way to make you snap out of it *before* we become prisoners of war." A pause. "Then again, getting us kidnapped to prove a point is *exactly* the sort of thing you'd do, brainwashed or not, so I'm not sure why I'm bothering."

She can't help it; she snorts. "Maybe you just like lost causes that much," she suggests. She only hesitates for a second before speaking again, voice lower but still, she knows, perfectly audible. "Would explain why you defected, too."

The words get her exactly the reaction she was hoping for; Adora cranes her neck to shoot her a murderous glance. "I did *not*– ugh, forget it."

But hey, if Catra has to get through all the shitty parts of today – and there are a *lot* of those–, then there's no reason why she can't have a bit of fun, too. "Yeah, it makes sense," she continues, "you saw the pink, pastel, sparkly side, and you immediately

decided that's where you needed to be to win a *war*. It checks out."

It's been almost a month since Catra got the chance to properly get on Adora's nerves, and she forgot how *fun* it can be. It's mostly because of how easy it is: the annoyed whine coming from the girl ahead is like music to her ears. "I didn't–" She trails off. "Wait, pastel? Seriously?"

She doesn't even try to hold back the laughter. "Oh yeah. *Very* glittery too."

"No way–"

"I'm pretty sure there were actual hearts on some of the uniforms."

This time Adora laughs, too, and okay, maybe that's even better than when she's annoyed. "You're so full of it." There's a short silence, and when she speaks again, it's with a teasing lilt so familiar Catra can almost *see* the smug grin she's pulling, even though she's walking several steps ahead: "Plus, we both know that if anyone was going to be defecting from the Horde, it would *have* to be you, so."

"*What*?" The word comes out a full octave higher than she intended, and Adora laughs again, high and bright.

"Well, yeah, obviously. You're the one ditching classes and saying you *so don't care* about what the Horde is doing. So, technically, that means *you're* the one who saw the pastel glittery side and decided to switch."

"*That is so not how any of this works*."

There's only an unconvinced hum in response, and it trails off into laughter again in barely seconds.

"You're *so* annoying," Catra groans, and she takes a moment to be glad Adora can't see her face right now, because there's nothing

she can do about the smile tugging at her own lips.

"I mean, *I'm* not the one who's dragging us through the Whispering Woods, right now," Adora says. Her tone turns pointed. "Or, you know. *Tasering* people."

She sounds so offended that Catra doesn't bother to hide her snicker. "Get over it."

Adora looks over her shoulder to glare at her again, but the impact is lessened considerably by how amused she looks. "It *hurt*!"

"Aww, you're such a baby."

The glare finishes melting away as Adora starts laughing too, almost incredulously. "I'm so going to kill you for all this when this is over."

Catra fakes a gasp. "*Threats*? My, my, what would your pink sparkly friends *say*, Adora?"

The eyeroll is so satisfying it almost makes the entire day worth it. "They'll understand when they meet you."

The fact that they probably would is suddenly so ridiculously funny that Catra can't help but burst out laughing. Stars, is this something she's allowed to laugh about? Is this dark humor?

Whatever it is, she decides to go with it. Cause the truth is, this? Talking shit with Adora? It feels *right*, even if Adora's cuffed, even if they're in the middle of rebel territory waiting to get captured… It feels righter than *anything* has, for weeks now.

The truth hits her with all the clarity of a quarterstaff to the face; she *missed* Adora. She missed her when she was gone, and she missed her maybe even more once she was back.

And the fact is, she's going to have to miss her a lot more, very soon. It's not a surprise, but the thought still stifles the laughter.

"You know," Adora says over her shoulder, oblivious, "I think we've already walked past this–*whoa*!"

Her foot catches on some bit of plant or other, and she stumbles, her tied hands stopping her from regaining her balance. She's about to crash face first into the grass again but Catra steps in, crossing the gap between them and stabilizing her with a hand on the shoulder.

"Thanks," Adora says with a small, sheepish smile.

Catra lets go, but doesn't step back. If she only has these next few hours, then she might as well enjoy them, enjoy whatever *right* she gets to feel before everything's over, again. "So now we're adding walking to the list of things you're not great at. Yep, pastel side of the war's definitely the right one for you, no question."

She starts walking again, expecting Adora to follow, probably with another half offended, half jokey retort.

The reply does come, but instead, Adora's voice is soft, barely audible.

"I'm sorry."

Catra stumbles to a stop, taken off-guard by how gentle the words are, but doesn't turn to look at her. This Adora doesn't even remember leaving –and yet the apology feels sincere, like she genuinely feels bad. And sure, feeling bad about stuff is kinda Adora's whole thing, but still… Catra figures that despite her assurances to the contrary, what Catra's been telling her must be echoing in her head somehow, with whatever is left of the memories. It's a good sign, probably; it means whatever Shadow Weaver did must be reversible.

A good sign, right. "Yeah," she says, voice tight. "You've mentioned."

"I've– Oh. Oh, no, I'm not sorry about that." Adora's voice is a little bit lighter. "I'm sorry about *this*."

Everything happens in a blink.

There's movement at her side, too fast for her to process, and then her hip is lighter than it was –the immediate consequence of her stun baton being taken away from its holster, except its weight didn't make its way to her hand, because *she's* not the one who took it and–

Shit.

She's been *had*.

It clicks fast enough that she manages to jump out of the way right as Adora charges at her with her new found weapon. Only, her foot catches on a root or plant or whatever, because this place is the *worst*, and Catra loses her balance, arms windmilling as she tries to avoid going down completely. The weight of the bag on her back is *not* helping.

Adora, whose hands are now somehow completely free of restraints, uses the opportunity and lunges again, the end of the baton crackling with ominous green sparks. Catra lets herself go down, narrowly avoiding the blast and feeling a couple of hairs get singed in the process. She shoots a leg out, smashing a foot against the back of Adora's knees and the girl tumbles into the grass. Catra goes over her, trying to reach for the taser, but Adora holds it out of reach, bringing one knee up to push her off.

With a groan of frustration, Catra grasps only empty air, fingers falling short of the weapon. "What happened to your *cuffs*?" she grits out.

Adora still finds it in her to grin cockily. "Picked the lock."

"With *what*?"

"A tiny stick I picked up while you were rambling about tiaras."

In any other situation, the fact that Adora managed to pick the ridiculously tiny lock on the handcuffs with nothing but a stick *while wearing them* would probably have been impressive enough that even Catra would have to reluctantly admit it was kinda cool.

In this particular situation however, it's mostly annoying as *shit*.

With a regain of frustrated energy, Catra uses one hand to push Adora's face into the dirt below, managing enough leverage to reach for the hand still holding the taser, grab the wrist, and *twist*. With a yell, Adora lets go, but before Catra can grab it for herself, she's launched off her position by a powerful kick, and lands a few feet away, winded. "I don't want to hurt you!"

Catra groans. "Convincing impression, then."

She dives for the baton that's still on the ground, but Adora flies to her feet and kicks it into the underbrush before she can reach it. "Catra *please*, I know you think this is right, but you're not yourself."

Ugh. "As soon as you get your memories back, I am so killing you for this," she mumbles under her breath, before leaping out of the way when Adora pounces on her again.

It would work, it *should* work, because it always does, because no one ever catches her in training when she doesn't want them to, not even Adora, except she has that stupid sword on her back, and it weighs a *ton*, and it throws her off completely. Adora gets a hold of her arm, and the pull almost brings her back down to the ground. It's only with a swipe of claws that sends Adora ducking that she gets free, and she immediately shrugs off the bag, letting it fall into the dirt.

Now it's a fair fight.

With the two of them on equal ground again, it's so easy to fall back into their usual rhythm; that's what a lifetime of training with someone will do to you. Catra knows where Adora will aim, knows when she will lunge. In return, Adora knows precisely how Catra

will try to dodge, and how she'll retaliate. They've only fought each other and meant it once, really, in Salineas, but it was off-balanced, what with Adora being so focused on her magic gate. And even then, Catra had hardly meant it, either.

And it's different here, too. Neither of them wants to do damage to the other –Adora's apparently convinced she's saving Catra, after all, and there's no point in taking the risks Catra's taken today if it's just to end up murdering Adora in the woods anyway. No matter how tempting it might be right now.

Those two facts put together mean that the fighting between the two of them quickly loses all kind of technicality and becomes…

Well.

More worthy of a couple of five-year-olds than of two of the youngest Force Captains the Horde has ever seen.

Catra can almost hear the disappointed sigh coming from their instructor all the way back in the Fright Zone as she puts her leg out and trips Adora mid swing. It gets worse when Adora retaliates by grabbing hold of her ankle from the ground and pulling, sending Catra tumbling face first into the dirt with a shriek. "Let *go* of me!" The words are muffled by the grass and *stars*, one day, Catra is going to murder Shadow Weaver for putting her through this, and she is going to *enjoy* it.

Adora basically sits on her back to keep her in place. "Catra come *on*, you have to snap out of this! You're better than a stupid magic spell!"

Catra twists under Adora's weight, enough to free one arm, and she reaches for Adora's ponytail and *pulls*. The girl yelps in response, losing her balance and tumbling to the ground next to her. "*Catra*!"

"What?" She's managed to free herself enough to stand back up, and that's all that matters.

Adora's struggling to her feet too, but Catra's already taken off in the direction where Adora kicked the baton –she hopes. If she can just find the stupid thing, then she'll drag Adora back to Bright Moon in peace; better dead-weight-Adora than kicking-your-ass-Adora.

She knows she only has seconds before Adora regains her balance enough to attack again, but her gaze snags on a black, cylindrical shape between the leaves, and she triumphantly dives towards it, ready to end this.

Before her fingers can touch the plastic however, her ears pick out a soft, high-pitched whistling sound. Her instincts send her jumping backwards –just in time, as it turns out.

One second later, she's staring at the shaft of an arrow, sticking out from the trunk of the tree behind her, still vibrating from the impact.

Uh oh.

"Adora!"

She twists on her heel and her gaze immediately lands on the two newcomers at the edge of their little patch of forest. She's never met them properly, but Adora's new best friends are unmistakable. The archer still has his bow in position after his shot, looking focused, but the pink one –hang on, is that actual *glitter* in her hair?– is the one who called Adora's name, expression frozen in shock, or maybe relief.

And Adora… Adora's rooted to the spot, looking like she might not even be breathing, eyes trained on them.

Time stands still.

And then the pink princess's gaze lands on Catra. Immediately, her brows furrow and she rears her arm back in what could possibly be the preparation for a punch if she wasn't standing a whole fifty feet away. The explanation comes quickly when instead

of a punch, it's a ball of bright pink glitter –which, once again, *seriously*?– that comes flying towards her. Catra jumps out of the way reflexively, half cackling, but the laughter quickly dies down when one of the energy pulses brushes her arm, singeing her on the way.

Okay. Burning, *glittery* energy projectiles. Sure. Why not. Today is just *like that*, apparently.

She's clearly readying herself for more when a sudden blur of white and red strikes across the space between them, tackling the princess to the ground with a yell –it takes a second for that blur to register as Adora. In a bright, *glittery* pink haze, the princess and Adora both vanish, but before Catra can begin to panic, they both reappear a few feet away.

The shock stalls Adora for a second, and she stumbles, disoriented, until she refocuses on the princess and charges again. The girl barely has a second to *teleport* herself away –and *how* did Catra forget that was a thing she could do?–, reappearing right behind Adora. "Adora, what are you–"

To her credit, Adora adapts pretty quickly to the fact that her opponent can disappear and reappear at will. She's light enough on her feet to be able to switch directions as needed, and Catra knows it's only a matter of time before she starts being able to anticipate the moves enough to actually get her hands on the princess.

That, in normal circumstances, would be a *good* thing, except that Catra's pretty sure that if Adora gets her memories back only to find out she's murdered one of her brand new pastel friends, well… She's probably not going to be *super* happy.

Which means that, as funny as this is –and it's *pretty* funny, especially with how offended the pink princess sounds as she yells at Adora–, Catra probably should try to intervene before it escalates.

Ugh.

She's about to jump into the fray, hoping to take Adora by surprise enough to throw her off, but she's barely taken a step in their direction when that same whistling sound comes again. She jumps out of the way of the thin golden arrow with a hiss, but they keep coming, the archer determined and unyielding and *so* annoying right now.

"Wait–" she starts, attempting a step in his direction, but, unsurprisingly, he does not. Soon enough, she's way too busy avoiding his shots to be able to intervene, and it gets so much worse when two quick ones in succession means she gets caught into the net that explodes out of the second one.

What kind of person makes *net* arrows anyway?

Catra's more aggravated than actually injured, but that's apparently not obvious, if Adora's panicked yell of her name is any indication. Catra twists in the restraints –her claws can slice through them easy, but they're so tangled that she still can't get free–, only to see Adora's gaze fly wildly around the clearing, looking for anything that could give her an advantage against what she sees as enemy combatants.

It lands on the bag Catra dropped earlier, and the determination in Adora's eyes is immediate. She dives for it, sudden and desperate, and even though this was the plan all along, Catra can't breathe, and she braces herself for the light and–

And nothing happens.

Well, not exactly nothing. There's no magic, no bright light, no eight-foot tall glowy lady.

What there *is*, however, is a very pissed off Adora with a sword.

Which, as it turns out, is definitely not *nothing*.

With a yell, she charges the sparkly one again and oh wow, *okay*, yeah, Catra *really* needs to intervene now if she doesn't want the murder scenario to become reality. She slices through the rest of the net, and is only mildly relieved when no more arrows fly her way. Only mildly, because the only reason they don't come turns out to be that the archer has switched his focus to Adora. The panic and confusion on his face tell Catra he doesn't *want* to shoot, but seeing the arrow pointed at her still floods her with something that's much too close to fear.

She takes off towards him –she can take down the immediate threat on Adora and explain *after*, it's fine–, only to get cut off when the plants at her feet suddenly grow *up*, twisting around her ankles and legs. Catra's not an expert on plants or anything, but she's pretty sure they can't just *do* that.

That idea gets confirmed when she catches sight of the very focused looking girl that's just appeared at the edge of the clearing. She is also in pink, and although free of glitter, the literal *flowers* in her hair are enough to mark her as a rebel –if the fact that she can apparently make plants grow on command wasn't enough of an indication.

The vines and other assorted green things aren't especially solid, and no match for her claws, but they grow fast and tangled, and she's immobilized in seconds. "Wait, I'm trying to–"

Her words fall on deaf ears, covered as they are by the way the first princess and the archer are yelling at Adora to get her to *stop* and *listen*. The fact that they're about as successful as she herself has been all day is only mildly comforting.

Adora is mostly swinging at empty air, but the princess is running out of steam –her teleports are more last minute, and the pink bursts of glitter she's been using to deflect Adora's blows lack the original energy they had. With a sharp, cold twist in her stomach, Catra realizes the archer has noticed, too; his posture tenses as he readies himself to take a shot before Adora can actually do some damage, and Catra stops thinking.

“Adora!” she calls out. She’s not sure what she’s hoping to achieve –warn Adora, or distract her, but either way, it works. At the sound of her voice, she turns, her eyes widening as she catches sight of Catra, trapped in the tangled vines, and her sword arm drops briefly, her next slash stopped in its track.

Unfortunately, the princess doesn’t get the memo; not having expected the sudden absence of attack, she shoots off another pink glittery projectile in Adora’s direction. Catra winces reflexively, but with a speed that is *way* beyond anything she's ever displayed before, Adora twists on her heel and brings up her sword to block it. One swing, and the burst of energy is deflected out of the way.

Except that the shot is so last second that it's also not particularly controlled; and so, out of Adora’s way also happens to mean directly in *Catra’s* way. She tries to duck out of the projectile’s trajectory with a yelp, but the trap proves too inescapable: the blast hits her square on, sending her head spinning and the breath rushing out of her in one painful gasp.

The last thing she hears is Adora’s panicked call of her name before it all goes dark.

Chapter End Notes

> Ah, chapter 3, aka “catra’s terrible, horrible, no good, very bad day”. I’d say it’s going to get better, but, well. bit of a way to go before we get there 😬
>
> Thank you for reading, and I’d love to hear what you thought! 💕

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

this,,,,, got away from me

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The first thing Catra sees when she wakes up is pink, glittery, and *severely* pissed off. Not a combination of traits she'd ever really expected to come face to face with, to be honest.

"What," grits out a voice that falls a bit too much on the shrill side to be intimidating, "did you do to Adora?"

The words finish snapping her out of her post-unconscious haze – ugh, did she really get knocked out by a bunch of pink sparkles? That is *so* embarrassing–, and the events of the previous days come rushing in. Shadow Weaver, Adora, the woods...

The princesses.

Right. So the tiny, furious, ridiculously pastel person in front of her must be one of Adora's new best friends. Not for the first time, Catra feels a stab of offense –*this* is what Adora left her for? Seriously?

The girl also looks like she's really out of patience, so Catra takes her time trying whatever she has left of it, looking around the room and taking in her surroundings.

So this is Bright Moon.

The room is large, airy, with massive floor to ceiling windows –and that's saying something, considering the ceiling is way higher than it should be. Whatever furniture there is looks... nice, all polished woods and glittering gold accents. Even the chair she's in –and tied to, she notices belatedly– is pretty comfortable.

What all this *isn't*, is very prison-like. Catra had pictured Bright Moon more than once, growing up. It was the heart of the rebellion after all, and their instructors had always made it sound like nightmare fuel. Of course, she'd figured there must be a healthy dose of Horde propaganda thrown in, but she'd definitely never expected it to be so... cushiony.

She speaks, repressing a grin. "Where am I?"

The girl in front of her crosses her arms –Catra gets the distinct impression she's trying not to stomp her foot against the gleaming marble floor–, but replies: "Bright Moon. You're our prisoner, Horde scum, so don't try anything funny."

She can't help it –she snorts. "This is a prison?"

Her eyes narrow. "Of course this is a prison."

Catra nods, making a show of looking around, even as she tests the restraints keeping her hands together and stuck to the back of her chair. It's tight, but it also seems to be basic rope. "Do all rebellion prisons have a decorative waterfall in them?" she asks innocently.

Ah, *there's* the foot stomp, together with an infuriated groan of frustration. She uses the distraction of the noise to pull at the knot with a claw. Not that she's planning on escaping –she's technically exactly where she wanted to be–, but if it does come to that, she'd rather be able to get out fast.

"*I* ask the questions," her interrogator declares, one finger wagging in her direction.

But before she can make good on that, the tall, ornamented doors open, letting in Adora's other new best friend. He looks more tired than angry, but his bow is very much still strapped to his back, which automatically makes him more of a threat –even if he isn't exactly radiating aggression right now.

He doesn't immediately notice that Catra's awake, rolling his eyes as he walks in. "Well, she tried to *bite* me, so I think we can safely say she's not getting any better." He pauses as he finally takes in the scene. Catra expects him to lash out, the same way his princess friend did, but all that comes is a flat: "Ah. You must be Catra."

She drops the nonchalant facade immediately, guarded. "And how do you know that?"

But he just makes his way across the room to sink onto a low chair a few feet away. "Because Adora's been demanding to know what we're doing to you for the better part of an hour," he says tiredly. "She seems to be convinced we're going to be torturing you, for some reason."

"Aren't you?"

"No," he says.

"Maybe," says the princess at the exact same time.

He shoots her a look that has her rolling her eyes. "*No*," he says again, firmer, before turning back to Catra. "You don't happen to know where Adora could have gotten that impression, do you?"

"Beats me."

He looks like he'd expected as much, quietly resigned, but the princess isn't so easily deterred.

"Which brings us back to our main topic," she says, stepping right in front of Catra again. "Whatever you've done to Adora, undo it. Right. Now."

"I haven't done anything."

"Riiiight." She laughs, high pitched and sarcastic. "So she just *happened* to leave us behind and go back to the Horde. For *no reason*. Just like she *happened* to forget all about us."

“Maybe you’re not as memorable as you thought. Adora’s fickle like that.” She shrugs.

“She’s not!”

“Yeah, well, you don’t know her like I do.” The princess’s mouth twists into a hard, tight line, and a flash of vindictive satisfaction rushes through her. “Maybe she’s not the person you thought she was.”

“Or maybe,” the archer says from his seat, “someone’s done something to her memories.” He’s staring at Catra like she’s a puzzle he can’t quite figure out how to put together, and it makes her shift uncomfortably. “Look, we just want Adora to be okay. We’ll even let you go, seriously.”

“Bow!” The princess’ mouth has dropped open into an incredulous o.

“What?” Bow –which, seriously? Next, it’ll turn out the princess’ name is actually Sparkles– says, standing up. “Were you planning on keeping her around forever?”

“She’s a *Horde soldier*.”

“She’s our only lead to help Adora.”

They seem to have forgotten Catra’s in the room with them and can therefore hear everything they’re saying. It’s another sign that they’re probably pretty new at this whole prisoner of war thing, although the lack of cell was a pretty big give away already.

They keep bickering for a bit, and she sighs to herself. As fun as it is to antagonize them –especially the princess–, she did bring Adora here for a reason. “You’re right,” she says, loud enough to stop their chatting. “Adora’s... not really herself right now.”

“Ha!” The girl spins on her heel with a triumphant grin. “I *knew* it. Whatever you’ve done, you better–“

"*I* didn't do anything." She slumps back into her chair a little. "The Horde has this... sorcerer."

"Do you mean Shadow Weaver?" Bow asks, turning back towards her and she pauses, caught off guard.

"Adora told you about Shadow Weaver?" She hadn't expected Adora to mention anything about her life with the Horde. Fresh start and all that.

He winces. "A bit, yeah. Mostly though, we got… a demonstration of sorts. In Mystacor."

Right; that's where Shadow Weaver found Adora. She should have guessed her friends would be with her when it happened. "Oh yeah," she says, eyes narrowing. "That's where you let Adore get *kidnapped*. I forgot."

The sparkly one spins on her heel, clearly ready to launch into a tirade, but Bow speaks before she can, flat and matter of fact. "Right. Also where your sorceress hijacked a massive ritual protection spell, almost destroyed the entire city, and locked it down for two weeks while the spell was rebuilt."

Huh. That *does* sound like a very Shadow Weaver thing to do.

"Castaspella and the guild of sorcerers managed to stop her before she could completely destroy it," Bow continues, "but by the time the chaos cleared, there was no sign of Adora."

"Shadow Weaver used her shadow spies to drag her back to the Fright Zone." She swallows hard. "And then she took Adora's memories of the whole thing. The whole time she spent here."

"And She-Ra," Bow completes.

She suppresses the urge to snarl, gritting her teeth instead. Of course, it makes sense that they'd focus on the warrior princess part –it *is* their best chance of making any kind of progress against the Horde–, but the fact that Adora's supposed *friends*

prioritize that over her general well-being leaves a bitter taste in her mouth. “And She-Ra,” she still confirms.

She was expecting horror, but instead, they exchange looks that don’t seem quite convinced enough.

“You don’t believe me,” she says flatly

Bow winces. “Well, it would explain a lot, but it’s just… you’ve never been exactly *trustworthy*, you know?”

She can’t help the stab of offense. “What–“

Bow sighs, listing the points on his fingers. “Look, the first time I saw you, you were tasering Adora to take her back to the Horde and trying to sack Thaymor; the second, you were trying to demolish the Sea Gate; and the third, once again, trying to taser Adora. First impressions wise, it’s not *the* most positive.”

That’s… kind of a good point, actually –not that she’s going to tell him that. “Okay, no, that’s not what I was–“

She trails off; she *was* kind of trying to taser Adora, even if it was for a good cause. “I wasn’t trying to take Adora back to the Horde,” she says instead, a bit more truthfully. “It’s the other way around. She wanted us to head back, and I was trying to bring her here.”

The princess lets out a sharp, incredulous laugh. “And you think we’re just going to believe you?”

“Why would I lie?”

“You’re a Horde soldier, it’s what you *do*.”

“Glimmer–“

Ha, *Glimmer*? Close enough. “Listen, Sparkles, I know you have no reason to trust me, but this isn’t about me. Or you, for that matter, if you can get that through your skull.” She takes a second

to tamp down on the flare of very real anger. "Now, I didn't risk my life and Adora's to have a *chat*. I did it because for some reason, I thought you guys might actually be able to figure this out and *do* something to help her."

She doesn't bother trying to repress the sneer that comes with her next words, however. "Honestly, I'm not sure *why* I thought that, considering you didn't even bother *trying* to get Adora back from the Fright Zone–"

"–magical lockdown spell on a flying city–" Bow reminds flatly.

"–but I did. Somehow, I still do. So, can you help her or not?"

For all their earlier bickering, the looks they exchange prove they're fully capable of having an entire conversation without words. Catra's immediately convinced that these two have known each other a very, *very* long time –she's familiar with that mode of communication, too, after all.

"Aunt Casta might be able to help," Sparkles says eventually, clearly for Bow's benefit more than Catra's. "She's still not at a hundred percent after Mystacor, and they're still rebuilding, but if I tell her it's for Adora, she'll try." She catches sight of Catra's narrowed eyes and sighs before elaborating: "My aunt Castaspella. She's the head sorceress in Mystacor."

The idea of letting *another* sorceress mess with Adora makes Catra want to grit her teeth, but she doubts there's any other option. If anything, these two probably won't let anyone hurt Adora –or their precious She-Ra.

And Catra'll stick around until it's over anyway, just in case.

Carefully, she makes sure no trace of her worry is perceivable, and grins, as annoyingly as she can. "Great," she says, giving a last slash of claws at the knot keeping her hands together. The rope falls in tatters on the ground and she stands up. "Let's do this, then."

Sparkles' annoyed groan isn't *as* amusing as Adora's, but honestly, it's a close call.

*

Things move pretty fast, after that. It might have taken them a while to go after Adora, but now that they have her, the rebels prove remarkably more efficient. In fact, the way everyone bends over backwards to satisfy Sparkles' demands makes Catra think she's probably somewhat highly placed in the rebellion's command chain, or at least connected to someone important.

Or maybe everyone just wants the glowy warrior princess back that badly, who knows.

Castaspella turns out to be a tall, exhausted-looking woman. She's also got a floating tiara circling her head, which is somehow even worse than a regular tiara. Still, beyond the floor-length robes, she has approximately nothing that reminds Catra of Shadow Weaver, which helps her feel slightly less on edge.

She still ends up digging the tip of her claws into her palms when the woman casts a sleeping spell on Adora from the hallway. The intricate, light blue designs she draws in the air and pushes through the door might not look anything like Shadow Weaver's dark red and black wisps, but sorcery's sorcery.

But once they make their way into the room where they've been keeping Adora, she looks peaceful –gently snoring in the chair at the centre of the room, with none of the tenseness or unnatural stillness Catra would have expected from a sleeping spell. With a nod from Sparkles, two guards undo Adora's restraints and carry her to the bed at the end of the room, before exiting.

Everyone moves in that direction, too, but Catra stays back a moment, looking around. The space is as bright and airy as the

room she'd woken up in, but a few things make it look just a little bit more *lived in*: some cushions scattered on the floor here and there, some scribbled over pieces of paper tacked to the wall… With a jolt, Catra realizes that this is probably *Adora's* room, the one where she's been staying since leaving the Horde.

Her gaze catches on the large canopy above the bed, and she finds herself wondering if Adora had as much trouble sleeping alone as Catra had, in those weeks she was gone. Probably not, if it was in a bedroom like this. And, after all, Adora's never needed her as much as Catra needed her –never really needed her at all, even, maybe.

The sorceress calls for her from Adora's bedside. "Catra?"

Except this time, she kind of really does.

Swallowing hard, Catra makes her way over, carefully ignoring the looks everyone is giving her.

There's not that many people around, but it's still too many for her to be comfortable –or maybe it's just that most of them are quite literally the very enemy she's spent her entire life preparing to fight. Sparkles and the archer are there, which was to be expected, and the sorceress of course. More intimidating, however, is the other member of their party: tall, delicate shoulders wrapped in a shimmering cape, is the very recognizable queen of Bright Moon herself.

Everyone's been more or less glaring at Catra every time she glances in their direction, but that's fine, really. Catra knows how to handle that. But the queen has this flat, impassible way of looking at her that makes her feel frustratingly *small*.

Still. She's got a lifetime of practice when it comes to not showing authority figures the impact they have on her. She keeps her stance loose and relaxed as she walks over to them, stopping next to the sorceress.

Castaspella, for all her floating tiaras, and Sparkles' talk of her being *head sorceress*, whatever that is, isn't a particularly threatening woman. The smell of sorcery clings to her in a way that makes Catra want to bolt every time she takes a breath, but beyond that, there's really not much about her that screams *in charge*, or even just *especially powerful*. It'd be good news, but since Catra's relying on her to undo whatever Shadow Weaver's done, it only makes her feel slightly uneasy.

From up close, that impression solidifies. There are dark circles under her eyes, and her skin is a bit ashen, a sure sign of exhaustion. There's also a long ish cut along the woman's temple, healed, but freshly so, and all of a sudden, Catra remembers that her city has just been all but torn apart by the Horde –Shadow Weaver and her spies, technically, but, well, same thing, really.

But where everyone's been staring at Catra like they're expecting her to set fire to the palace if they turn their back, the woman's gaze is calm and free of reproach when she addresses her: "What can you tell me about the spell?"

Catra blinks. "I don't– I mean, I don't know anything about magic, so–"

But Castaspella only shakes her head, her expression still gentle. "No, I know. But there's any number of thing… *Shadow Weaver* might have done." She says the name with a surprisingly hard lilt to her voice. "Anything you can tell me about the effects will help narrow it down." Catra still hesitates, so she continues. "Glimmer says it affected her memories?"

She needs to get herself together –no matter how on edge all this *magic* has her, Adora needs it. Needs *her*, right now. She nods. "Yeah. She took away all the time Adora spent here. Everything about She-Ra, too. When Adora came back, she just thought she'd been captured and held hostage. She didn't remember what had actually happened."

There's a worried glint in the woman's eyes. "She overwrote the memories?"

But that's not quite right. "No, she said… She said she'd given her suggestions," Catra recounts, trying to remember the words Shadow Weaver had used. Thinking about that particular conversation brings back memories of dark, icily choking shadows, but she clenches her fists and forces herself to breathe past it. "She said Adora's mind would fill in the gaps."

The woman's face twists disdainfully. "Ha. So she's *not* quite as powerful as she'd like to be, huh. Serves her *right*, if you ask–"

The queen clears her throat and the sorceress stops, shaking her head. She lifts a hand, holding it over Adora's head, and the tips of her fingers start glowing a faint blue –it takes Catra a lifetime of practice to stop herself from bristling at the sight.

"What I *mean*," Castaspella says, pointed, "is that this is good news. If she wasn't able to overwrite the memories, then chances are she only blocked the real ones."

"So it's reversible?" Sparkles asks, hope obvious in her voice.

"That's not it," Catra interrupts. She shifts a little when she feels everyone's gaze turn back towards her. "It's… It's not just the memories. She's done something else."

Castaspella lets her hand fall back to her side. "What else?"

"I'm not *sure*, but it's just… I think she's influencing her. Still now, I mean."

There's a few whispers at her words, but the sorceress only tilts her head. "Influencing her how?"

"Making her say things. Think things. Things she wouldn't actually… She–" Catra trails off, unwilling to give away what had made her realize that Shadow Weaver's influence was more long lasting –that Adora had promised not to leave her behind and

actually seemed to *mean* it. She settles on the next best example, instead. "We saw records of the Horde's operations, but she didn't react. It was just… Normal, for her. Like she didn't care."

"That doesn't sound like Adora," Bow says, somewhere behind her.

Castaspella looks worried now, gnawing at her lip as she thinks. "No, it really doesn't." Another pass of a glowy hand over Adora's face, and she frowns, her brow creasing in something that might be anger. "That woman really has no shame," she mutters, and yeah, that's definitely anger. "Influencing a *child* like that, it's–" She cuts herself off with a long breath, before turning back to Catra. "Is there anything else you can remember? Any other things that made you think Shadow Weaver was influencing her?"

"It wasn't really anything specific," she says, and she's not really lying; beyond the obvious, it was more to do with Adora generally *was*, rather than a specific incident. "Every time she seemed to be about to remember, or say something against the Horde, the spell would kick in again."

Catra can tell it's not enough; the woman doesn't say anything, doesn't admonish her, but it's the way her face doesn't relax, and in the way she squares her shoulder as she draws another complicated glyph over Adora. Gently, she lowers it, but right as it reaches her, it dissolves in a puff of angry red smoke.

"What is it, Casta?" the queen asks, the tension in her voice betraying her apparent calm.

"What it is, is that Light Spinner is a tricky little *snake*," Castaspella retorts back, brow furrowed in concentration as she closes her eyes and gently puts a glowing finger to Adora's temple. She sighs and takes a step back, her eyes reopening. "This is going to be tricky."

"Light Spinner?" Catra didn't necessarily mean to ask out loud, but Castaspella doesn't seem to mind, only nodding.

"It's what she was called, back in Mystacor."

"Shadow Weaver used to live in Mystacor?" She's not sure why the news is *such* a shock –apparently, the whole place is crawling with sorcerers. Shadow Weaver is just so connected to the Fright Zone in her mind that it's hard to imagine her anywhere else, much less on the side of the Rebellion.

"She was cast out," the queen says, tone hard. "Banished, with good reason."

Yeah, that's not hard to believe. She can't really imagine that Shadow Weaver's preferred methods would fly with the pink, heart-covered side of this fight.

"She sought power at all cost," Castaspella continues. "And she almost took my brother down with her, too, when he was just a *child*. She trained him, got into his head, and tried to use him to get more power for herself."

Well *that* sounds familiar. Catra's gaze falls to Adora automatically, taking in her relaxed, peaceful features as she sleeps through this. "She does that," she mutters under her breath, almost unconsciously.

Castaspella shoots her a look, but Sparkles speaks first: "So there's nothing you can do?"

"I didn't say that." Another complicated glyph is drawn above Adora, and suffers the same fate as its predecessor. "From Catra's description, I think she's only put a lock on Adora's mind, and sealed away her memories. It's not particularly sophisticated, but it does the job."

"But the influence–" Catra starts.

She doesn't get far; Castaspella nods. "I know. But sustaining that kind of influence, over distance and time? If she had that sort of power at her disposal, then Mystacor would be ruins, right now. We'd never have been able to stop her." She stops, swallowing

hard as she presumably thinks of that possibility, before she manages to shake it off. "The mind is… complicated. There's a reason why that sort of spell is prohibited. Our memories make us who we are, in a way. Depending on what she locked away, it might be affecting Adora's perception, or her empathy." She nods once, determined. "Our best bet is removing the lock. We can see how to proceed from there."

"And you *can* do that, right? Remove it?" Catra knows she sounds disbelieving, but she doesn't care; she needs to know this is doable –that all this wasn't for nothing.

"I… yes." The hesitation doesn't exactly fill Catra with confidence, and Castaspella catches that. "I *can*. The problem is going to be figuring out how to get a hold of the spell, rather than removing it. It's like…" Her gaze unfocuses as she apparently searches for an appropriate comparison. She snaps her fingers, smiling brightly. "Do you knit? It's like a tangled ball of yarn, where I have to find the right thread to pull."

Catra blinks at her.

The woman's face falls a little. "Right. Horde soldier. Probably not a lot of time for knitting. That's fine." She chews on her bottom lip for a few seconds. "It's the right idea, though. I have to pull on the right thing, and avoid making the knot worse in the process." Her gaze suddenly sharpens. "You said the spell flared, sometimes?"

"Uh, yeah." The sorceress' intensity is hard to parse, and Catra reins in the urge to swing on to the balls of her feet, forcing herself still to avoid showing her nervousness. "I tried to ask about what she remembered, and it was like some of the memories she had didn't quite line up? And when she started realizing that, it kicked in again." The memory of the dark red glow isn't a pleasant one. "Not long, but just enough that she wouldn't be thinking about it anymore."

"Ha *ha*!" Castaspella looks like she's about to start bouncing into place, her eyes bright with a victorious glint. "*That*'s our key."

Catra isn't sure she's following; she feels marginally better about it when she sees the puzzled glances the others are throwing each other. "It… is?" Sparkles says, clearly unconvinced.

Castaspella doesn't let the lukewarm reaction deter her. "Of course! Adora's memories are constructs, things her mind came up with to breach the gaps the spell created. The more she questions them, the harder the spell has to work, the easier it'll be to grasp and undo." She smiles, wide and determined. "Undo one of those memories, and the whole spell will come apart, like a dropped stitch unravelling all the others."

Catra's not sure she's grasping the knitting metaphor, but the idea's clear enough. And what's more, she knows exactly what thread –or stitch, or whatever– they should be pulling at. "Thaymor," she says, almost unconsciously.

Everyone's gaze snaps towards her again, and she straightens up, forcing her next words to be loud and steady. "Thaymor's the memory we want to aim for," she explains. "It's the biggest overwrite; Adora thinks it's where I– where the Horde rescued her. It's one of the first things she remembered."

"It makes sense," Bow interjects. "It's where everything changed for her. If Adora can remember what actually happened in Thaymor, then there's no way the rest of the spell will hold."

Bow's support is annoyingly comforting. Catra squares her shoulders, trying to ignore the feeling as she addresses the sorceress. "If you wake her up and give me a few minutes alone with her, I can talk her through it again. I let it go before she really started doubting it last time, but it shouldn't be hard to bring her back to that point."

Then again, that last conversation took place *before* Adora became convinced Catra was under some kind of princess spell.

Rubbing a hand against the sore spot on her jaw, she mumbles an amendment: "Maybe just… tie her to a chair first, or something."

Castaspella nods, speaking in a low voice, almost to herself. "Then we have our angle. Now, about–"

"Wait," Sparkles suddenly interrupts, and Catra grits her teeth again. Now that she's this close to actually fixing things, she's really not interested in whatever the pink princess' misgivings are. She fixes her with a cold glare.

The princess, to her credit, returns it right back. Her eyes narrow, and when she speaks again, the words are clipped as she gestures vaguely in Catra's direction. "I don't think we should let her do this."

Yeah, Catra *really* isn't here for this. She rolls her eyes, and turns back to the sorceress, fully intent on ignoring the interruption. "*Like I said*, a few minutes should be enough. It'll be better if you can–"

"I'm serious," comes the bordering-on-shrill voice again, apparently not so easily defeated. "She's from the *Horde*; for all we know, if we leave her alone with Adora, all she'll do is solidify the fake memories, and make sure the spell can't be reversed! We can't trust her!"

Bow opens his mouth, presumably to say something very reasonable and helpful indeed, but Catra beats him to it, with a markedly less level response. "*What*? That is the *stupidest*–"

"All I'm saying is that we've known her for maximum three hours total and that she spent two of those trying to *kill* us so–"

"–fucking thing I've ever heard. What would be the *point*? If I wanted to keep Adora under the spell, I could have just *stayed* where we were, instead of–"

"–I really don't see *why* everyone suddenly seems *so* happy to trust her–"

"–having to drag her through the entirety of the Whispering Woods, which, by the way, thanks again for that, considering it took you a literal *entire day* to track us down–"

Sparkles just raises her voice and speaks over her, something she is, as it turns out, annoyingly *good* at –the girl might be short, but she has a *voice*. "Most of the memories that got taken were of me and Bow," she says, addressing the sorceress and stubbornly ignoring Catra. "That means either of us could do this, too."

Too bad for her –Catra's not really in the mood to be ignored, right now. "She doesn't remember *anything* about these memories, Sparkles. It's not going to make her question anything."

The words seem to push the princess up a level on the annoyance scale, and she turns to speak in Catra's direction, even if the words aren't aimed at her. "We were in Thaymor as well. Even if it *has* to be Thaymor, we don't need *her* to do it, it could be either of us."

Is she for *real*? It's like she wants Adora to stay under that spell. "She has *no idea* who you are! All she knows is that you're the enemy! She's not going to listen to a word you say, she'll just think you're trying to trick her."

But the princess just glares harder. "If aunt Casta undoes the spell as we go, the memories'll start to come back and it'll be fine, so–"

"Have you *met* Adora? She's way too stubborn, there's no way it'll work. If anything, as soon as you start telling her about what really happened, she'll cling to her own version out of sheer spite. I'm the only option, and you know it, so if you could stop your little tantrum and let us actually get to work fixing this, that would be *great*."

The look she gets in response makes her glance reflexively at the princess' fists, half expecting to see another volley of pink sparkles ready to be thrown at her. There aren't any, but she can

tell it's a close call. "I am *not* letting you hurt her," the princess grits out, finally addressing Catra directly.

"Hurt her? I'm trying to *help* her!"

"So you keep saying, and *yet*, every time we see you, you just so *happen* to be tasering her!"

"*Again*, that was– She wanted to go *back* to the Horde because of the spell. You know, that thing I brought her here to *remove*?" The gleam of distrust in the princess' eyes might not be hard to understand, but Catra doesn't get how this conversation is happening from a simple *logical* perspective. "I know you don't think that highly of me, but how *stupid* would I have to be to go to all this trouble only to *not lift the spell* in the end? What would be the *point*?"

"I don't know!" Sparkles throws her hands up in the air in frustration, and Catra would swear the tips of her fingers glitter ominously for a second there. "I don't *know*, I'm not the Horde soldier here! Maybe you wanted to make sure it couldn't be undone! Maybe… Maybe you want to unlock She-Ra and use her for the Horde!"

The princess continues her tirade, presumably, but Catra can't hear her anymore.

Of course it all comes down to the stars-damned *She-Ra*. Figures that'd be the first thing she'd think of. It's probably their first priority, all of them. For all their talk of greater good, and being the good guys, they're the same, deep down –it's about winning, and what it takes to do it.

Some fucking friends Adora's made. Catra might not have been the *best* of friends at all times, but at least she cared about *Adora*.

"Don't worry, I'm not interested in your precious *She-Ra*," Catra all but snarls at her. "You'll get her back. But if you want that to happen, you need to back off and let me make it so *Adora* is okay."

To her surprise, the princess' jaw drops as her expression melts from aggression to something that is clearly taken aback. "I'm not doing this for– I mean, I don't care about–"

"*Glimmer*." The queen doesn't raise her voice, but the words radiate as much authority as if she'd shouted. "Enough."

"But *mom*!" Well, that's Catra's earlier hypotheses about her connections in the hierarchy confirmed. And the ones about her maturity, too, but that was already pretty much a given.

Queen Angella shakes her head, and exchanges a look with Castaspella. "Catra makes good points. If your earlier attempts are any indication," –Catra catches Bow rubbing at what looks suspiciously like teeth marks on the back of his hand and represses a snicker–"then Adora isn't going to be willing to listen to what any of us might say. A familiar face is the one that'll have the best chance of actually getting through to her."

"But we can't *trust* her!"

The queen's gaze turns to Catra and, to her embarrassment, she finds herself unable to hold the eye contact for more than a few moments. Her eyes drop to her own feet, staring through the floor without seeing it, as the queen's reply comes: "I didn't say we should. But… Sometimes goals can align, in surprising ways. I believe this is one of those times."

The weight of the woman's gaze is almost tangible –not necessarily threatening, but *too much*. She feels herself breathe a little easier when she catches her turning away out of the corner of her eye. "Castaspella, you're the most qualified to make the call," the queen says eventually.

Castaspella is gentle, but firm as she addresses the princess directly. "Glimmer, I understand your concern, but…" Her gaze trails back to Catra and she forces her face into an impenetrable blank slate. "Catra *is* right. And this spell is going to be tricky

enough as it is… We can't take the chance of Adora fighting us too."

She's expecting Sparkles to launch back into another rant, but thankfully, she only falls into a resigned, reluctant silence. Catra speaks instead, steeling herself and making sure no sign of her doubts are showing on her face as she nods towards Adora. "Alright then. Wake her up and let's end this."

But Castaspella hesitates, one hand hovering over Adora. "Actually," she starts, and something in Catra *really* doesn't like the way she says it, "I think I might have a better idea."

*

Catra really isn't sure this would classify as a *better* idea.

For a start, it's got her standing in the middle of a large, glowing rune circle that's been painstakingly traced onto the floor around the bed where Adora still sleeps peacefully.

She turns a little, and her heel brushes the edge of one of the glowing lines. It sends an odd, ticklish feeling rushing up her leg and she almost hisses. *Definitely* not a better idea.

Castaspella stands from where she's been crouching to draw the last of the intricate lines, brushing off her hands and taking in her work with a satisfied look. "Perfect." She glances at Catra. "All right?"

The scent and feel of pure *magic* that surround her have every single hair she has standing on edge –she is a lot of things, but all right is definitely not one of them. Still, no way she's giving that away. Odds are, Castaspella would try to call this off and find another way, and Catra's not letting Adora down now.

Plus, Sparkles is glowering at her from the other side of the room, and Catra is *not* going to give her the satisfaction of admitting just how much she hates this. She nods curtly.

"Good." Castaspella nods to herself a few times, and starts explaining the same thing she's already gone through at least four times while setting up the spell. "So. Since we need Adora to question her recollections, the best way is to *show* her how they're wrong. And to do that–"

"You're going to get inside her head," Catra completes.

"Yes. Well, no. Not me. Not you, either. Just–" She gestures at the circle. "This'll project the both of you into a mindscape of sorts. Adora's memories'll shape it, so it'll reflect what she remembers from that day. Once you're in there, it'll be up to you to make her see the inconsistencies in that projection. Most likely, the spell will fight back, reshape the memory so it fits better, but that will let *me* unravel it." She pauses, fidgeting a little with the edge of a sleeve. "Are you *sure* you're alright?"

She sounds genuinely concerned, and that's so much worse than if she didn't care. Catra grits her teeth. "I'm fine."

For a moment, the sorceress looks like she wants to argue, but something in Catra's expression must click with her –she closes her mouth and nods again, more determined. "All right then. Here goes."

With a deep breath, the sorceress closes her eyes and raises her hands. Instantly, the lines under Catra's feet start glowing brighter, from the faint glimmer they had to an almost blinding light that makes her squint. The light reaches *up*, forming a barrier along the edge of the circle, separating her and Adora from the others.

Through the bluish haze, Catra barely manages to catch a glimpse of Castapella's eyes opening, the brown replaced by a bright,

unnatural blue. The light around her flares, making her squeeze her own eyes shut reflexively.

When she opens them again, she's in Thaymor.

She knows it's not real; Castaspella has gone over the specifics enough times. She's acutely aware that all this is nothing more than an illusion but…

Well, for an illusion, it's a pretty good one.

The smoke burns her nose and makes her eyes water, and the world around her is a blur of chaos and shouts. Seeing it again brings back the same flood of adrenaline she'd had back then, at being faced with her first real battlefield after a lifetime of sterile, virtual training sims.

Except…

Except it's not quite *right*.

It takes her a second, notably because as it turns out, it's not about anything she sees; it's what she can't quite *look at*.

Everything around her *feels* correct –the Horde bots slowly, but inexorably flooding the streets, the torn up flags and banners, the heavy smoke–, but whenever she tries to focus on any specific part, she finds herself… staring past it. She knows the ruined buildings are there, knows the fleeing villagers must be nearby somewhere, because she was *there* and she remembers them. But she can't quite *see* them, her eyes gliding past without stopping. The final effect is destabilizing, like her entire peripheral vision has turned into a useless blur.

A useless blur that has a distinct red tint to it, she notices, before a yell of her name startles her out of her observations.

She doesn't get to track the source of it; the next second, something collides with her so abruptly all the breath rushes out of her, together with her balance. She braces herself for the fall to

the hard, dusty ground, but it never comes. Instead, the projectile she was just hit with grabs hold of her, strong arms wrapping around her and stabilizing her, and only then does it register that said projectile isn't a loose piece of rubble, but *Adora*.

The shock has Catra taking a step back, and, yep, that's Adora alright. She looks about the same she did when Catra saw her in the Black Garnet chamber barely a couple of weeks ago –that is, the perfect kidnapped Horde officer part. Her temple is more bruise than skin, her jacket's torn, and deep exhausted circles are dug under her eyes, but the bright blue of her gaze is nothing but *relief* as she gazes at Catra.

It's such a staggering contrast to the way Catra *remembers* Adora looking at her in Thaymor that she doesn't interrupt, even as Adora starts speaking: "You're here! You're actually, really here, I can't believe— Are you here for *me*? How did you guys even know where to find me?" Her gaze snags on Catra's uniform and her eyes go wide. "Catra, you're a *Force Captain*?"

She needs to say something. "Adora…"

"That's amazing, I mean, *I* knew you were good enough, but I'm *so* glad Shadow Weaver saw that too—"

"Adora."

"Oh, but you guys shouldn't have come, seriously, this is way too dangerous. I mean, it's good that you did, cause it made the leaders run away, and that let me escape, but it's still—"

"*Adora*!"

She finally stops her rambling, a hint of a sheepish expression peeking through the dust and grime on her face. "Sorry. I'm just… really happy to see you. It's been a long couple of weeks." She blinks. "Also I think I might be in shock a bit."

Yeah, that seems about right. Castaspella's instructions are ringing in Catra's head, but when she opens her mouth, she finds her

throat too tight to speak.

It's not helped when Adora uses her sudden silence to speak again, soft in a way Catra's only ever heard in the dark of the barracks: "I just– Let's go home, yeah?" She reaches a hand out towards her and everything in Catra's head *stops*.

Just for one moment, she considers it.

If she doesn't make Adora confront her memories, then Castaspella won't be able to lift the spell. Most likely, that'll lead to some kind of princess council, to decide what to do. Considering how laughable the security of the palace has proven to be, that should give her plenty of time to free Adora and get the hell out of there. All she'll have to say is that Adora was right, that Catra was under a magic spell she finally broke out of, and they'll be on their way to the Fright Zone in no time. Sure, Shadow Weaver will be a problem, but when isn't she? And with Adora with her, they'll make it through the worst of the immediate consequences.

Plus, soon enough, it won't even matter; with the two of them Force Captains, it'll only be a matter of time before they're out of the sorceress' reach. And then *they'*ll be calling the shots, together.

Just like they always said they would.

And all Catra has to do is *let it happen*. Just stand there, take Adora's hand, and she'll have everything she's ever wanted.

Adora's voice comes again, crashing through the vision like a fully armored tank. "Oh and, you know. Thanks for looking out for me."

The wakeup call is jarring, to say the least.

The words are sincere, and that's the problem. Adora's expression is open and grateful, and just like that, Catra knows she can't do it. Just like that, she hears Adora's voice again, from back in the woods, barely a few hours ago, her words hurt and confused.

It's just that we promised!

Sure, Thaymor is where that promise was shattered in a million sharp, cutting shards. It's where it all broke apart.

But it doesn't have to be; not this time. Not again.

She won't let it.

Too bad that means driving Adora away for good.

The red around them seems to flare for a moment, and Catra steels herself.

"Has it?" she asks, voice flat.

Adora blinks, looking like she might be wondering whether her head injury's worse off than she thought. "Has it...what?"

"Been a long couple of weeks."

And now she's looking at Catra like she's wondering if *she* doesn't have a head injury. "Uh. Yes?"

"Cause *I*'d say it's only been a long few hours. Barely. Less than a day, for sure."

Adora frowns, but doesn't interrupt her, and Catra forces her features into a cynical smirk. "Honestly, Adora, I'm hurt. Do you really think it'd take us that long to come after you? What kind of friend do you think I am?"

The red flares; this time she's sure of it. It encroaches on her field of vision, making her take a reflexive step back, but as quickly as it arrives, the tint turns to bright blue. It's just a second, and then the color palette goes back to normal, but it's there, and as awful as this is, the thought that she's undoing Shadow Weaver's careful work is *very* satisfying.

"Catra, I don't—" Adora looks the same she did in that training room, confused and *scared*, and it takes everything in Catra to remember that it's a good sign.

"Come *on*, Adora! I know observation isn't exactly your forte, but look around! Does this really look like a fortress to you?"

Adora looks like she's going to argue, but, to Catra's surprise, she ends up doing as she says and *looks*. She frowns as she stares at the nearest ruins, and Catra can only *gape* as the rubble surrounding them starts to change. Outlined in faint red, the ruins of what were clearly civilian residences become blockier, darker. Light rock turns to darker metal, twisted out of shape but still recognizable as military issued.

She bites back a curse, as she remembers Castaspella's words about the spell fighting back. Even miles away, Shadow Weaver is still making her life difficult.

She speaks again, gesturing to the buildings further in the distance, that the spell hasn't managed to start affecting. "This place isn't a rebel stronghold, Adora! It's not even an outpost. It's just… a village. A civilian space."

The words make Adora turn back towards her, confusion and something Catra can't quite name creasing her forehead. "What? But… That wouldn't make sense. Why would the Horde attack a village? There's nothing to gain from that."

Catra shrugs. "Because they can. Because it's what they… what we do"

"No." Adora takes a step back, shaking her head, but Catra sees the same hesitation that was on her face back in that sparring room. "No, that's not– The Horde does what it has to do to win, but it's all… It's to make Etheria a better place, it's…"

"A better place for Hordak, maybe."

Catra can't help a spark of curiosity. There's something in the way Adora says those words… She'd noticed it already, just barely, back in the Fright Zone, but now, with Castaspella's talk of locks and influence, it's more noticeable.

They're very… flat.

Adora was always the more committed of the two of them, when it came to the Horde. Growing up, Catra hadn't needed long to figure out that most of what they were told was bullshit, a steady stream of propaganda. She'd known Adora was a bit more convinced, but it hadn't sunk in just *how much* she'd believed it all until, well… Until she'd *stopped* believing it.

In hindsight, thinking back on their years together, it'd been easier to see: the steady, solid drive with which Adora did everything, always strived to be the best, to encourage the other cadets… Of course, part of it was just what Adora was like, but it'd suddenly become clear that a lot of it was also the simple fact that Adora believed in what she was fighting for.

This, on the other hand? This isn't quite it. It reminds her of her blank stare back in Force Captain orientation, a few days ago. There's no sign of Adora's usual determination, and the words aren't her own, unlike when they were kids. They're just bland, rehashed, word-for-word propaganda. Like she doesn't really *believe* it. Whatever the spell's done to her empathy, it's affected her belief in the Horde, too.

Ironically, it might make unravelling the false memory even easier.

Of course, easier doesn't mean *done*. Adora is still, after all, stubborn as hell. Catra watches as she shakes her head, briefly squeezing her eyes shut. "No, you're wrong. This isn't… It's not what–"

Still. The good thing about having lived through this once is that Catra knows *exactly* what to say –all she has to do is reuse

Adora's own words. It's not even going to be hard; they haven't left her head since.

"Adora, just listen to me. Everything they told us when we were kids was a lie; Hordak, the Horde, Shadow Weaver… They've been lying to us, all along. Just *look* at it!"

"But it's–" Adora doesn't look disbelieving anymore, just horribly, terribly lost. It's probably progress, but it really doesn't feel like it. Her voice is so *small* when she speaks again. "But how's that possible? How could we not know?"

Speak for yourself.

Catra bites back the retort in the nick of time. How could Adora not know, indeed. Catra certainly did –she'd known it with every choking spell, with every glacial word about how *inadequate* she was.

Of course, Adora'd never had to worry about *that*; the natural consequence of being perfect in every way already. And clearly, seeing it happen hadn't been enough.

Well, not when it was happening to Catra, at least.

The red around them flashes again, turning the smoke into a crimson fog, and she swallows the words down. None of that is going to help, but suddenly, she knows what will. Adora might not have cared about what happened to *her*, but she's pretty sure there isn't a spell on this planet that could handle the girl's insufferable hero complex.

And so, she gestures towards where the chaos seems to be the worst. "Come *on* Adora. These people need help. *Your* help. Are you really going to let them down?"

It works; her head snaps in that direction, and in a second, it's like a filter's been lifted: amongst the noise of machinery and weaponry, she can distinctly hear the screaming of the villagers.

The red haze comes again, but she'd swear it's lighter, and the noise doesn't diminish.

Adora doesn't take off running, but Catra sees the way her posture tenses. "They're hurting them," she says, almost like in a daze.

"Yeah."

"I can't– I can't let that happen."

Catra's smile is genuine, if bitter. "I know." She braces herself for the sight of her best friend walking away from her –again.

Except Adora does the last thing she expects; she turns back instead. "What about you?"

Catra blinks. "What about me?"

Adora doesn't respond, her gaze still lost. And slowly, she reaches a hand out.

Ha.

Catra takes a step back.

"Oh no. I'm not going with you." The smile *hurts* now, but she can't stop it. "That's not how it goes. Remember?"

And suddenly, Adora does.

Catra gasps as the scene around them flashes, a succession of red and blue that continues blinding her even after she's shut her eyes. As suddenly as it came on, the light vanishes, and she's–

–she's standing, looking down on Adora, curled up on the floor, a stun baton still crackling with energy in her hand–

–she's smiling, smug and self-satisfied, as reinforcements roll in, circling the archer that's just attacked her–

–she's watching, mute in shock, as a tall, glowing figure makes her way to the center of the fight, cutting through tanks and canons like they're nothing more than day-old ration bars–

–she's standing in the smoke, only capable of staring as the glow recedes, and the figure becomes Adora.

She has to run, she knows. The others have retreated, and soon enough this place will be swarming with rebels. It's not safe to stay here, not without backup. But she can't move, can't even *process*–

Adora looks up, and with a jolt, Catra snaps out of it –this isn't real. It's a memory, a dream, shifting pictures and glowy lights. Only, that particular realization is almost instantly overshadowed by another one, as her gaze meets Adora's.

The spell is gone.

She knows it, with a certainty she's rarely felt about anything. Shadow Weaver's spell is gone, undone for good. She knows it, because she *knows* that look in Adora's eyes –that mix of anger, sadness, *betrayal*. It's how Adora's looked at her every time since Thaymor, the *real* Thaymor, until she came back to the Fright Zone. Under the spell, there was no trace of it.

Catra did not miss it.

It's just that we promised!

Catra's not the same person she was when this first happened. But this is a memory, and she knows the next steps.

Catra turns, and she runs.

*

The first thing that registers is *yelling*.

"– I *knew* it! I knew we should never have let that woman go!"

Instinctively, her muscles lock up, and she's ready to bolt, ready to get away from the sound of *anger*, of the danger it usually spells. She's on the floor, a part of her notes distantly, a light colored, gleaming thing, but she doesn't focus on it. Instead, she snaps her head up, forcing her vision to clear.

It takes a moment for the surroundings to click, for the memories of Bright Moon to snap back into place. Even once they do, she only gives them a passing consideration, more focused on finding the source of the noise.

It takes her less than a second to identify it as Castaspella. The sorceress is pacing the room as she rants, and her eyes are *blazing*. Gone is the soft-spoken, awkward woman that made Catra wonder just how she'd managed to get to the spot of head sorceress –the person in front of her is radiating barely-leashed power.

And *boy* is she angry. It's not the cold, sharp as a blade anger that Shadow Weaver displayed –this is bright and *scalding*, but it's fury all the same and Catra finds herself shrinking in on herself reflexively, even as she scrambles to sit up, waiting for the brunt of that anger to fall on her, on whatever she did wrong, whatever she did that messed up the spell–

Except that when the actual words start registering, she realizes they're not aimed at her. "I am telling you, Angella, she should have been locked up, thrown in a cell and left there to *rot*, and instead what did they do? They let her get away, and now *look* at what she's done! She's done it again, Angella, she's found new *children* to hurt, and she's done it again, and it's our fault! We should have stopped her, we should have–"

It takes a few more seconds for everything to click in Catra's head. The sorceress isn't angry *at* her.

She's angry… *for* her? Her and Adora, just Adora, just Catra, it doesn't matter. The only person this woman is interested in destroying right now is *Shadow Weaver*.

The thought doesn't compute completely, but it's enough to let her adrenaline levels drop a little, to calm the flight instincts that just kicked in. Castaspella is still pacing, looking like she's ready to march to the Fright Zone and burn it to the ground, but Catra's fear is gone, leaving her free to try and catch her breath. Slowly, she struggles to her feet, using the side of the bed as support – her head is *spinning*, the acrid smoke of the battlefield still clinging to her lungs.

Distantly, she notices Sparkles on the other side of the room. She's seemingly trying to speak in between the sorceress' angry sentences, but all her attempts are going unnoticed. Eventually, she falls back on her usual strategy, and all but yells: "Aunt Casta! Did it work?"

Castaspella stops mid-sentence, thrown off, and that gives room for Catra to respond. "Yeah," she says in a rasp. "It worked."

Her voice is *way* too feeble for her tastes, but it's apparently audible enough: everyone turns to look at her. In her state, Catra isn't quite sure she can parse their expressions. She decides to focus her energy on staying upright, instead.

Castaspella's is easy though: the wide-eyed concern is obvious, if jarring. She makes a beeline towards her, stopping a few feet away. Her hands are vaguely outstretched towards Catra, like she stopped herself just short of actually touching her, and Catra is pathetically grateful –she really doesn't want anyone getting too close right now.

"Catra, are you alright?"

She's saved from having to respond by Sparkles' next question. "Are you *sure*?"

If she didn't feel approximately one gust of wind away from passing out, Catra would have rolled her eyes.

Thankfully, Castaspella takes over. The concern on the woman's face eases, replaced with a glint that is pure *victory*.

"*Yes*," she confirms. "Shadow Weaver is a lot of things," –she looks like she'd like nothing more to list all of them– "but she isn't that good. I was right; it was only a memory lock. Basic, crude, and *horrifying* to put on a child. On anyone, really. The influence was part of it."

Her eyes flash in anger, and she turns towards where Adora is still peacefully lying. "She locked Adora's perception. By blocking the memory of the first time Adora *truly* questioned the Horde, she made it so she wouldn't be able to really register anything that showed it in a negative light. It's *wrong*, and–"

She trails off, long enough to take a deep breath. Reaching forward, she gently smoothes out a few of the hairs that have escaped Adora's ponytail, and Catra is struck with how gentle the gesture is, compared to the possessiveness Shadow Weaver always displayed.

"Adora's strength," she continues, softer, "lies in how passionate she is. Shadow Weaver thought she could use that, redirect it for the Horde's cause, instead of against. Goes to show she never understood anything." The words are accompanied by a disdainful snort that makes Catra crack a smile before she can help it. "Adora cares about *people* –she wants to protect, to help. Shadow Weaver stopped her from seeing the harm the Horde was causing, but she never could have changed that." A pause, as Castaspella tilts her head. "All she ended up doing was muting those instincts. Burying them under the spell, burying *Adora* under her influence."

The fury eases for a moment, and the woman almost looks *sad*. "It must have been… Stars, poor Adora. It must have been a nightmare; like nothing was real, like nothing actually mattered."

A silence, heavy and tense, falls over the room.

The words make sense, technically; they actually match pretty well with what Catra had put together, back in the projection. Adora clearly hadn't believed in, well, *everything*, the way she used to before. On that front, Castaspella's explanation seems perfectly reasonable.

What Catra can't quite reconcile, however, is everything *else*. The nightmares; the scared, almost desperate energy Adora had exuded during their argument in the sparring room; the way she'd tried so hard to snap Catra out of a nonexistent spell… None of that matches with words like *muted* and *nothing mattered*.

"But it's gone now, right?"

Sparkles' voice sounds surprisingly small, with none of the grating overconfidence Catra's learnt to associate with it over the past few hours. It's enough to snap her out of it, though.

It doesn't matter, really, why Adora said the things she did under that spell. It *doesn't*, because if the way Adora looked at her in that projection is any indication –and Catra knows it is–, well…
"Yeah," Catra says. "It's gone now."

As if on cue, Adora stirs lightly.

The reaction is immediate: Bow and Sparkles rush to her bedside, followed closely by Castaspella and the queen, who stands back but still looks incredibly relieved. As she steps away, Catra vaguely picks up a few exchanged words, whispered questions and reassurances, and, in between that, the faintest suggestion of Adora's voice.

She stands there for a second, a few steps removed, taking the picture in.

And then she slips out the very unguarded door.

It's not just the door; the hallways also have *abysmal* security, she notes distantly, but it's detached, a passing thought through the numbness –just one thing for her brain to focus on that's not… *anything* else. It'd probably be useful to know, too, as a Horde soldier.

Shame it doesn't actually matter now.

Testament to how out of it she is: she doesn't hear Bow following her until he calls her name.

For some reason, she finds herself stopping. She turns, tilting her head as she watches him advance.

He stops a few steps away. "What are you doing?"

She stretches both arms, gesturing at the empty hallway around them and, more specifically, at the large door at the end that leads outside –she hopes. This place is *massive*. "What's it look like, arrow boy?"

He stays silent, which takes her by surprise, because she might only have known him for a couple of hours, but if one thing's *very* clear, it's that he's not one for silence –none of them are, here.

But he just stares, and it suddenly clicks in her head. "Oh." She blinks. "Right. I'm a prisoner of war. Forgot about that." A beat. "Didn't you say I could leave if I helped fix Adora?"

He jumps, and Catra's immediately certain he had *also* forgotten she is technically a prisoner. "No, that's not… I mean, yeah, you're free to go but—"

"Cool. See ya."

"No, wait, it's just—" Why is Catra letting him talk? She has no idea. She puts it on the weird haze she hasn't been able to shake since stepping inside that stupid circle.

Bow sighs. “Look, I know the Horde is your home, but you don’t *have* to go back there.”

That snaps through the numbness. She laughs, and it’s real laughter too –only a little bit hysterical. “How much of a death wish do you think I have? I’m not going back to the Horde.”

He blinks. “You’re not going back to the Horde?”

She gestures towards the direction they both came from, towards the room where Adora still is. “*Hello*? I kidnapped their prized Force Captain and literally hand delivered her to the enemy, accessorily furnishing said enemy with a literal *magical warrior princess*. No, I’m not going back to the Horde.”

It looks like it’s still not clicking in his head. “But… where, then?”

She fixes her gaze on a piece of pastel mosaic on the wall. Stars, what is it with this place and the color pink? It’s everywhere. “I’ll find my own way.” She forces a breath in, and out. “I always do.”

“You could st—“

He cuts off mid-sentence when she lifts her head and *stares* – good. At least *one* of Adora’s new best friends has some kind of self-preservation instincts. Not that it’ll be enough to make up for Adora’s complete absence of it, probably, but it’s a start.

Speaking of. Hating herself for it, for what it gives away, Catra nods towards the hallway and asks: “She’s fine, right? It *did* work?” She *knows* it has, but–

“Yeah,” Bow confirms and the last of the weight leaves her shoulders. Granted, it only moves to the pit of her stomach, but it’s still progress.

She nods. “Good.” Spinning on her heel, she starts walking towards what she hopes is the exit.

“Adora would want you to stay.”

The words still her, but don't make her turn around, don't make her say anything.

At her silence, Bow fumbles a bit. "I mean… I don't really know what the history is, between you two, and it's not like Adora talked a lot about her time with the Horde, but I think she'd want you to. I mean, I spent two hours with her earlier and she was *terrified* that we were going to hurt you. She clearly cares about you a lot."

Her smile is sardonic and it almost hurts –it cuts at the corner of her mouth. "Sure. All she needs to care about me is to get mind wiped and brainwashed."

Bow's frown is almost audible. "Uh… Well, considering what Castaspella said about the spell and the whole muting thing, it seems to me like it's more that she cared about you *through* the mindwiping and brainwashing."

She–

She didn't think of it like that. She can't afford to think of it like that, not when she knows he's wrong. No matter how horribly, terribly tempting it might be.

Bow is still talking. "All that to say… I really think she'd want you to stay."

She takes a second to make sure her voice will be steady when she speaks. "Yeah, well. Like I told Sparkles. You don't know her like I do." The words definitely don't have the same bite they did when she tossed them at the princess earlier, but she pretends not to notice.

Thankfully, he does, too. "Look." She hears him take a step closer and tenses up, acutely aware of how *touchy* this bunch seems to be, but he stops a few steps away. "*Clearly*, you're not a bad person. I mean, like you said, you brought Adora back to us—"

At that, she turns around. “I didn’t do it for you,” she all but hisses. “I didn’t do it for you, *or* for your stupid rebellion.”

But Bow doesn’t flinch, doesn’t waver. If anything, his expression gets softer. “All the more reason to stay, then, isn’t it?”

She needs to go. She needs to go *now*, before all the very good reasons she has to leave evaporate under his kind eyes and stupid, ridiculously naive words. He has no idea what he’s talking about; he didn’t *see* it. She squares her shoulders, shoots him one more icy stare and turns around, intent on walking and not stopping until she is *far* away from all this.

And yet… she’s only a few steps away when she hears the words come out of her own mouth: “Look out for her, yeah? Not just *She-Ra* or whatever. Adora, too. She needs it more than she looks.”

“We will.”

She finds she believes him, and breathes a little easier for it.

And so, Catra leaves.

Chapter End Notes

> me looking at my outline as I start this chapter: oh nice, this one should be short and easy, it won’t take me too long to write!
> me, emerging four weeks later with 5 separate (and completely different) drafts, one completely unrelated one-shot, and a final version sitting at 11k aka by far the longest chapter so far:
>
> i did consider splitting this into 2, but also it has been four (4) weeks and i need it out of my life so jfhgkd
>
> Also, fun fact, this fic’s now got a B plot that can be summarized as “Castaspella marches on the Fright Zone and murders shadow weaver with her bare hands and maybe a

couple of knitting needles”. I won’t write it bc I feel like it may distract slightly from the main plot but it is 100% canon to this story, just so y’all know

We’re almost done! Next chapter should be the last but I am putting the usual disclaimer of it maybe ending up split into 2 if it ends up deviating too much from the outline. Which, considering I have /never/ written something where the characters are as reluctant to follow an outline as they are in this, is honestly somewhat likely

Thanks for reading, and a big ty again to everyone who commented and/or left kudos! i know i can be a bit slow to reply, but i appreciate every single one very much 💕 And as always, I’d love to hear what you thought!

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

shoving the chapter count under a rug i can explain

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"This is the fucking *worst*!"

The voice almost startles Catra out of the tree she's been half napping in. She wasn't fully asleep, which is the only reason she manages to stabilize herself before toppling to the ground a dozen feet below.

Still, not fully asleep doesn't mean fully *awake* either, and so it takes a few seconds for the voice to click in her head. Well, there's that, and the very simple fact that there's no way –*no way*– she should be hearing it, right now.

But no, it really is. It takes a bit of almost-dangerous leaning over the empty air to catch enough of a look through the dense foliage, but quickly enough, the incomprehensible truth is unavoidable.

Sparkles is here.

She's also clearly not *happy* to be. With the leaves obscuring her field of vision, Catra can just about make out the exasperated way she trudges forward. Her cape flutters dramatically when she drops down to sit on a flat rock, her back to Catra.

Her voice carries just fine, though. "I mean it. This is stupid."

"Glimmer…" Bow, his tone chiding but patient. A few seconds later, he comes into view, standing next to his friend.

Catra blinks a few times. Has she lost it? Did she fall out of the tree during her nap and is now mid-concussion?

She hadn't even especially *wanted* to rest –she still has a way to cover before she's far enough from Bright Moon and the Fright Zone to feel comfortable. Only, after three days of near constant marching, she'd had to admit that running on ten-minute micro naps would probably just take *longer* than stopping to actually rest. She'd picked one of the trees with the most leaves to minimize the risk of anyone seeing her, climbed as high as was comfortable, and tried to doze off for a few hours.

Except that now she's staring at two people that she supposedly left three days' worth of walking behind, and is *severely* regretting that decision. She's pretty sure she's not hallucinating, but the alternative isn't much more comforting. Without even getting into *why* they'd be here, she doesn't get *how* they can be. If anything, she had one hell of a head start.

"I know," the princess says, the annoyance seeping out of her tone. "I know, it's just… Ugh, it feels pointless. And I can't even *do* anything, because I need to have enough magic to teleport us *back*."

Ah. Right.

How does Catra keep forgetting about the fucking *teleporting* thing?

She's distracted, fuming at herself for the oversight, and so she misses Bow's reply until one of the words catches her attention. "–but you know it's important to Adora."

Catra's head snaps up, and she ends up having to dig her claws into the soft bark of the branch beneath her to keep her balance.

"… But I know it's important to Adora," Sparkles repeats a few seconds later with a sigh.

Okay, so Adora is why they're out there. That's fine. That doesn't mean anything. There's *any* number of reasons why they might be out there for Adora. It doesn't mean it's got anything to do with her.

"But," Sparkles continues suddenly, "I also know that if *Catra* doesn't want to be found –which seems to be the case, considering that she *left*–, then we're not going to find her."

Okay. So maybe it's got something to do with her.

Bow pats the top of her head sympathetically. "Maybe not. But it's still worth a try."

"If you say so."

The words sound final, but Bow just stands silently next to her and, sure enough, after a few seconds, she continues. "Okay, no. Cause, it's not even like she's nice or anything! She's the *worst*! I mean, seriously? The whole, *oh look at me, I'm so snarky and rude, and annoying* thing?"

"She did save Adora."

"But did she have to be so *annoying* about it?" Catra has to hold in a snicker at how aggravated the princess' tone is.

Bow sounds like he's also holding back laughter. "Maybe not. But you know, if I'd left, you'd have wanted to go after me, too, right?"

She lifts her head, and even though Catra can't see her face, it's not hard to imagine the *duh* look she's probably shooting his way. "Except you wouldn't have *left*, because you're a rational, normal person?"

"Okay, maybe not. But the point stands. It's like Adora said; they've known each other since they were kids. Of course she wants to try."

"I guess." To say she sounds unconvinced is an understatement. "It's just… The way she *acted*, like… Like…" She splutters angrily for a few seconds. "Like we don't care about Adora? Like we only cared about She-Ra, or something, that's… That's just *insane*!"

Bow seems uneasy. “Kind of understandable though.”

“No it *isn’t*?” Sparkles sounds aghast. “We’re the *good* guys! We don’t befriend people because they’re… convenient! That’s not how it works! That’s not how it should *ever* work!”

“Guess the Horde isn’t the greatest place to grown up in,” Bow concludes diplomatically. Catra distantly notices that she’s dug grooves into the branch beneath her with her claws, but she doesn’t retract them either. “I mean, from what Adora said… I’m not that surprised she’d think that. Or that she’d act accordingly.”

There’s a few seconds’ pause as the princess tilts her head, studying him. “You like her, don’t you? You do. Why? It’s not like she was much nicer to you than to anyone else.”

Catra can’t see his face, but his easy smile’s audible. “I don’t know. I guess she just reminds me of someone.”

“Who?’

There’s a beat. “Just someone.”

The princess is not so easily deterred. “Bow, *who*?”

This time her friend laughs. “Honestly? You.”

Catra’s hiss is thankfully covered up by the offended, high-pitched yell Sparkles lets out. “*What*?”

Bow laughs, bright and amused. “Come on, we should find Adora. Clearly, the villager was wrong, but there’s still a few towns we should check out.”

“What do you *mean* she reminds you of me?”

“Plus, I really don’t think we should leave Adora on her own for too long. There were some shady types in that village, and that spell did a number on her, even if she pretends it didn’t. I don’t want her getting into trouble she can’t get out of.”

Sparkles is still spluttering, but she stands to follow Bow as he starts walking again. There's any number of things Catra could try to focus on right now –*Adora is looking for her* is a prime contender–, but before she can even begin to try and sort through the mess in her head, she feels the back of her neck prickle.

With a quiet intake of breath, she silently flips into a crouch, muscles locking into place. She doesn't know what the threat is yet, not consciously, but years of training combined with her natural instincts leave her with no doubt that there is one. She scans the clearing below, gaze flitting from patch to patch, ears straining.

There.

It's barely a flicker; a reflection of metal between the leaves on the other side of the clearing. Nothing particularly threatening, but it's *out of place*, and out of place is what she's been looking out for since she left Bright Moon.

See, the thing about leaving the Horde is that you *do not do it*. There had been defectors, over the years; a slightly nicer than usual training instructor that had vanished, a specific guard they never saw on duty again, or, on a more notable occasion, one of the cadets in the squadron who lived in the barracks nearest to theirs. All these people had made a run for it, because they were too *weak*, because they were selfish enough to betray the greater ideals for their own personal gain.

Or at least, that was what all the cadets had been told when these people came back. Because that was the other thing about leaving the Horde: even if you did manage it, it was never for long. Not because you changed your mind –simply because there was nowhere to hide.

Wherever you went, the Horde *found* you.

And once they did, well… Catra doesn't know the details, but she doesn't need to. All the people that were brought back were never

seen again, and that was enough to convince her to be *careful* as she trekked through the woods.

It's not like the Horde has outposts everywhere; after all, much of the woods is still rebel territory. But they don't need to have deployed elements to have *reach* –people who aren't technically part of the Horde, but who don't mind working with them either, for the right price.

As a cadet, her training was focused on more *concrete* topics – disarming, shooting straight, and avoiding getting shot herself–, but she'd always found the higher-level, strategy issues much more interesting. And so, she'd kept an eye on how the superior officers worked; it hadn't been hard to put together that this kind of mercenaries were a massive asset, so long as you were clever enough not to get played. From what she'd gathered sneaking around and listening in on meetings, the Horde used these contacts for all sorts of things: information, mostly, but also on occasion for more *physical* jobs, like grabbing Rebellion members for interrogations.

Or to find and bring back defectors.

It's why she's been so relentless for the past few days –the further she gets from Bright Moon, and by extension, from the Fright Zone, the less likely she'd be to run into one of those. Not that she doesn't think she could handle it, but she'd rather avoid having to take the chance at all.

Bow's words echo in her head –*clearly the villagers were wrong*. She'd been too in shock to really process them earlier, but the implications now fall on her like a ton of brick. These three –the three *obvious* rebels, one of them a known defector, another one a literal princess– have been walking around villages asking about Catra.

She grits her teeth as she realizes that all her care in covering up her traces was wasted effort. She might as well have been

wearing a sign, thanks to them – *Horde defector this way! Follow the signposts!*

You'd think Adora would have known to be at least vaguely careful, but odds are the possibility didn't even cross her mind. Turning into a warrior princess that could smash tanks into scrap metal without breaking a sweat has its advantages, and one of them is not having to worry about mercenaries trying to track you down. That, together with the way she'd stayed within the heart of the rebellion, had kept her out of reach of any bounty hunter.

Catra, on the other hand, magic-less and traveling alone in more remote parts of the woods? She'd be a prime target.

And now, thanks to the three rebel idiots, she's an *easy to track down* target –and so are they. After all, rebel fighters probably fetch as good a price as a defector, especially central ones like, oh, the *daughter of the stars-damned queen of Bright Moon*.

Movement, on the other side of the clearing –barely a shift, but with no wind to have caused it.

Slowly, she leans forward, trying to catch a better look. If she can get an idea of how many they are, and how much of a threat they *actually* are, then she can figure out her next move.

Only, Sparkles, completely oblivious to the trap that's slowly closing around her and the archer, is *still talking*, fast and high-pitched and *so fucking loud.* Because of that, Catra can't rely on her hearing, which is by far one of the worst blind spots she can be in.

And because of that, she can't act before it's too late.

Bow reaches the edge of the clearing, and suddenly everything flashes *green*. The smell of charring hits Catra at the same time as his shout of pain, and she tenses, breath going shallow in anticipation.

Her view is still obstructed, but she manages to catch sight of the way he stumbles back, clutching his arm to his chest. Sparkles follows, eyes wide as she asks if he's okay. That's not what Catra focuses on, though.

The green tint stays in the air, although dimmer, and a tilt of her head shows her the reason: stretched between the trees surrounding the clearing are a succession of green, sparkling horizontal lines. Something heavy drops to the pit of her stomach –dread mixed with recognition.

Perimeter lines.

Those things had defined her entire childhood –literally. They were all over the Fright Zone, adjustable energy beams that made perfect boundary lines. If she squints, she can make out the small black delimiters set into each tree trunk: hand-sized generators with dials that would let you adjust the repulsion –and therefore pain– level. The most common use was as boundary lines in training areas, since the singeing pain they delivered on contact made a great deterrent against cheating in assessments. That was especially true with some particularly sadistic instructors who always picked the more painful settings.

From the way Bow is hunched over, clutching his arm and leaning against his friend to stay standing, it seems whoever set those up went for the higher end of the pain scale, too.

With their targets incapacitated, the people in question don't waste any more time and spring out of their hiding spots around the clearing. There's two of them –a tall woman with shoulder-length white blond hair, and a lizardfolk with deep grey scales–, plus a hip-high bot. None of them are in uniform, nor familiar, but the bot is clearly Horde-issued, a metal sphere tottering on spindly legs. The blasters and stun batons they're carrying are just as recognizable, and finish confirming her assumptions.

Whoever they are, they're working with the Horde.

Slowly, carefully, Catra starts inching back towards the trunk of the tree. She needs to get out of here, and her best chance is *now*, while they're distracted with the two rebels. The start of her climb down means she loses visual completely on what's happening, but she can still hear everything.

"Well, would you look at that? Looks like these poor kids have gone and gotten themselves lost." The woman's voice is high-pitched and nasal, and Catra finds herself disliking her even more than she already did.

"How unlucky," says a raspier, deeper voice, with the fakest sympathy she's ever heard. She scrambles down from branch to branch, making sure no moving leaf or creak can give her away. "Good thing we're here to help out, huh?"

"Stay back." Sparkles' voice is steady, but Catra's hyper aware right now, and she doesn't miss the tension in it. With a wince, she jumps the rest of the distance to the ground, silently landing on her feet. The smaller, dense bushes around her tree of choice keep her invisible from the clearing, thankfully.

"Oh, don't be like that. We're just trying to help out." There's a pause, and in the silence, Catra catches the sound of a faint, almost crackly sound. Together with what she knows of the princess, she assumes the girl's fingers have most likely started glowing ominously.

That suspicion is quickly confirmed when the woman continues. "Now, none of that. Wouldn't want you to *run out of magic*, right?"

As quietly as she can, Catra makes her way through the dense branches, until she can catch a glimpse of the scene ahead in between leaves. By the tension in Sparkles' shoulders, she's just realized that the two have been listening to them all along. Catra can practically *see* her running through the previous conversation to find whether they said anything incriminating.

Catra doesn't need to; she knows the answer is yes.

"What do you want?" Bow, this time. He was clearly aiming for steady, but the pain is audible, a strain in his voice. She can't help a sympathetic wince –she knows how bad these lines can hit. She's gotten caught in them more times than she cares to count.

The bot beeps a couple of times, and the lizardfolk whistles lowly in response. "You're right, yeah, that arm looks bad. You should get it checked out, kid."

"Lucky," his partner continues, "we know just the place."

"We're good, thanks," Sparkles bites back, and the two laugh, grating. The bot adds a quick staccato series of beeps.

"Yeah, that wasn't a question," he says. He takes a step forward, and the blaster at his hip catches the light. "As it happens, we've got some friends who'd *love* to meet you guys."

"Yeah, two Rebellion fighters like you? A *princess*? People would do a lot to talk to you." The woman advances too, and her own weapon falls in Catra's line of sight as she drops a hand to the hilt –some kind of whip that looks annoyingly cool.

"Or at least pay a lot."

"Which is the part we're interested in."

The tension crystallizes and holds in the air –lightning about to strike the ground. Catra can almost taste the fight that's about to break out, at the back of her throat. She needs to *get out of here*.

Except she finds that she is not moving.

Why is she not moving? This is the nightmare scenario: bounty hunters that will drag her back to the Fright Zone with no hesitation. It's what she's been running from for the past three days, and now is her best chance to get out and get as far away as possible, while their attention is fully on the rebels.

Only… from here, Catra sees more than she did from up in the tree. And so she can't help but notice the way Sparkles' fists aren't glowing quite as brightly as usual, or how Bow is still cradling his injured arm and therefore unable to reach for his bow –which, what a *stupid* weapon choice, something that needs *two* arms. Then again, from the way he's barely standing as he leans against his friend, she doubts he could wield a one-handed weapon either right now.

But that's not her problem. They're Rebellion fighters –they can take care of themselves. She needs to go. Now.

The bot fires a warning shot at the ground in front of the rebels and she takes a reflexive step back, freezing when she feels more than hears a twig break somewhere behind her. The next second, there's someone at her back and the unmistakable two-pronged end of a stun baton digging into her side.

"Well, well, well," calls an unfamiliar voice from behind her, loud enough to be heard by the others. "Look who was going to miss the party."

The man who has her forces her forward into the clearing, and if she wasn't being threatened, she would *kick* herself.

Three of them. There's *three* of them. Of course they wouldn't just leave an open escape route, she should have *known* there'd be another one blocking the rebels off.

The two others congratulate him, but she's too busy pretending not to notice Sparkles and Bow's taken aback expressions to really listen. Her captor stops a few feet into the clearing, grabbing her shoulder with his free hand and digging the stun baton into her side a bit more forcefully. "Looks like today's a good day, friends," he calls. "Defectors *and* rebels, my, my."

They're gloating, all of them, certain of their victory, and that more than anything gives Catra hope. After all, if there's one thing

she knows, is that you should never claim your victory before you're really, *really* sure of it.

Still. This is far from ideal. She scans the clearing, looking for anything that'll give her an edge, and blinks when she ends up meeting the princess' gaze.

Her eyes are wide, still clearly surprised, but something shifts in them when Catra looks at her. A flicker of determination flashes, and she looks forcefully down to the ground, and then back up at her.

It takes a second to click; *is she really–*

Their gazes cross and *yeah, she is*. Catra nods, the movement barely there, and the princess starts mouthing something that, in her shock, takes her a second to decipher: *three, two…*

On *zero*, Catra ducks.

It's sudden enough that her captor doesn't manage to hold her up, and he doesn't get to recover from his surprise: the princess instantly sends a volley of bright energy blasts in his direction – Catra feels them singe the back of her head. He lets go of her with a yell as he goes flying backwards.

Not wasting a second, she shoots her elbow backwards as hard as she can, snarling when it meets flesh, and flips round, hand grasping the wrist that's still holding the baton and *twisting*. He lets go, and she catches the weapon before it can hit the ground, immediately digging it into his ribs and pressing the switch. The sizzle of electricity fills the air, and he goes down, out cold.

When she turns back around, Sparkles is still shooting, using blasts to keep the two others from advancing, but it's not a viable long term strategy. The bot sends a string of shots in their direction, and Bow yanks her out of the way, sending the both of them stumbling.

Catra gets to them just in time; she grabs Bow before he can collapse and bring the princess down with him, but he's all but passed out. Out of options, she helps him sink down to the ground, back to the boulder Sparkles had been sitting on earlier. It's not exactly an airtight barricade, but at least he's out of the direct line of fire.

"Aim for the sensor at the center front," she tells the princess as she crouches next to Bow. The weapon she has is for close range combat –you can send a few shots, but no further than a few feet. So long as that bot is still shooting, she's never going to be able to get close enough to actually do some damage.

"I'm *trying*, thanks," is the gritted reply as the princess shoots another pulse. It fizzes out when it reaches the bot, harmless.

This isn't going to work –the realization is as daunting as it's inevitable.

She *could* go around and get closer while the bot is somewhat occupied with Sparkles, but if she does, then the archer's defenseless. He's still conscious, but not by much, and in no state to hold his own or even get out of the way of a shot. She can't be sure both adversaries will focus on her, and if Sparkles turns her attention away from the bot to defend him, then they're *all* screwed.

The lizardfolk sends a shot in their direction, and Catra makes a snap decision. "Do you have enough magic to get out of here?"

Sparkles is still focused towards the bot, but she shoots a brief, guilty look in Catra's direction. "Not all of us."

That's not why Catra's asking. "Do you have enough for you and him?"

This time she looks over her shoulder, startled, although another flurry of laser shots brings her facing forward quickly enough. "What? We're not going to just leave you behind."

"Yeah, no offense, but you guys aren't exactly helping right now." She sends a warning shot over the rock towards the two that have started advancing, and stands up. "Just get out of here, both of you. I can handle it."

Sparkles looks stunned. "What are you…? Why are you even helping us?"

Question of the hour. She could have been gone the second the perimeter lines activated. Hell, she could still leave *now*; the passed out captor leaves an exit route, so long as the princess holds the bot at bay. Plus, no doubt the mercenaries will consider two rebels to be enough of a prize –they won't go after her.

Catra swallows hard. "If you get yourself captured, then Adora'll do the same trying to get you back. I'm not letting that happen."

It's true enough. She just hadn't thought of it until now.

The princess hesitates, but only briefly. With something that almost looks like a reluctant sort of respect in her eyes, she nods. "You sure you can handle them?"

"Oh, please." She aims a precise shot at the woman, who's advanced the most, and she jumps back out of range with a yelp. "Just *go*."

From the ground, she hears Bow attempt a vague protest, but he's thoroughly ignored. She and Sparkles exchange a look and then, after one last volley of pink glitter, the princess grabs his arm and they're gone in a blink.

"Aw, looks like your little friends ditched you." The woman, tilting her head in false sympathy. "Didn't the Horde teach you never to trust a princess? Don't worry, I'm sure they'll be happy to give you a refresher when you get back."

As her only response, Catra takes aim with the baton and presses the button for another distance shot. The two jump back

reflexively, but nothing comes beyond a tiny click –the battery's out.

After a disbelieving pause, the mercenaries start laughing.

It's meant to scare her, probably; cow her into surrendering, or panic her into making a mistake.

Instead, Catra straightens up, tosses the now useless weapon off to the side, and *grins*.

There's a flicker of hesitation on their face and, if anything, that makes her smile wider. She's alone, weaponless, and facing two adversaries and a bot –by any account, she should not be smiling. But she's not faking.

As it happens, she's got a few days' worth of frustration to burn through and this seems like *just the thing*.

Her ears twitch as she picks up a ruffle of grass somewhere behind her. Okay, make that three adversaries and a bot. Even better.

He's quiet, she'll give him that. Only, she's not about to let him get her twice: at the last possible moment, she twists out of the way, landing on the merc's back with one hand digging into his shoulder and the other pulling his arm back at an angle that's bad news, if his pained cry is any indication.

It snaps the others into action, but her new position doesn't just keep her out of his reach; it also lets her use her assailant as a shield against the laser blasts that start flying towards her. The others hesitate, reluctant to injure their friend.

She pulls a bit harder, but he suddenly drops forward, destabilizing her. The movement sends her flying over his head, but she doesn't miss the opportunity to *scratch* as she goes. Turning the crash into a roll, she smoothly rises to her feet to find him clutching his bleeding face and gasping in pain. She can't help a satisfied smirk at the sight, but a sudden snap from what turns

out to be a *laser whip*, coming uncomfortably close, shoots her back into action.

She eyes the weapon as she dodges –yeah, she *really* wants one of those.

The nap turns out to have been a great idea. Despite her three days of marching, Catra finds herself brimming with energy as she dodges hit after hit, jumping out of the way, and always managing to keep her adversaries at bay. This would go a lot faster if she could get her hands on an actual weapon, but she's in no particular hurry. They only ever get close to her when she decides to close the distance, and it's always so she can land a kick here or a particularly vicious clawing there.

It can't have been more than a few minutes before the general atmosphere starts to change. Her adversaries go from overconfident to wary. They expected an easy win, but she can tell from the way they glance at each other that they're starting to realize that it might not even be a win at all. It's in the looks they exchange as one holds a bleeding forearm and the other limps on a fucked ankle, the *is this really worth it*.

Their earlier smugness has made its way to Catra; she's having *fun* as she lands on top of the bot, just out of the range of its sensors –a zone she's very familiar with after years of practice. She's about to plunge her hand inside to rip out the computer powering it, when a shout distracts her. She lifts her head, just in time to see something charging.

The sight throws her completely –metaphorically, *and* literally: she's so distracted that she misses the whip until it wraps around her ankle with a scorching hold. She's launched off the bot and ends up on the ground, in direct range of the its weaponry.

Oh, and *Adora* is here, deflecting a blast from the lizardfolk with that stupid sword of hers. "Catra!"

This isn't happening. This is *not* happening.

"What the fuck are you *doing*?" Her question ends in a squeak when the bot fires a rapid series of blasts in her direction. She scrambles to her feet, barely dodging.

"What does it look like? I'm helping!"

Catra can't help but gape, and is rewarded with another *way* too close blaster shot. "This isn't *helping*!"

The defeat that had started to show itself in the mercenaries is gone. Even though an extra adversary should be bad news, the fact that Catra has clearly lost her concentration is apparently enough to reassure them. The lizardfolk grins as he fires off a few shots in her direction, which she narrowly avoids with a dive to the side.

Adora's response is *offended*, and Catra is *tired*. "What do you mean this isn't– Okay, no, you know what, we're not doing this now." Out of the corner of her eye, Catra catches her raising the sword above her head. "For the honour of– *hey*!"

Sure, the whole glowy, magical transformation thing is probably very cool. And *sure*, maybe having an eight-foot tall warrior princess around could be useful, right about now.

Only, the problem is that raising your sword above your head, no matter why you're doing it, *kinda* leaves your guard completely open.

Adora's call trails off when Catra tackles her from the side, sending the both of them toppling over and narrowly avoiding the green blast that would have caught Adora square in the chest otherwise.

The landing is rough, and Catra raises her head to find Adora staring at her wide-eyed. She opens her mouth, presumably to complain, but all that comes is a yell of pain, in sync with a flash of bright, white light. Catra squints, and makes out the end of the whip wrapped around Adora's hand, crackling with energy. The

mercenary tugs, and the sword flies out of Adora's grip and out of reach.

Catra swallows hard as their four adversaries advance slowly, but surely –even the *bot* is radiating smugness now. She and Adora are on the ground, weaponless, and surrounded.

"Hm," Adora says.

Or, in simpler terms, they are *fucked.*

Catra lets herself flop back down onto the hard ground. "Yeah."

*

"So are you just going to keep glaring at me silently the whole way, or…?"

Yeah, actually, that's *exactly* what Catra's going to do. She shifts on the hard metal floor of the hold, trying to find a position that's slightly less uncomfortable. Unfortunately, that's made pretty much impossible by the very limited range of movement allowed by the cuffs keeping her hands together and, mostly, attached to the ring set into the floor in front of her.

She gives up for now and dials up the scowl she's sending in Adora's direction, instead. It's not like she isn't justified, after all.

Adora rolls her eyes and lets her head fall back against the wall behind her. The space they've been shoved into is cramped, and made even more so by the dozens of crates that fill it. It makes sense, considering it's a makeshift cargo hold at the back of an even more makeshift customized skiff. Those ships don't normally *have* holds –they're designed for speed, not transport–, but Catra's been assigned enough boring inspection shifts to recognize a smuggler's rig. The actual controls outside are raised on an

elevated platform, and the space freed below is ideal to stash contraband stuff, be it weapons or food.

Or, you know. Deserters.

"It's not like this is *my* fault," Adora mumbles under her breath.

The sheer factual incorrectness of the statement is enough to break Catra out of her vow of silence. "*How* is this not your fault? This is completely, utterly, *one hundred percent* your fault, Adora!"

"I told you, I was trying to help–"

"I didn't need help! I had everything under control!"

Adora scoffs, and something scorching and bitter starts building at the pit of Catra's stomach. "You were facing three people and a bot alone, with no weapon and no backup. Sorry for assuming you could use a hand."

"Yeah! You should be!" *Fuck*, it's one thing knowing Adora thinks she can't take care of herself, but seeing it spelled out so clearly is another altogether, especially after the last few days. "Believe it or not, I'm actually at least *vaguely* capable."

"I'm not saying you're not–"

"*I*'m not the one of us who's needed rescuing lately." The words are harsh, and probably something she'll regret in a few hours, but in the face of Adora's painfully unconvinced expression, they slip out, angry and vicious.

They land hard. Adora's mouth drops open. "I… Really?"

Really. Anger churns in her gut and she's distantly aware that she should probably take a step back and attempt to cool down but *stars*. Sure, Adora's always seen her as the weak kid, someone who needed protection, so maybe Catra should have seen this coming. But still, after the last few days, she'd at least hoped she'd shown she wasn't utterly *useless*. "If it wasn't for me, you'd

still be in the Fright Zone, so would it kill you to acknowledge that I'm not *completely* incapable?"

"I didn't mean… I mean, that's not– I know you're not…" Adora stutters, and Catra lets her head drop back against the wall behind her.

Of course. Sparkles would turn over to the Horde's side before Adora'd accept that Catra could handle herself. She'd been stupid to think that the last few days would be enough to change that – that *anything* would ever be.

She sighs. "Why are you even here, Adora? Why did you come?"

Adora lets out a short, annoyed breath, presumably at getting cut off mid-sentence again. "Well, believe it or not, I was actually worried about my friend disappearing. I didn't realize that was a *crime*." Her head drops forward a little, and the anger in her tone cools. "I mean, come on, Catra! I didn't even know if you were going back to the Horde, or–"

"Oh, so you don't *just* think I'm useless, you also think I'm stupid. Noted."

And that's the anger, right back. "That's not what I'm saying–"

"I was doing *fine*, Adora. I was doing just fine until you and your stupid, ridiculously conspicuous friends showed up."

Adora blinks in surprise. "My friends? You saw Glimmer and Bow?"

Catra rolls her eyes but still answers. "Yeah. They're the ones the mercenaries tracked down in the first place. They're *fine*," she adds quickly when Adora opens her mouth, only to amend the statement when she thinks back to Bow's arm. "Mostly. Sparkles used her teleport… thing before it got too bad."

She frowns. "Wait, they left you behind?"

Ugh. "They saw I could handle it. Because it was very, *very* clear." The realization that even *Sparkles* seems to have more faith in her skills than Adora does is not a pleasant one.

Adora rolls her eyes again, but a bit of the tension seeps out of her shoulders as she slumps against the wall. Catra thinks it's the end of the conversation, but she speaks again after a few seconds, barely audible. "I wouldn't have *needed* to go after you if you hadn't left with no warning."

Catra blinks. Did she slip and land in another *dimension*? She must have. It's the only explanation for what she's just heard. "*You*? *You* are going to sit there and lecture me about *leaving*? *Fuck* you, Adora–"

"You didn't say anything, you were just gone!" She leans forward, eyes wide, and raises her bound hands, the movement halted by the restraints. "What was I supposed to think, Catra? I didn't know why you left, or where you were going, or if something had happened to you–"

"I left for a *reason*, Adora." The reason in question is crystal clear, even unsaid, floating in the air between them and as painful as a perimeter line, but Catra still spells it out. "I left because I didn't want to have anything to do with you."

Silence.

The flash of hurt on Adora's face is quick, but it's not quick enough that Catra misses it. Luckily, her former friend's face hardens back into cold, sharp anger fast enough that she can ignore the twinge of guilt the sight creates.

"*Fine*," Adora bites out, looking like she'd cross her arms if it wasn't for the cuffs. "Noted. Don't worry, I won't make the mistake of worrying about you ever again. Once we're out of here, we can go our separate ways and never see each other again."

It's what Catra wants. "Fine."

"Fine."

Silence stretches as they each glare at opposite sides of the cramped space. This is what Catra wants –she'll be happy about it as soon as she stops being so pissed off.

Of course she will.

Any minute now.

"… We do still need to get out of here, though," Adora says eventually, and a glance out of the corner of her eye shows Catra that she's angrily glaring at the ceiling.

"I know," Catra says, angrily glaring at the floor.

A beat.

"So. How do we do that."

Cooling down *is* however going to be difficult if Adora keeps talking, which, Catra knows, she is bound to do. She grits her teeth. "I don't know; you're the one who's here to rescue *me*, remember?"

She's 95% certain Adora is going through the calming breathing exercises they were taught as kids –it's in the way she's tapping her fingers against her thigh as she breathes out, gaze focused on anything that's not Catra.

They're not working great; she's clenching her jaw when she speaks again, after ten taps. "Come on. What's the situation? What assets do we have?"

She's trying to pull her usual squad-leader tone, which is already annoying at the best of times, and this is far from the best of times. The effect is also somewhat spoiled by the way she's still radiating annoyance.

Catra eyes her blankly, one eyebrow lifting. "*Well*, we're presently on a skiff going at high speed towards our probable death sentence. Said skiff is piloted by three armed people who won't hesitate to use force, and we're cuffed inside a locked room. We have a magical princess with no magical sword, and a bunch of contraband junk. How's that for assets?"

Adora scoffs. "Okay, you know what, if you're not going to help, you could at least be quiet and let me think. I don't–"

"The junk," Catra says again, realization dawning.

"What?"

Because yes, they *are* surrounded with junk. Shitty crates overflowing with packed food and whatnot, all the stuff that circulates in the contraband rings in the Fright Zone. It makes sense –fulfilling assignments for the Horde also gives them access *to* the Fright Zone and its potential customers. Only…

"Adora, the crate to your left."

Only it's not *just* that.

Adora frowns, but turns her head, and her eyes widen. "Is that…"

It is. The grey metal is pockmarked, but the heavy locking mechanism keeping the lid into place leaves no doubt; they're staring at a Horde-issued locker.

The Fright Zone is packed with them –they're used to store everything from weaponry to spare uniforms, the adjustable security of the lock making it usable anywhere. This one has clearly seen better days, but the faint green glow around the tiny square panel at the front shows it's still functional.

"Why do they have that?"

Things are clicking in Catra's head. "They don't just smuggle stuff to the Fright Zone," she says slowly, remembering the blasters and

perimeter lines they used –all Horde tech. "They take stuff *from* the Fright Zone. They must sell it back to whatever criminals exist in the Whispering Woods."

"They steal it?"

"I don't think they need to. Hell, it's probably how some of the officers *pay* for the stuff they bring over." And a locker wouldn't buy much, maybe, but, well… It'd depend on what's inside. "Can you open it?"

Adora nods, before getting to work pushing at the crate with her shoulder until the lock is facing her. No doubt there's some kind of security set –fingerprint lock or maybe just a code–, but a side effect of these things being everywhere in the Fright Zone is that every single cadet knows how to force them open. It was basically one of the first things you learnt –when your punishments meant you were withheld rations or bandages, knowing how to get one of these open became a life skill.

And so, everyone quickly learnt that the impassable looking interface could be pried up from one corner. After that, it was just a matter of crossing the right wires together, and the lid would open without a hitch. Once the panel was fixed back in place, there wouldn't even be a trace of the intrusion. It was at most the work of a few seconds, with experience.

Well, most of the time.

Adora curses under her breath as she fiddles with the screen, crouching awkwardly to maximize her limited reach. Catra finds herself tapping a finger against the chain connecting her cuffs to the floor. "*May* I remind you about the whole "probable death sentence" situation? What's taking you so long?"

"Well *excuse me*," Adora huffs, "it's not exactly easy when your hands are tied together."

"How come you haven't gotten out of those already? Thought that was your specialty," Catra snarks in response, the tiniest bit bitter

–her jaw *still* hurts from Adora's stunts in the woods three days ago.

To her surprise, Adora flashes her an amused smile. "Got a stick I can use?"

Catra blinks at the reference. She didn't think Adora would remember much about her time under the spell in general, much less about their trek through the woods, but the words seem to indicate otherwise.

Before she gets to dwell on the implications of that however, Adora lets out a triumphant exclamation that almost drowns out the beep of the lock unlatching. With an awkwardly angled elbow, she pushes the lid up, and her jaw drops.

"Well?" Catra cranes her neck to try and see inside, to no avail. "What's in there?"

Adora's answering grin is so familiar it almost hurts –it's Adora at the very end of a sparring session as she's about to give the final blow; Adora when she's seconds away from the finish line in a race; Adora when she shoots the final shot in target practice. It's Adora when she knows she's *won* –cocky, and confident, and just a little bit breathtaking.

"Assets."

*

The sound the metal locker makes when it crashes into the floor is so loud it hurts. Thankfully, it also has the desired effect: seconds later, the door to the outside slides open with a high-pitched noise, and the bot comes scuttling in, its sensor scanning the space frantically.

"You guys should *really* think about tidying this place up," Catra says conversationally, careful to keep her hands still in front of her. She nods towards the pile of collapsed crates. "Not sure how much a squished force captain's going to get you."

The sensor light briefly widens as her words are computed, and then the bot hurries forward to see past the debris and assess how accurate Catra's 'squished' description is.

The almost baffled pause that follows the discovery that the space holds no force captain at all, squished or not, is pretty funny. The bot swivels to turn its sensor on Catra, who smiles innocently. "Lucky she got time to get out of the way, huh?"

On that, she lifts her hand, letting it catch sight of the half melted, severed handcuffs and, more pressingly, of the perimeter line delimiter she's holding.

Not for long, though; from her spot against the wall near the door, Adora lifts her own delimiter. As soon as the two devices align, the lines crackle to life, slicing straight through the bot that stands in the center. It's not strong enough to *actually* cut it in half –it's solid metal, not cheap plastic like their handcuffs were–, but the surge is plenty enough to short-circuit it. With one loud beep, the bot crashes to the floor, fried.

They barely have the time to exchange triumphant grins: a shout drifts in from the outside, and a glance towards the still open door shows Catra that they're in direct sight of the lizardfolk, who's sitting at the front of the skiff. From his expression, he clearly just witnessed their little maneuver.

So much for the effect of surprise.

They burst out of the tiny hold before he can take action, but it's milliseconds before he comes to his senses and jumps into a fighting stance. Adora flies forward, taking him on immediately. As for Catra, she barely gets the time to recognize the canyon-y region they're flying in –*fuck*, that is *way* closer to the Fright Zone than she thought they were– before her attention gets stolen by the blaster that goes off somewhere behind her.

She jumps out of the way, spinning round to take in the situation. The white-haired woman is at the commands, and while she has

one hand on the hilt of her whip, she hasn't let go of the controls either –she can't, not in that terrain; they'd go splattering against a rocky wall in seconds.

The shot came from the other one, the guy whose face she clawed earlier –a clawing he's tried to cover up with a few makeshift bandages covering his left eye and cheek. He's standing on the steps leading up to the command platform, one hand on his blaster, the other wrapped around the hilt of a large, golden sword –well, that's one mystery solved.

Not wasting a second, she leaps forward, getting into his personal space to make his blaster unusable –they're not designed for close-range combat. To his credit, he adjusts quickly and ditches it, flipping the sword into his dominant hand and using it to hold her back. She tries a few swipes and punches, but she keeps having to jerk her hands back before the blade slices *through* them.

"Catra!"

She doesn't need to think, or look back; she brings her left hand behind her and angles the delimiter she's still holding towards Adora's voice. The telltale crackle of energy fills the air, followed seconds later by a shout from her adversary.

A swipe of the sword makes her bring her arms in front of her for protection, and the blade catches on the device, smashing it in her hand. With a hiss of pain, she tosses the debris at his face.

He didn't expect that; he takes a stumbling step back, and she takes her chance, pouncing forward and digging a series of nasty scratches into his forearm, until he drops the sword with a shout. She dives forward, fingers wrapping around the hilt just as the skiff violently lurches to the right, almost sending her overboard. Desperate for a handhold, she stabs the blade into the metal flooring, wincing at the screech of metal against metal, and uses the now steady hilt to stabilize herself.

"*Hey*, be careful with that!"

She tosses an incredulous glance over her shoulder. Adora's still busy with her own confrontation, throwing kicks and punches, but she's also looking back to frown in the direction of the sword.

Come *on*. "Seriously? Bit of a tight spot, here, Adora!" She digs the sword out and brings it up just in time to block her adversary's sudden swing of a stun baton –where did he even *get* that?"

"I'm just *saying*," Adora calls, loud enough to be heard over the engines and the fighting, "it's not like I have any spare ones, so if you could *please* just be a little careful–"

Catra scoffs, parrying blow after blow. "I thought you wanted to help? *This*"–she swings the sword a little more ostensibly, making sure Adora catches sight of the move–"is helpful."

She doesn't see Adora roll her eyes, but she doesn't need to. "*Whatever*. Just" –a pause as she twists out of the way of a very obvious feint with complete ease "–give it here already."

Catra *had* been about to –a magical warrior princess could have its use right about now, after all– but now she finds herself tightening her grip instead. "Bet I can use this better than you anyway."

Adora snorts, and when Catra next manages to glance at her, she's got one eyebrow up in amused disbelief. "Yeah, *okay*."

"I can."

"Catra, it's literally *my* magic sword." In a move that's annoyingly graceful, Adora sidesteps her adversary's attack and grabs his wrist, forcing his arm back and twisting until he drops down to his knees. She smirks in Catra's direction, and suddenly, it's like they're sparring in the assessment zone of the Fright Zone, exchanging more quips than hits. "Not to play the *magical princess* card, but like… It actually responds *only* to me."

That's a fair point, probably. Catra should toss it to her, probably.

Only, those words sound an awful lot like a challenge now, and, well... Catra's never been one to back down from one of those. She adds an extra flourish to her next swing and grins over her shoulder. "Guess we'll find out, huh?"

The best part is probably that the answering glint in Adora's eye is anything but angry.

With the extra adrenaline of a challenge, somehow still comfortingly familiar, Catra refocuses on her fight, blocking and slashing and progressively backing him up against the side of the skiff, even if the white-haired woman keeps brutally swerving to throw her and Adora off. It's not a losing fight, by any mean, but it's slow going.

Too slow going, in fact, possibly. Her glee starts slowly fading as the landscape the skiff is flying through gets progressively less mountain-y –the passage is widening with every minute, and the bottom of the canyon seems to be progressively rising up.

"Catra…" Adora's voice, somewhere behind her, is low –a warning.

"I know." She really does. As soon as they clear the canyon, the woman will be able to set the skiff on auto-pilot, and then they'll be facing three people, minutes away from the Fright Zone. They wouldn't be *done for*, not necessarily, but their chances would get drastically worse.

Their respective fights have brought them to the front of the skiff, back to back. The realization that they're running out of time sends Catra leaping forward towards the command platform, but a sudden white hot *snap*, landing inches away from her, stops her in her tracks. With now only a light grip on the controls and her weapon of choice unsheathed, the pilot grins in her direction, smug and self-satisfied. *Fuck*.

"Catra–"

The whip snaps again, this time clearly heading for her grip on the sword, and Catra angles the weapon away at the last second. "Bit busy right now."

When the whip comes again, she's expecting it –instead of dodging, she lets it wrap around the blade, until there's a *tug*. Immediately, she brings her arm back and pulls the blade down with as much strength as she can.

It works; victory floods her when the whip flies out of the woman's grip, and she reaches up with her free hand, barely managing to catch the hilt before it can go overboard.

Her victory's short-lived, however; with an angry snarl, the woman slams a hand over what Catra recognizes as the auto-pilot command –*shit*.

"Catra, we need to jump."

That gets her attention –she looks over her shoulder to gape at Adora, something she quickly ends up regretting when the unmistakable sound of a blaster shot echoes, together with a flash of sudden heat that is *way* too close to her face. She snaps her head and focus back towards the apparently once again *armed* enemy –how much weaponry do they even *have*?– with a curse. "Are you *insane*?"

From the sound of it, Adora's not faring much better. Between a few pants and hits, she manages: "It's the only way out and you know it."

"I'm not jumping out of a moving skiff! Have you lost your damn mind?"

Except… Except they're out of options. The canyon is *barely* one at all anymore; they have a minute at the most before they're on an open plane and the autopilot completely takes over, and then–

"Catra, just *trust* me!"

And it's been weeks –it's been fucking weeks, and Adora betrayed her, Adora left her, and Adora still doesn't trust her to even take care of herself, and Catra has no reason, no reason *at all* to trust Adora, not anymore–

"*Jump!*"

But apparently, she still fucking does anyway.

Catra closes her eyes, and she jumps.

Chapter End Notes

so. astute readers will have noticed that this is, in fact, not the final chapter. I have no excuse beyond "this draft is 17k and still not done oh my god what happened"

this one was also,,,, slightly longer in the making due to:
1. my getting so distracted by the idea of catra with a sword that I wrote a whole one shot about it
2. my randomly deciding to apply to a phd
3. the aforementioned 17k situation
but! we made it!

regardless, ty so much to anyone who's made it this far, and as always, big shout out to kudos-ers and commenters; yall are 100% the reason why this fic is still going 💕

final thing: I've finally caved and made a she-ra sideblog! Come say hi at @ariesnoctua!

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

walks in ten months late with a 15k chapter and starbucks

yeah, i have no excuse

See the end of the chapter for more notes

So, yes, apparently, she still trusts Adora.

Also apparently, that is very much a *bad* thing.

The landing is rough, but that's not the problem. She manages to tuck into a roll when she hits the sandy ground, although the sharp incline means she has no way to stop her momentum and goes careening down without slowing. Her shoulder's a bit jostled, and the final tumble down adds more bruises and aches to the ever-growing list, but when she finally reaches the bottom, she can tell there's nothing broken. So no, that's not the problem.

Adora seems alright too –she's standing already when Catra's head stops spinning, rolling her shoulders as if to check that they're still working right. She winces as she rolls the left one a bit higher up, so she probably pulled something, but generally, is still standing and seems alright. So, *also* not the problem.

Catra watches as Adora takes a few steps and looks up towards the way they came from, and *there's* the problem.

She looks *up*.

Catra pushes herself up until she's sitting, letting go of the sword and sending it clattering against the stone ground. The space they're in is cool, the slightest bit damp, and dark, save for the light that's coming from their entry point.

The tiny, very far away, *very far up* entry point.

They're at the mouth of a large cave; and, to put it bluntly, at the bottom of a hole. A ridiculously deep, definitely impossible to climb out of, hole. It's not *quite* a vertical climb up, which is why they didn't just fall straight down and break their necks on impact, but the slipperiness of the sand that coats it combined with the slope means there's not going to be any way out through there.

Which means they're *stuck*. At the bottom of a *hole*.

That is the problem.

Adora apparently didn't get the memo. She's eyeing the pinprick of sky they can see from down there –*fuck*, that is *so* far up– and breathes a giddy, almost laughing sigh. "I think we lost them. We did it." She turns to Catra, frowning when she sees she's still sitting. "You alright? That was a bit further down than I thought."

Catra gapes at her. "Than you *thought*?" she repeats, incredulous, as she forces herself to stand on still wobbly legs. Her left hip protests –it hit the ground first–, but she ignores it. "You mean you did this on purpose?"

Adora seems confused. "Did what?"

"*Stranded us at the bottom of a hole*?"

"Oh." Adora shifts a little, and the shadows aren't enough to mask her sheepish expression. "Well. Not specifically. Maybe. Kind of."

"Kind of."

"Well. You know." She crosses her arms, tone turning defensive. "I saw the cave coming up, and I figured that if we jumped into it, they wouldn't be able to find us, even if they did another pass of the canyon with the skiff. There didn't seem to be much of a point in jumping off if it was just for them to pick us back up right after."

Catra's earlier alternate dimension theory floats back to the forefront of her mind. "So that's a yes, then."

"Yes what?"

"You *did* strand us at the bottom of a hole on purpose."

Adora rolls her eyes. "We're not *stranded*." She eyes the pinprick of sky again. "So maybe we're not going to climb out the way we came, but it's not like this is a dead end." She gestures towards the other way, where the rest of the cave presumably lies –not that they can *see* it, what with it being pitch dark and all. Still, the slight draft that comes through does seem to show that it isn't just a wall, at least.

It's still *far* from a good idea. Catra stares into the dark for a second, before turning back to Adora. "Your plan is to get lost in the pitch dark cavern that is probably collapsing, and hope there's another way out? *That* is your plan?"

"It's not *collapsing*–" she trails off when Catra gestures at the rubble around them, a clear sign that this place didn't use to be this far down, but had been dragged down during a *collapse*. "Probably. It'll be fine! This canyon is full of interconnecting caves. We're bound to find a way out at some point."

Catra stares for one more second before looking away and starting to pace the dimly lit space. She's pretty sure she's going to start screaming if she keeps looking at Adora. "Wow," she drawls eventually. "The Rebellion is *so* lucky to have you, Adora."

Adora lets out an annoyed huff of breath. "Well, *sorry*, it was a bit of a tight spot, in case you hadn't noticed. It's not like we had a ton of options."

Catra hums as she walks, until her gaze catches one of the dark shapes at the end of the cavern. She pauses, puzzled, as she eyes it. She'd thought all the hulking shapes were boulders and rocks, but now that her vision is slowly adjusting, the glow coming from that one looks almost… metallic. She frowns, and heads over.

Adora's still talking. "–and yes, I'm sure you could have handled it *all on your own* perfectly well, *once again*, but–"

But Catra's not listening anymore, her heartbeat hammering in her ears as she kicks over the shape until it falls out of the shadows and into the pathetic bit of light that streams in from the surface. Her eyes widen as she finally recognizes it. "Adora."

Adora trails off, apparently recognizing the urgency in her tone. She catches up to Catra, squinting in the dark and tilting her head. "What's– Oh."

It took her a few seconds longer than Catra to recognize it, what with her eyes being less good in dim lighting, but understanding makes its way across her features all at once as she takes in the crumpled, but still recognizable carcass of a Horde bot.

"*What*?" she asks under her breath, but Catra's already squinting at the walls and the rest of the dark shapes.

"We need light." She's barely said the words that Adora makes a beeline for her sword, still where Catra left it. A few seconds later, she holds it out towards the darkest part of the cavern, and the gem set into the hilt starts glowing a faint, but noticeable blue. The general effect is basically the stupidest-looking flashlight Catra has ever seen.

Her snarky remark about that very fact dies in her throat however when the glow falls on the far wall; and, mostly, the massive Horde sigil inscribed upon it.

Right. Guess they *really* had made it pretty close to the Fright Zone after all.

"What is this?" Adora asks, almost in a whisper.

Catra's got the sinking suspicion she already knows, but she stays quiet, using the glow to make her way to other shadow-y shapes. A couple more bots, sets of dusty lockers, and, more telling than anything else, a large, flat, dark rectangle lying against a wall.

She flicks a finger against the top, but the screen is long dead. Still, she's seen enough of them in her life to recognize a

scoreboard when she sees one. She swallows hard. "It's an assessment zone."

Adora snaps her head in her direction. "*What*?"

Most of the training recruits went through took place within the Fright Zone –it was virtual, sterile, and perfectly controlled. But sometimes, just sometimes, they were taken beyond the strict boundaries of the compound. The assessment they'd had to pass to get to the rank of officer cadet, back when they were thirteen, had been one of those. Assessment courses had been set up in the nearby canyon cave networks, to force them out of their element.

Catra had *loved* those courses. Sure, the caves were dark and damp and cold, and the traps set up hadn't exactly been a walk in the park, but it was *new* and challenging, and she'd been *good* at it. Hell, she's pretty sure that if she managed to switch that scoreboard back on, she'd see her –and Adora's– old identification code at the top.

Unfortunately, the whole program had been shut down soon after their cadet assessment, when a rock fall had shown how unstable the network was. Not that the Horde particularly cared about the safety of their recruits, but there was little point in training kids for years if it was just for them to get buried under a cave collapse.

She eyes the space warily, an odd sense of familiarity coloring her perception now she's recognized it. That bit there was where the cadets would be briefed; that other big metal bar set into the wall was where their plastrons would be stored in between runs.

The contrast between the loud, sharply metallic space she remembers it to be and this dark, rusted ghost space is jarring, and it's probably why she jumps when Adora speaks again, way closer to her than she'd realized.

"Catra, do you realize what this means?"

Her voice is almost giddy and Catra represses a wince. “That the cave is *definitely* collapsing?”

Adora is undeterred. “It means there’s a way *out!*”

“It *means* that this is a collapsing cave network that is *full of traps*, Adora.” How is she still grinning?

Adora waves her hand dismissively. “Okay, so maybe it’s not super stable, but there’s no way these traps are still live.” She makes her way to the end of the cave, where it narrows down into a passageway that marks the beginning of one of the actual assessments, calling over her shoulder as she goes. “This place was decommissioned years ago. We’ll be fine.”

Catra catches up to her just in time. She holds one hand out in front of her to stop her walking into the actual passage, and uses the other to grab a stray piece of rock that’s lying on a ridge in the wall. Without a second’s pause, she tosses it ahead into the dark stone corridor.

Bright green lasers flash instantly, half blinding her. When they stop, the blue glow of Adora’s sword is just about enough to make out the rock on the ground, scorched and smoking.

“Yeah,” Catra drawls. “No way they’re still live. We’ll be fine.”

*

They manage to knock the lasers out of alignment by tossing more rocks at them –not the most elegant solution, but it lets them get through without getting sliced into pieces, so.

For the most part, however, Adora does seem to be right: most of the traps they encounter as they slowly make their way through the dark and narrow tunnels aren’t functional. Catra’s pretty sure

it’s more down to them having fallen apart without maintenance than to the Horde bothering to take them offline, though.

Catra is… uneasy. Part of it is the very real threat of the cave coming collapsing down over their heads at any moment, but that’s not what’s *really* bothering her, and she’s annoyingly aware of that fact.

She swings the weak beam of the flashlight she’d unearthed in one of the crates –“*Sorry*, we can’t all just summon magic light whenever we want.” “We all have our flaws.”– across the space behind them. Adora’s leading the way, using her sword’s glow to make out the obstacles ahead, while Catra’s bringing up the rear and watching their backs. It’s the set up they always used as cadets for paired assignments. They just automatically fell back into it without even needing to think, and *that*’s the core of it.

Everything is so… *normal*, right now.

Well, not really. The cave is in ruins, they’ve just escaped capture by mercenaries, and Adora’s using a *magic sword*. But beyond that… Everything is painfully, bizarrely familiar, like this is just another day with a paired assessment. Like they’ll make their way out, and then walk back to the barracks, gloating about the speed record they’ll most likely have beaten. Like they’ll then head to their spot at the top of the Fright Zone to split the extra ration bar the exploit will have earned them.

Like nothing has changed.

Every few seconds, she has to actively remind herself that it’s not true; that *everything*’s changed. Adora is a *princess* now, for stars’ sake. Things couldn’t have changed any more than they have.

So why does it feel the same? Why does Adora still feel like she *belongs* here, as she sidesteps traps and tests the way ahead? An irrational, livid part of Catra wants to stomp her foot about how *unfair* it is.

Adora's changed –she shouldn't *get* to belong here, not anymore. She should be feeling just as out of place as Catra did in Bright Moon, surrounded with magic and sparkly princesses.

But *no*. Here she is, humming to herself, clearly perfectly at ease, with none of Catra's jitteriness.

Catra grits her teeth. Makes sense –Adora's just that *special*.

But meanwhile, Catra's the one who has to make sure she remembers how temporary this all is. She can't let herself forget, can't let herself fall back into fun banter as they fight back to back, can't let herself get hung up about how *in sync* she and Adora can get sometimes.

She doesn't need Adora, and that's just as well, because they're about to go their separate ways.

And so, she fumes silently, trying to keep her focus equally on looking for potential traps and keeping her anger in check long enough to get out of here. She's pretty sure she can succeed, so long as Adora stays quiet.

"Can I ask you something?"

If Adora stays quiet. Which, of course, she wouldn't do.

Catra doesn't respond, but Adora takes her silence as acquiescence, speaking without looking back at her. "Why did you help me escape? The Fright Zone, I mean."

Yeah, she wasn't getting into that in the forest with a brainwashed Adora, and she certainly isn't now either. "Do we have to do this now?"

Adora tosses her a look over her shoulder, one eyebrow up. "Got anything better to do?"

Silence is her best bet, she knows. She also knows it's not going to deter her friend, and she's, unfortunately, right.

"Come on, Catra." Another look over her shoulder, and there's a hint of cocky teasing in the tilt of her eyebrow that makes Catra's muscles go a bit rigid. "It's a simple question."

Catra should ignore her. She finds that she can't. "Why'd you think?"

Adora laughs a little. "Well, that's the point. I don't know. I've been"–she pauses and swings her sword in the empty space in front of her, wincing when a green laser lights the space–"wracking my brain trying to figure it out, and I can't make it make sense."

There's something, in her tone, that vaguely tugs at Catra because of its familiarity, but the idea is quickly smothered under the bitterness that floods her at the words. She watches silently as Adora uses the point of the sword to gently nudge the laser cannon sticking out of the wall so it lies flat against it instead, trying to rein the anger in. The fact that Adora thinks so little of her that she'd just *stand back* and let Shadow Weaver brainwash her… It sits at the back of her throat, a sour aftertaste.

"Thought maybe I'd gotten through to you a little bit," Adora continues lightly, completely oblivious. "About the Horde? I thought maybe you'd realized how evil they actually are, and that you'd changed your mind about the Rebellion." This time the laugh is nervous, self-conscious. "Guess maybe not."

Fuck staying composed. "How many times do I need to say it?" Catra hisses, and Adora swivels around, eyes wide at the venom in her voice. "I *knew*, Adora. I've known *all along*. I knew the Horde was evil, and I didn't care." She's enunciating every syllable, watching as Adora's expression falls. "I still don't."

"But…" Adora's sword arm drops a little, and with it the glow that fills the air. "But, that doesn't…"

Catra needs to finish this. She takes a step forward, right into Adora's personal space. "Maybe you're the problem, Adora. Maybe

I didn't *want you there*. Did you think of that? Maybe I saw what it was like without you, and I decided I liked it better that way."

She's poured every bit of the anger that's been eating at her into the words, and she gets to watch Adora falter as she takes a small step back.

But she's also shaking her head, and when she speaks, her voice is assured, solid. "Bullshit."

Adora doesn't swear much, usually –although she always tended to do it more when Catra was around. Just one more of the many ways Catra made her worse, like Shadow Weaver always said.

"That's not…" Adora hesitates a little, but her gaze doesn't waver. "If you wanted me gone, there were plenty of ways to go about it. Plenty of ways that didn't involve throwing away your entire future in the Horde."

Shit. *Shit, shit, shit*. Her heartbeat pounding in her ears, Catra pushes past her, forging ahead on the dark path. She's *not* having this fucking conversation, not when she's stuck underground, not *ever*. She has lost a lot these last few weeks, and she is *not* going to give up her damned pride as well.

And now Adora's angry, too, which tracks; Catra's always been great at that –pissing her off. "You can't just *ignore* me, Catra!" She can and she will. "I got Glimmer to teleport me all over Etheria to find you, I put the whole damned *Alliance* on pause–"

"Good thing I never asked you to do any of that, then."

Adora's frustrated huff is familiar enough that Catra knows there's a whole tirade just waiting to happen hiding behind it, so she stops and turns back to face Adora, speaking before it can start.

"I never *asked* you to put your precious Alliance on pause," she says, words sharp and bitter. "I never *asked* you to leave your precious rebel friends, I never *asked* you to come after me. *You*

decided to do that, because you can't *bear* to think for *one* moment that *I* could have saved *you*."

As soon as the words are out, it clicks –because of *course* that's it. The look on Adora's face that's been nagging at her during this entire conversation, the uncertain waver in her eyes? That's *guilt*.

It's still here now, although muted under a layer of shock, and Catra continues, her own anger subdued under the tired, bitter realization. She rubs a hand against her forehead. "So thanks, Adora," she says, lower, "but no thanks. You can keep your damn guilt, your stupid *hero complex*, and you can damn well live with the fact that someone else helped *you* for a change."

"I don't–"

"And you know what? You can even damn well live with the fact that *I* did, incapable as you may think I am." She turns her back on Adora, ready to start forward again, but the other girl holds her back with one hand on her arm, forcing her to face her again.

"*That*'s why you think I'm here?" Adora's eyes are positively *blazing*. "Because I feel *guilty*?"

"I *know* that's why–"

"I'm here because I wanted to know *why you helped me!*" She lets out a breath of angry, incredulous laughter. "I wanted to know *why* you'd risk it. I– I needed to know. Because…"

Adora's voice turns hesitant, her gaze too intense, and Catra shakes herself free, continuing down the path without a glance back at her.

"*Catra!*"

Catra doesn't slow down, even though she knows Adora's not going to have any trouble keeping up. All she needs to do is keep quiet, and in a few hours, she'll be out of here, and none of it will matter.

Again, Adora breathes a sharp, angry burst of laughter. Catra doesn't turn around, but she doesn't need to to picture Adora's hard expression as the girl speaks again.

"Don't know what I expected," she mumbles, bitter, and angry, and the smallest tinge of *sad*. "It doesn't matter to you, right? Cause you don't care about anything. You don't care that the Horde is evil, you don't care if people are getting hurt." A pause. "You don't care about me."

Catra freezes.

"That is low, even for you." *"You know nothing's too low for me."*

"If I started getting first place, people might start expecting something of me. Trust me, second place suits me just fine." *"Hm. Okay."*

"I thought you didn't care *about this stuff."* *"I* don't*."*

The words spin in her head, dizzying, until she feels she might be sick. All those times; all those times Catra had clung to her pride, to her façade, to whatever shreds of dignity she could muster.

Adora had never seen through it. And that was fine, really, that was the *point*, that was what Catra had wanted, back then. Losing was bad enough –she couldn't handle Adora seeing how much it *hurt*, too. She'd rather Adora think she didn't give a shit, and so she'd worked to make sure that was how it seemed.

But this? After *everything*, that Adora wouldn't see through it when it came to *her*? That *Adora*, Adora who *left* her, Adora who never *gave a shit* what happened to her after she was gone, *that* Adora, would get to stand there and talk about how Catra never cared about her?

Something snaps.

She spins on her heel, one finger flying accusingly in Adora's direction. "I did it because that was the *deal*, Adora!"

The silence that follows her words knocks the energy out of her, and she suddenly feels very, very small.

Well.

There it is.

She breathes out, long and slow, against the burn in her eyes, and resists the urge to scrub at them. "That was always the deal, Adora. You look out for me, I look out for you." She swallows hard, looking away. "Just because you dropped your end doesn't mean I had to."

Adora breathes in sharply. "Catra, I–"

No –absolutely not. She turns her back on her. "Let's just go. Now you know, you don't have to… wonder anymore. The sooner we get out of here, the sooner we can go our separate ways and never see each other again."

It's the words Adora used earlier, only they completely lack the bite they had. Catra just can't quite muster it.

Adora's reply doesn't have it either. "That's what you want?"

"That's how it's got to be."

Catra tenses when she feels Adora's hand wrap around her wrist, but before she can shake herself free, three things happen in rapid succession.

There's a hiss of pressure releasing as Adora takes a step forward.

The ground under their feet *creaks*.

Catra realizes she's stopped monitoring for traps that might open *behind* them.

The next second, the ground under Adora's feet vanishes.

Adora lets out a strangled scream as she falls, with nothing to hang on to. Lightning fast, Catra jumps round, wrapping her hand around Adora's wrist and dropping to the ground, right at the edge of the newly opened hole. She feels the *tug* in her shoulder and winces, but she holds on, gritting her teeth.

"Hang on," she manages to huff out.

"I resent the implication that I'm doing anything else," Adora breathes in between two pained gasps, and Catra rolls her eyes.

"I can still drop you," she points out.

"Well *that* would make the last week a waste of time."

She almost considers it. But even though the hole is even darker than the tunnel they've been trekking through, it's just about light enough that she can see the tension in Adora's expression.

With an *oof*, she pulls her out. It's not easy, what with how she's still sore from their fall earlier, but she's something of an expert, when it comes to pulling Adora out of holes –both metaphorically and literally. There was a reason why Catra was the one of them in charge of looking for traps, back in the Horde.

Adora clambers out as soon as Catra's lifted her high enough, the sword clattering against the stone, and she lets herself flop down for a second, facing the ceiling, as Catra eyes her warily. "Thanks," she breathes.

"Don't mention it. Shoulder?"

She shoots Catra a surprised look that Catra doesn't dignify with an acknowledgement –did she *really* think Catra hadn't noticed?–, before sitting up and trying a tentative roll of it. "Still attached."

Catra nods sharply, getting to her feet. The ghost of her earlier words is still hanging in the air, and she's not interested in getting back to them. "Good. We should–"

"It's why I did it, too."

She closes her eyes briefly. "What?"

When she opens them again, Adora is also standing, with an expression that's vaguely sheepish as she stares at her feet. "Well, it's just. Back when I was under the spell, that night in the sparring room…" More fidgeting, more feet staring, and Catra stares, feeling strangely detached. "I said I wouldn't leave you again. Well, I didn't *know*, back then, that I'd done it already, but still. I promised. And I know I promised before, and I sort of– well, it didn't work out. So. That's why I'm here. Not just because I wanted to know, I just. Yeah," she finishes, a tad miserably.

Silence stretches, until Adora risks a glance up in her direction. Unfortunately, Catra is way too gobsmacked to get her expression under control.

She's having trouble processing, but she has to say *something.* Eventually, she hears words leave her mouth. "It doesn't count as you leaving if I'm the one who left, you dumbass."

The words have no bite to them: the shock's stolen every ounce of it she had. Adora snorts to herself. "Yeah, guess not. Still." The silence holds a few more seconds, and Adora clears her throat. "We should uh. Probably keep moving. Before the cave collapses, and all that."

Noiselessly, Catra nods, and Adora takes the lead again, testing the ground as she goes a bit more carefully.

Catra follows, head still spinning.

*

Oddly enough, the atmosphere becomes slightly more breathable after the exchange. Catra's still far from *at ease*, but she's not quite so on edge anymore.

Case in point: when the tunnel takes a sharp right only to stop abruptly in front of a massive pile of rubble, she only stares blankly.

"Ah," Adora says, eventually.

Yeah, it's a fair assessment. The way is completely blocked, boulders and rocks piled together in the very recognizable aftermath of a collapse, all the way up to the ceiling at least twenty feet above them.

Adora squares her shoulder next to her, chin lifting. "Okay," she says, with a note of anticipation in her voice that makes alarm bells go off in Catra's head. "I can deal with this."

She barely gets the time to wrap her second hand around the hilt of her sword before Catra speaks. "Bad plan."

Adora pauses, eyeing her without turning her head. "You don't know what the plan is."

Catra sighs internally. She's known Adora for almost two decades –she knows what the plan is. "Is the plan turning into a magical princess and smashing the rocks to pieces?"

Silence. Adora opens her mouth, and closes it again.

"Is it," Catra asks again, voice flat.

"…Maybe."

Yeah. Catra points to the rubble. "You realize that this is here because this part of the cavern started collapsing, right?

Adora closes her eyes and lowers her sword. "So this part is unstable–"

"–so it's especially unstable and ready to collapse, which means–"

"–so it could collapse if I break the wrong thing–"

"–it's going to come down over our heads if you start smashing things at random, yeah."

"–yeah, okay," Adora finishes, a tad sulkily. She kicks at a loose pebble, before sighing. "Fine. Let's turn back. There might be another tunnel that connects into this one at some point."

She turns around, but Catra lifts a hand to stop her, silent. Because yeah, there's a big fuck off pile of rocks but…

There's also a draft.

It's barely there; she hears it more than she feels it, a ghost of a whistle that barely ruffles the ends of her hair, but it's *there*. And if there's a draft, then there must be a gap somewhere, too. "I think there might be a way through."

Not waiting for an answer, she starts to climb up. The massive boulders quickly give way to smaller rocks, and she curses when some of them roll under foot, shooting her balance to hell. Still, if they move, then that's even more signs that this might not be as impassable as it looks.

She was always the best climber, growing up, and so she makes it to the top in record time. Careful not to bang her head on the ceiling, she squints in the dark, reaching for the torch she'd tucked back in her belt.

"Anything?" Adora calls from back on the ground. Her voice echoes oddly from up there, but Catra's attention is quickly stolen when the beam of her light gets swallowed up by a small patch of dark.

She moves forward, careful to only step on the more solidly fixed holds, and suddenly, it's not a draft: there's a *breeze*, cool against her face.

She’s staring into a hole.

The torch isn’t enough to pierce through the dark beyond it, but that’s fine. Whatever traps were set around this part of the course will have gotten squashed by the rockfall anyway. Tentatively, she reaches for one of the rocks that line the edge of the fist-sized hole, and pushes.

It wobbles once, twice, and, when she gives a more forceful shove, gives way, tumbling into the dark beyond with a clattering noise. The resulting hole is large enough for two hands, and Catra grins, calling back over her shoulder. “There’s a way through. I just need to widen it a bit.”

Adora’s victorious exclamation brings an amused smile to her face. It freezes in place with her next words, however. “Great. I’m coming up.”

Catra turns around so fast she almost loses her balance, and she clutches the edge of the gap with her free hand as she shines her torch in Adora’s direction. She looks tiny from up there. “Like hell you are.”

Adora pauses, one foot already up on one of the boulders. “What?”

“Adora, you’ve never been particularly good at climbing, even at the best of times–“

“I’m not *that* bad.”

“–and this is really unstable,” Catra finishes determinedly, ignoring her protests. Adora still looks unconvinced, and even from up there, she recognizes that same guilt from earlier on her face. Catra sighs before continuing. “If you climb up, I’ll just break my neck trying to stop you breaking *your* neck when you slip and fall.”

The argument lands; her shoulders dropping, Adora goes back to the ground and sits on a smaller stone, her back to the wall.

"Fine," she mumbles. "Just… Shout if you need me to do something."

And because she knows how badly Adora must need to feel *useful* right now, Catra nods. "Will do."

The truth is, she's being a bit uncharitable to Adora's climbing skills. She's not as agile as Catra is –no one is–, but she's far from terrible at it, either. Even on the unstable terrain, Adora could make the climb safely and help widen the passage on any normal day.

But that's the thing; this isn't a normal day. Tucking her lit flashlight into a small crevice to free her hands, she glances over her shoulder down at Adora, who's morosely staring at the glowing gem set in her sword. Sure, the dim blue glow isn't particularly flattering, but even taking that into account, Adora looks… tired. There's bags under her eyes, and her posture lacks the barely restrained energy it normally has.

Bow's earlier words echo in her head, even as she gets to work pushing at the barricade. *That spell really did a number on her*.

Castaspella's description had made it clear that Shadow Weaver's spell hadn't exactly been a walk in the park for Adora, but Catra had, for some reason, assumed that at the very least, the memories would be blurred. That would have made the spell a shitty experience, but with limited long-lasting consequences. Only, Adora's earlier jokes about handcuff lockpicking or, more pressingly, her clear guilt over the things she'd said back in the Fright Zone, all seem to hint that those memories are actually *much* clearer than Catra had anticipated. And apparently, the consequences don't just include memories: she's still drained now, days after it was lifted.

Although, that last part might just be Adora not taking the time to recover. Part of her wants to be angry at her new best friends for not getting her to rest more, but… Well, she's known Adora long enough to know that that often falls in the *lost causes* category.

Only, now, Catra can't help but wonder just how bad the consequences are. *Pretty fucking bad* is a fair, if vague assessment, she'd wager. It's at least bad enough that Adora can't quite hide them. And if the *aftermath* is that bad, well… That's not very reassuring concerning the spell itself. Castaspella's words hadn't been encouraging, and the memory of the red, crackly shocks is still very present in Catra's mind.

She's so engrossed in her thoughts that she doesn't realize she's spoken until the words echo against the cavern walls around her. "What was it like?"

There's a brief silence, and Catra closes her eyes, hoping against hope the dark ahead will have swallowed her words before they could reach Adora.

"What?"

No such luck, of course.

Oh, what the hell. "Shadow Weaver's spell. The sorceress said it was… probably not great, but she didn't specify." Silence meets her words, and she finds herself scrambling to fill it, feeling stupid. "If you even remember, I mean. Or want to talk about it. You don't have to."

"No, I…" Adora doesn't sound angry, at least, just thoughtful. "I do remember. A bit." Catra risks a glance over her shoulder to find her staring thoughtfully at the sword in her lap. "It's kind of… distant. Not the memories themselves, but just? How it was, I guess? It's like…" She suddenly raises her head towards Catra, who quickly refocuses her attention on the rock ahead of her. "Do you remember those mornings sometimes in the Fright Zone, when we'd get out, and there was so much fog you couldn't see your fingers if you stretched out your arms?"

Catra hums an agreement. She can almost feel the phantom sting of it, the chemical taste at the back of her throat.

"It was a bit like that. Like I was myself, but everything else was sort of… muted. Stuck through fog. Hard to see, harder to care about." She falls silent, but Catra knows better than to interrupt. "It was weird because… I *remembered* caring about all that, about the Horde and winning the war. I knew how I was *supposed* to feel, but I just… couldn't." She laughs a little, self-deprecating. "I just told myself I needed to try harder. Didn't help much. So I just… went through the motions, I guess. Tried to make it look right, at least."

Catra realizes she's holding her breath, and forces an exhale. "Sounds awful," she manages eventually, tone carefully controlled. Another shove, and a small pile of rubble falls loose. The hole's almost as wide as her shoulders now.

"It wasn't that bad."

Catra breaks her self-imposed "look away" order to shoot her a look. The other girl winces a little, but doesn't let off.

"I mean, it wasn't… *Good*," she amends, chewing on her bottom lip and pointedly not looking at Catra directly, "but, you know. All things told, it wasn't *that* different from usual, I guess." She huffs a short, self-deprecating laugh. "It was just… more *direct* than before, but all in all, it was all about Shadow Weaver wanting me to be certain things, and…" Her voice falters a little, but she pushes through to the end of the sentence. "And me failing at being that, I guess."

There's a silence, while Catra grapples with Adora's words, and with the guilt that weighs them down, trying to understand what the hell she's even *talking* about –as far as Shadow Weaver had been concerned, Catra's pretty sure Adora had never failed at *anything*. She doesn't get to a conclusion before Adora speaks again.

"Huh. Okay, so maybe it was pretty bad." She sounds genuinely surprised, and if this was any other situation, Catra might have

laughed. Instead, she refocuses on her task, pushing at a stubborn rock that refuses to move.

Because *pretty bad* doesn't sound like it covers it. It sounds hellish, and the fact that Adora barely seems to realize that tightens her lungs until breathing becomes much more difficult than it has any right to be.

Adora's drive is everything that makes her *her* –she radiates determination when she brushes her *teeth*, for stars' sake. Having that taken away from her… It's a wonder she managed to get out of bed at all. Every day must have been a swing between the nightmares she had every night and the living one she was stuck in.

Funny, really, that Catra's dream life, where everything was *right*, would be Adora's nightmare.

She bites the inside of her cheek against the thought, pushing against the rock harder until it starts digging into her hands, but it doesn't quiet her head. The fact is, she almost *left* Adora under that spell. She stood by for weeks, and let it happen. Even once she'd decided to get her out, while she was planning their escape from the Fright Zone, she'd changed her mind over and over, dozens of times.

And then in Bright Moon… She hadn't done it, but she'd *considered* it, standing in the half-remembered ruins of Thaymor. She'd thought about blowing the plan to hell and not lifting the spell, all because it would have been better for *her*. Because at least then, Adora would have stayed.

Shadow Weaver always said Catra was selfish, after all. Catra had just never realized how *right* she was.

She shoves harder, and her hand slips, sliding against a sharper edge. She pulls back with a hiss; in the dim light of her torch, she can see the thin cut it dug into her palm, blood reflecting darkly.

She must have been silent for too long, because Adora speaks again, a note of anxiety in her voice that's badly hidden under false cheerfulness. "I mean, it wasn't *all* bad." Catra almost laughs; of course Adora wouldn't be able to handle the idea of someone, much less Catra, worrying about her. "Some stuff was still… fine. Fighting, that still felt normal."

Catra wipes her palm against the leg of her trousers, ignoring the pain as she resumes her prodding against the stuck rock. "Fighting?"

A hum. "Sparring, I mean. The physical act of it, training… It felt like it always had, that was good."

Well, that explained why she'd dived back into training with that much intensity. She'd never been one to slack off, but she'd gone particularly hard after her return to the Fright Zone, hours and hours of training, pushing herself to the brink of exhaustion, over and over.

Silence falls, and Catra figures it's the end of the conversation – which is for the best, really. She huffs a bit at the stubborn, still very much immobile rock, before shifting so she can use her shoulder to push against it.

"And… You, as well."

Her foot slips and she drops, hip knocking painfully against the rock. She manages to scramble for a hand hold before she goes tumbling down the pile, but there's no disguising the squeak in her voice. "*What*?"

Adora is very carefully not looking in her direction, gaze intently focused on the sword in her lap, but she explains. "Under the spell, I mean. You still felt right. Real."

It's more that she cared about you through *the mindwiping and brainwashing*.

No. No, she can't let herself think like that. It's not *like that*, it's just… Shadow Weaver fucking up. Adora seeing her as so weak, so needing protection that it broke through fucking *mind wiping*.

"Kind of why it sucked a *lot* when you gave me the cold shoulder, ha," she continues, and it's nearly impossible to tell in the dim lighting, but Catra is almost positive she's flushing.

Catra stands up and gets back into position against the rock, but doesn't push –it's like all her strength's been zapped.

Adora looks up, tilting her head as she takes in Catra's slouched posture. "You alright?"

She clears her throat, feeling oddly off-balance. "Yeah. Yeah, uh. This one's…" Her voice trails off and she squeezes her cut hand tight into a fist, letting the sharp pain clear her head. "This one is stuck, I think."

"Oh." She drums her fingers against her knee for a second before suddenly pushing to her feet and extending the sword in Catra's direction. "Here."

Catra blinks. "What?"

She nods her head towards the faintly glowing sword. "Take it."

"You want me to take your magic sword?"

An amused half smile crosses her face. "You didn't seem to mind earlier."

She *hadn't*, but for some reason, the memory of their fight earlier on the skiff brings a flush to her face. It feels like a lifetime ago.

Adora's expression softens. "You can use it as a lever."

She needs to get herself together. Slowly, she starts heading down, still dubitative. "You want me to use your magic sword as a lever?"

“Got a better idea?”

She kind of doesn’t, but still… “What if it breaks?”

Adora snorts, loosening her grip and letting the sword swing around so she’s offering her the hilt. “It’s a magical sword. I don’t think it *can* break.” Her expression softens. “Plus, I trust you.”

That does not help with the flustering situation. Catra still feels completely unbalanced when her hand closes around the hilt. “Guess we’ll find out,” she says, pointedly ignoring the second part of Adora’s statement, but even then, the words land a few miles off the casual, cool tone she’d been aiming for.

Adora’s expression morphs into something unreadable, and Catra bails, scrambling back up the rock pile with the sword in hand. She’s not a *complete* asshole, so she tosses Adora her flashlight so she’s not stuck in pitch darkness, before getting to work wedging the blade into one of the crevices.

Once it’s solidly fixed into place, she plants her feet as solidly as she can and wraps both hands around the golden hilt. For one very weird second, she’d swear she can feel it humming under her palms, and she has to fight the urge to toss it into the dark pit beyond. It hadn’t felt anything like that earlier, but it’s not like she’d had much time to think about it.

Whatever. The dark must be getting to her. Studiously ignoring the feeling, she starts pushing, feeling a satisfying answering wobble from the boulder.

Adora’s voice comes again, snapping her out of it. “I didn’t thank you. For helping me.”

The sword damn near well flies out of her hands and into the pit beyond. She scrambles to steady her grip, voice a little strangled. “You don’t have to.”

“No, I do. I mean, I want to. I… You took a lot of risks, to get me out. And, regardless of… I mean, it’s a big deal. So. Thank you.”

Catra's about ninety percent certain her voice is gone for good, and her knees almost buckle with relief when she hears it –a bit raspy, but better than nothing. "You'd have done the same for me."

To her surprise, Adora snorts. "Not like I would have needed to." Before Catra can feel offended –yes, Shadow Weaver wouldn't have gone to that trouble to keep her around, but there's no need to phrase it like *that*–, she adds: "I'm pretty sure that spell wouldn't even have worked on you, anyway."

Catra's mind has to do a 180 –she's clearly *way* misinterpreted Adora's original words, but the actual meaning is *far* from clear. "What?"

"Well, you know. You never listened to Shadow Weaver; spell or not, you wouldn't have believed her."

Catra does *not* know, because what the *fuck*. "Adora," she says, completely incredulous, "it was a *magic spell*. I couldn't have disrespected my way out of a *memory lock*."

This time it's an actual laugh that answers her. "Well, firstly, if anyone could, it *would* be you," Adora points out, before growing more serious. "But you know what I mean. You… stood up to her."

"Yeah, against your advice." The words are quick and sharp, but she can't hold them back, not with the echoes of the seemingly thousands of times Adora had sided with Shadow Weaver.

You are *kind of disrespectful.*

She grits her teeth and pushes harder against the metal, until the hilt digs painfully into her cut palm.

"Well, I guess." Is she imagining it, or is Adora's voice a bit weaker? It doesn't matter anyway. "I was just trying to… Make it easier for us, I guess. I just thought that if you went along with it, maybe she'd go easier on you."

Push. Don't think. *Don't* say anything.

"But… she wouldn't have, would she?" Adora's voice is barely audible.

"No," Catra grits out, the word bitter enough to taste. "She wouldn't have."

This conversation needs to *die* right here and then; it's the only way Catra can even *hope* to retain enough self-composure to actually make it *out* of this cave.

But, as always, Adora doesn't get the memo. Instead of letting it wither into faded obscurity, she speaks again, her voice wavering the slightest bit.

"You were right, earlier."

Catra closes her eyes briefly. She doesn't even know what Adora is referring to, but it can't be good. "I usually am," she quips, hoping against hope that Adora will get her drift and *stop talking about this*, but, of course, no such luck.

"I do…" She trails off, before continuing with renewed determination. "You're right. I did go after you because I felt guilty."

Catra's throat is suddenly feeling very, *very* tight, no Shadow Weaver tricks necessary. Great.

"*But*," Adora continues quickly, a note of warning in her voice, "it's not because of… Whatever you said. It's just… Well, I let you down." Her voice drops lower, smaller, like Adora's vocal chords are getting crushed under the weight of her misery. "You helped me, you took all those risks for me, you *saved* me, when all I did was let you down."

Catra clings to the sword, the metal hilt suddenly becoming a lifeline as the words don't quite sink in, improbable and incomprehensible. "Adora–"

"No," she says, interrupting with a firmer tone. "No, it's true. You said it, that was the deal. The deal was we looked out for each other, and I didn't hold my end, and I knew that. And I just… I wanted to make that right, if I could. Or at least apologize."

There's about a ninety percent chance Catra is not currently breathing; she can't quite be bothered to check anyway. "Adora," she tries again, and fuck if her voice doesn't sound strangled to her own ears, "Thaymor was a fucking *mess* of a day, but–"

"Thaymor?" Adora sounds surprised. "Oh. Well, yes, I mean Thaymor, too, but it's not–" She trails off with a frustrated huff that Catra recognizes as her struggling to find the right words. "I let you down when I left, but I meant when we were growing up. I… I *tried* to help, but I always let you down. I *failed*. You stood up to her, but I never did."

The ground might as well have dropped under her feet. For a moment, Catra feels almost weightless as she processes Adora's words, from underneath the literal metric ton of guilt they seem to be encased in.

And then her meaning hits.

That's… Catra would be lying if she said she hadn't had that exact thought a few times growing up; watching Adora always say the right thing, do the right thing, be the perfect cadet, while Catra would get berated for breathing… Of course she had. But there's something about hearing it here and now, out of Adora's mouth, so desperately self-berating, with barely a hint of her usual energy after spending weeks under a spell… It doesn't feel like vindication.

Actually, it feels pretty fucking *terrible.*

"No."

Adora stops, a short, silent surprise echoing between them. "No?" she repeats tentatively after a few seconds.

"No." It takes her a moment to get her breathing under control enough that she knows her voice will be steady for her next words. "That… That wasn't on… Shadow Weaver's bullshit…" She exhales, finally forcing the words out. "There was nothing you could have done."

"I could have–"

"*Adora*." Catra is clutching the hilt so tightly she can feel her heartbeat echo through her hands. Her next words come through gritted teeth. "You *couldn't* have. Shadow Weaver…" Her voice gives out on her, and she clears her throat, restarting the sentence. "If you'd tried, all you'd have achieved was getting that spell thrown at you earlier on. It wouldn't have made a difference."

For a second, there's no sound other than the distant trickle of water and Catra's heartbeat in her ears.

Because she's *right*, she realizes. She had never really thought of it that way, mostly because she'd been so *certain* Adora could do no wrong in Shadow Weaver's eyes, but that spell proved it, didn't it? Shadow Weaver *did* prefer Adora, but only so long as Adora did what she wanted. So long as Adora was whatever Shadow Weaver wanted her to be. Even *if* Adora had tried to stand up to her, all it would have done would be to push Shadow Weaver to more *direct* methods, the way her stint with the Rebellion had.

And, Catra suddenly thinks with a twisted knot in her throat, Adora *had* tried. She *had*, standing up for Catra, never enough to make a difference, and in a way that had always felt so *hollow* to Catra but… *Could* it have made a difference? All of a sudden, she *really*, really isn't so sure.

"Yeah," Adora says after a moment, her whisper barely audible. "Maybe you're right. Maybe there was never really a choice at all."

Yeah, Catra's starting to realize that. She wouldn't know how to *begin* to untangle the complex mess of emotions swirling in her

chest, but she does know one thing; Adora's not the one who should be apologizing. Not for this.

With a shuddering breath, Catra squares the thought away and turns her attention back to the blockade, trying to bite back a small smile she can't quite understand. "Of course I'm right." She pushes on the golden hilt with a renewed burst of strength, and is met with complete, unfailing resistance. She pauses for a second, forcing a couple of steadying breaths against the dizziness before she continues. "You know what *was* a choice, though? That cape of yours," she says, her casual delivery slightly ruined by the breathlessness that has nothing to do with the physical effort. "*That?* That was a bad choice."

Adora's laugh is more startled than amused, the sudden drop in tension so intense Catra feels her own shoulders drop down. "I didn't *choose* it."

Catra hums, giving another push to the lever with remarkably less enthusiasm than previously. Speaking of capes. That rock is not going to budge, lever or not. It needs more strength than she possesses.

And she knows just what might do the trick, as much as she hates it.

She glowers at the sword for a few seconds, before breaking the silence, looking back over her shoulder at Adora. "Does it have to be all… bright and magick-y and explode-y?"

Adora looks lost, so Catra pulls the sword from the crevice and lets herself slip from rock to rock, down to the ground, until she's standing in front of her.

And then she holds out the sword in Adora's direction, looking away from her face when understanding dawns on her. "We only need a *tiny* push," she continues, staring furiously at the ground. "Don't you *dare* collapse the entire cave."

Adora eyes the sword, then the pile of rocks, then back to Catra. "You sure?"

Fuck no she isn't sure. Actually, she's sure she *doesn't* want Adora to do this, and worst of all, it has nothing to do with the tunnel potentially collapsing. But she also needs *out* of here and this is the quickest way.

She nods and extends her arm further, until Adora takes the weight away. She's glad to see she at least manages to keep her breathing steady, but despite her best efforts, she can't quite get herself to look as Adora raises her sword in the air and calls the usual incomprehensible words: "For the honor of Grayskull!"

Her tone is more measured than usual, but light still fills the cavern, especially blinding after the hours they've spent in the dark. There's a rush over her skin, like the tingling she felt earlier but magnified, a breath of impossible wind, and then the light recedes to a manageable glow, and Adora is gone.

She's seen She-Ra from up close before, at Salineas, but this feels… closer, somehow, without the distraction of the Sea Gate or the Rebels or the Horde. The cave around them is empty, which means there isn't really anything *else* to focus on, even if she wasn't literally the main source of light right now.

She's tall –Catra has to tilt her head to look at her, which she hates. It's not a *surprise*, but for some reason it still catches her off-guard. The hair and cape fluttering in a non-existent breeze are also pretty distracting, but it's mostly the way her eyes glow faintly that makes Catra want to take a step back and *hiss*. They radiate magic in the same way that Castaspella's intricate drawings had.

She-Ra shakes her head a little –long, glowy, spun gold hair floats around her shoulders, unimpeded by something as pedestrian as gravity–, and she blinks a few times before focusing her gaze on Catra. "Right," she says eventually. "So. Which rock am I allowed to smash, then?"

Catra's not sure what it is; maybe it's the tone, painfully fake and upbeat to try and cover up the just as painfully tangible awkwardness; maybe it's the smile, small and hopeful and just as uncomfortable; or maybe it's just the words themselves, so ridiculously *Adora*. Nothing like the eldritch, ancient wisdom you'd expect from an eight-foot-tall warrior being who glows with literal magic.

Whatever it is, it's a game-changer. Because suddenly, Catra *isn't* staring at an arcane magical being anymore; she's staring at *Adora*.

Taller, glowier Adora, for sure. But also just… Adora. Adora, whom she witnessed tripping over her own feet in training more times than she can count. Adora, who fights in her sleep. Adora, who needs to do *push-ups* when she's sad.

Just… Adora.

Catra bursts out laughing.

"Uh," Adora says after a second, awkwardly shuffling from one foot to the other. If anything, that makes Catra laugh even harder, watching this tall, intimidating being of pure magic being so perfectly, *dorkily* Adora. "Is everything. Okay, or?"

She catches her breath enough to speak –barely. There are *tears* in her eyes, and she's 95% sure that they're not *all* linked to a hysterical stress response. "Sorry," she manages, "it's just… The get up's even stupider than I remember."

There's a pause as Adora apparently processes her words. And then her concerned awkwardness melts away, replaced by annoyed disbelief. She raises an eyebrow and crosses her –softly glowing, might-as-well-be-chiseled-in-stone– arms. "Really?"

"Really. Seriously, can't you do something about… any of this?" She makes a vague gesture that encompasses the whole outfit. "All I'm saying is, you should reconsider the accessorizing you've got going on, here."

"It's an *ancient magical sword I found in the woods*. Sorry if it's not up to your fashion standards." Adora is trying very hard to keep a straight face, but there's amusement in the creases by her eyes.

"Still." Catra tilts her head, wiping one last tear of mirth away. "You've got to admit, the cape's a bit much."

Adora opens her mouth, looking like she's about to argue, but instead, she stops to look over her shoulder at the cape that is still very much floating behind her. "Yeah," she concedes eventually, scrunching her face a little. "Maybe a bit."

With one more chuckle, Catra starts her way back up the barricade, taking the steady lighting as indication that Adora follows. She's not worried about Adora stumbling now –for one, there's the whole magical princess thing, and, mostly, the space is so brightly lit that the climb becomes as easy as going up a flight of stairs.

"Right then," she says once they're at the top, while Adora bends forward to avoid banging her head into the rocky ceiling. She points to the recalcitrant rock. "That's the one." Adora nods and swings her sword into a battle ready stance, and Catra can't help but wince and add: "*Please* be careful."

Adora arches a brow. "Once again, mysterious magical sword I found in the woods. Not really a scalpel."

"All I'm saying is, if you kill us with a rock fall, I'm coming back to life and killing you myself."

Adora chuckles, like she always does when Catra talks shit at her, and then she gets to work. With precise, controlled slices of her sword, she starts hacking away at the boulder.

She makes quick work of it: the dark brown stone is no match for a magic sword, and chips of it go flying in a nonstop, pattering rain. There's a few occasions where a hit sends a few more nearby rocks rolling, making the both of them freeze until it quiets

down again, but the tunnel doesn't come collapsing on top of their heads, which Catra counts as a win. Adora even goes a bit overboard, and by the time she stands back, the hole is large enough for Catra to go through standing, only needing to bend forward a little.

She turns back around once she's through, standing on a boulder on the other side of the passage with a grin. "Not bad," she concedes.

Adora eyes her, one eyebrow up. "Not bad?" she repeats flatly. She pointedly looks at the perfectly circular opening she's carved into the rock, and Catra feels her smirk grow.

"Don't fish, Adora," she calls out in a singsong. She pivots on her heel, ready to shine her shitty torch down to get an idea of the layout, but her laughter catches in her throat and turns into a shriek when she loses control of the movement, her foot slipping on the damp stone. The pull of gravity, inexorable and uncontrollable, grabs at her and she feels herself start to fall–

A hand, warm and golden, wraps around her wrist, holding her in place. Eyes wide and heart hammering with panic, she looks up to find herself staring into equally panicked blue eyes. "You okay?"

Her balance restored, she quickly rights herself and takes a step back, careful to stay on stable ground. Adora drops her hand immediately, and Catra fists hers at her back against the vaguely ticklish feeling she can't shake. She clears her throat. "Fine. Careful, it's not stable on this side either." A pause as she represses a wince. "Thanks."

Adora's gracious enough not to rub it in. She nods with a small smile and makes her way through the opening. "I can go first. You know, light the way. Literally."

Catra's still too unsettled to protest, and so Adora sets off, carefully testing rocks before putting her weight on them. The

light she emits is barely enough to dent the large space, but the ground isn't too far down.

The tingling feeling doesn't fade. Absent-mindedly, she rubs her opposite thumb onto her palm, where it's strongest.

And then she freezes into place, looking down.

Her skin is smooth and unmarred. No trace of the tiny scrapes she accumulated while trekking through the cave. More strikingly, no trace of the long, thin cut she'd opened just minutes before.

*

Catra recognizes the dark, metallic podium immediately.

Adora, who'd changed back into herself as soon as they'd cleared the blockade, doesn't pause, apparently not noticing it, but she stops when she realizes Catra's stopped walking. "Catra?"

She doesn't answer right away, running a finger along the edge of the square surface at the top. There's a thick layer of dust, but…

She slams the side of her fist against the top right corner with a dull *thud*. For a second, nothing happens, and then the whirr of ancient, dust-choked fans starts echoing, coming from inside the metallic structure. With a grin, she watches as the screen set into the top struggles to life, the light washed out but plenty after so long in near complete darkness.

Eventually, the screen resolves into a simple, pixelated text message: *Course primed. Press START to begin. Assessed elements will be given one minute to get into position*.

"Wait," Adora breathes next to her, eyes wide as she gazes at the screen. "Is that…"

"Final assessment course, yeah." The cave had a bunch of separate courses, but this was the real deal; your time in that particular stretch was worth half your grade, when it came to getting to the officer cadet rank. And it made you work for it, too: it was by far the most challenging one, a race that tested speed and agility, but also reasoning and memory.

"I can't believe that thing still works," Adora says, gingerly poking at the top of the screen.

Catra's surprised too, if she's honest, but she's not complaining. For a start… "It means we're almost out of here," she points out, relief filling her at the idea of being under open sky again. The light will be killer, but she'll take that over the threat of tons of rock collapsing on top of them with no warning any time.

Adora's gaze flits briefly to her, expression unreadable. "Yeah," she says in an oddly flat tone. "Guess it does." She takes a step back, eyeing the darkened passage ahead. "Hopefully the power went out when the end of section gates were open," she mumbles.

About that… With only a flicker of hesitation, Catra takes a deep breath and taps the large START sign.

Instantly, the cavern around them fills with light. Strips of light fixtures affixed to the cavern walls flicker to life with a few wheezes and groans, making them squint in the sudden brightness. The noise echoes all the way ahead, *clings* and *clangs* as the assessment course slowly, but surely, comes back to life after years of disuse.

Adora pivots on her heel to stare at her, mouth open. "Catra!"

She shrugs, barely holding back her smile. "Looks like the power didn't go out at all."

"What are you *doing*?" Adora's incredulous, but she doesn't sound particularly angry. The light also means Catra can catch sight of the slight flicker in her eyes, and as it happens, she knows precisely what anticipation looks like on Adora.

"Oh, come on," she says. "Like you said; if the power was out with the gates at the end shut, we'd have been stuck. That way we're sure they'll open."

"They'll open *if* we make it through the course," Adora points out, a dash incredulous, but Catra doesn't miss the way she rolls back onto her heels and then to the tip of her toes.

She glances one last time at the screen –*39 seconds remaining, place assessed elements in starting position*– and makes her way over to where Adora's standing, stopping just behind the dark black line that's somehow still visible on the cave floor. "*Please*. We'll ace it. Just like we always did."

Letting Adora process, she squints at the cavern wall nearest to her. Metal shelves are still set into the rock, most of them rusted. Unfortunately, they also look empty –no forgotten quarterstaves left behind.

Her hand falls to the hilt of the laser whip she's been carrying tucked in her belt. Paying no mind to Adora's protests about the course, she frees it, experimentally swinging her wrist a little. It's lighter than she expected.

Thumbing the switch on the handle, she turns towards a metal bar set into a wall about twenty feet away, squeezes one eye shut to aim, and *flicks* her wrist.

The whip crackles with energy as it flies through the air, blinding white. It connects with the metal bar with a deafening *crack*, wrapping around the steel; one pull, and the whole thing rips out of the wall, crashing into the floor. With a few more tentative tugs and twists, Catra frees the end of her weapon, bringing it back to a starting position with a grin.

Oh, yeah. She can work with this.

She suddenly realizes Adora has gone quiet. She turns back towards her, to find her staring at the whip in Catra's hand with an expression Catra can't quite parse. She lifts a brow. "Unless, of

course," she says, her tone as innocent as she can make it, "you're worried I'll win. *Again*."

Adora rolls her eyes at that, but she still seems unsure.

Catra sighs and makes her way to the starting zone. "If it makes you feel better, you can do the whole–" she waves a hand vaguely in Adora's direction– "magical princess thing." She pauses, precisely timing it for maximum nonchalance. "Not that the tiara will help you win."

It does the trick. The rest of the unease fades from Adora's face, replaced by cocky disbelief. "*Okay*, I do not need a tiara to kick your ass."

"Mhm." She has to bite back a smile when she spots Adora's stance growing distinctly more *huffy*.

Adora walks up to her, and holding back her smile suddenly takes twice as much effort when Catra realizes the girl has her sword in hand, clearly ready to use it.

"I don't think the point counters still work," Adora says, eyeing the rusty equipment around them.

"Guess I'll just have to make my victory indisputable."

Finally, Adora breaks into a smile, and Catra feels the same rush she always has at the sight. "Good luck with that."

Almost on cue, a loud, blaring *beep* fills the air, and the section ahead of them lights up.

Catra takes off running, vaguely aware of Adora on her heels –the girl is fast, but Catra knows she's faster. Her memories of the assessment itself are blurry, but she remembers enough not to let herself be fooled by the innocuous appearance of the stretch of tunnel they're crossing.

That turns out to be a good thing. It's barely seconds before the deceptively sturdy looking metal ground starts dropping under their feet, revealing a network of platforms separated by dark, uninviting gaps. Effortlessly, Catra leaps away from the nearest chasm onto the next platform, without slowing. Distantly, she notices Adora doing the same thing, a few steps behind her, but her focus is quickly stolen again when a first volley of laser projectiles shoots out from the wall to her right. Nothing deadly, but definitely painful and incapacitating.

Well, painful and incapacitating *if* they get her, which they don't come close to –she tucks into a roll, standing back up in a fluid motion once she's out of range. She sprints forward, narrowly ducking under a mechanical arm swinging out of the ceiling, and flicks her whip, sending the tail end smack into the nearest red circle. No *beep* –the point counters must be out, just like Adora guessed.

But that's okay; the deep gouge her weapon leaves into the metal is much more satisfying anyway.

Adora seems to agree; she slashes at the metal circles on her path with her sword, splitting most of the targets in half. They stay neck to neck, stealing each other's targets as they run forward, ducking under laser volleys and avoiding obstacles.

Catra spies Adora gearing up to stab an overhead red circle and, with a precise flick of the wrist, sends her whip slashing at the metal before she can get to it. The circle splits with a satisfying crack, and, with an additional twist of the hilt, she wraps the end around a metal beam and uses the weapon to swing over Adora, gaining a few feet on her.

"*Hey*, stick to your *own* targets!" she hears Adora complain.

She doesn't bother holding back her laughter. "Go faster, then."

Her laughter trails off into a *squeak* as Adora puts on a burst of speed under her, jumping onto the narrow platform she'd been

aiming for and effectively stranding her in the air. She saves it, barely, stumbling down onto an adjacent platform with significantly less elegance than she'd planned. "*Hey!*"

Adora turns back to shoot her a cocky, self-assured grin. "Sorry, what was that? I was too busy being *faster than you*."

Catra rolls her eyes, using a path of platforms much too narrow for Adora's sense of balance to overtake her again. "See you at the finish," she calls over her shoulder, smug and laughing. "But I'm not waiting for longer than two hours, so you'd better hurry– *wow!*"

Catra reels back with a yelp, as a sudden burst of bright gold flames comes shooting out of the wall, right in front of her face.

She has to fight against her own momentum to keep from toppling right into the fire. The heat comes at her in a scorching wave, making her hold her breath reflexively, and it takes her a second of windmilling her arms to regain her balance. The flare of flame dies down, and Catra has to resist the urge to smack herself on the forehead –how had she forgotten about the *fire* part?

"Tired already?" Adora's voice is pure smugness as she goes flying past Catra at a light, effortless-looking run. She gracefully sidesteps the jet of flames that returns at her approach, and bounds over onto the next platform, pausing to give her a cocky look.

Catra rolls her eyes, before following suit, dodging to the side of the flames' limited reach. "Just curious to see how you do without me to activate all the traps for you," she shoots back, catching up to Adora's position in a few agile leaps.

Now she remembers they're there, she can spot the flamethrowers all over the section of the track ahead. The first one was proximity-based, but the next ones are already lighting up, bursts of bright yellow flame searing their imprints on her retinas.

Right. The track didn't just test speed, but memory as well. Nothing better to encourage memorization than getting hit by literal flames if you get it wrong.

She exchanges a look with Adora, and, with one last grin, they're off.

She doesn't remember the exact patterns, but she's sharp enough to analyze them on the fly. She dives and ducks, flicking her wrist to catch the targets with the tail end of her whip as she goes. The air is bordering on unbreathable, each flash of flame adding to the uncomfortable temperatures, but she barely feels it, completely focused on the task at hand.

Only… She can't help but notice *other* things too, and quickly, those *other* things start taking precedence over the patterns themselves.

A darkened, soot-covered flame fuel nozzle spitting out nasty looking electrical sparks and dark fumes.

A conduit running along the wall, cracked and leaking a fluid that can only be an accelerant.

The wheeze of ancient, rusted machinery as the disused track struggles to keep feeding the dozens of flamethrowers at play.

She realizes what's going to happen precisely one second before it actually does.

Adora is barely a few steps ahead, her hair glowing like spun gold in the light of the flames as she slashes her sword at one of the targets. Above her, a metal conduit creaks and *bends* and–

With a renewed burst of speed, Catra dives forward and shoves Adora with all her strength. Her friend goes tumbling forward with a yell, managing to turn the unavoidable fall into a roll along the metal platform.

Catra gets the time to catch the incredulous expression on her face when she turns back to look at Catra before the conduit *cracks*.

A shower of fuel drops in a curtain, and immediately catches on the flame spit out by the nearest generator. Throwing an arm up to protect her face, Catra scrambles backwards, the sudden flash of light and heat powerful enough to throw her off her feet. When she next manages to look up, sitting on the platform, she finds herself staring at a literal wall of flames separating her from Adora –and, accessorily, from the exit.

"Catra!" Adora is barely visible through the blinding fire, and Catra has to squint to even make her out. Her voice is drowned out by the roar too –the sudden burst of heat seems to have fried whatever computer controlled the generator, which means it's now constantly projecting additional fuel. Great.

She makes it to her feet, but can't even approach the wall much – the heat is simply *too much*. "Adora, get *out* of here," she calls out, without much hope.

Unsurprisingly, Adora ignores her completely. Maybe she didn't hear her, but Catra doubts it. "Can you break the generator from your side?"

She glances at the metal, glowing a faint red in the constant flame –it clearly wasn't designed for this kind of temperature. She *could* try a whip slash, but she's pretty sure all it would achieve is to short her weapon out. "Don't think so."

"Okay, I think I can–" Whatever plan Adora's come up with is interrupted by a deafening, terrifying *creaking* sound. Her heart in her throat, Catra looks up to find the flames spreading *up*, along the conduit, a bluish, almost transparent glow that then spreads to the *other* pipes, running the length of the entire track, above and around her. With *pops* and *crackles*, the pipes behind her start bursting, projecting thin streams of nearly vaporized fluid which, in the heat, catch fire almost immediately.

She doesn't know if it's the heat or the oxygen running thin, but it's getting harder to breathe.

"Catra–"

Again, the rest of Adora's sentence is swallowed up by noise; a rumble echoes from far above them, and, despite the nearly unbearably scorching air, Catra feels her blood turn to ice in her veins.

The cavern starts *shaking*, tremors still faint, but unmistakable. The sudden burst of heat is too much for the already bordering on collapsing cave.

It's going to come down.

"Adora, you need to *go!"* This time, Catra's tone brokers no argument. This entire thing is about to come crashing down on top of their heads, metric tons of rocks and dirt and metal, but Adora can still *make it.* The exit isn't far from the end of this section, and, with some luck, the heat will have shorted out the rest of the traps–

Catra's stomach sinks. The doors marking the exit of the course – those only unlock when the course is cleared. Adora might very well be trapped, too.

It's still worth a try; it's a better shot than Catra has, anyway. But if Adora wants to have any chance at getting out of here, she has to go *now.*

But when has Adora ever done the sensible thing? Through the blinding heat, Catra can just about make her out, still on the other side of the wall of flames, still very much not moving.

A tremor shakes a few large rocks loose, and one of them hits the conduit running along the wall next to her. It explodes in a shower of sparks that quickly turn into roaring flames, and she jumps out of the way with a hiss which promptly turns into a cough. A look over her shoulder shows going back isn't an option, even if the

entire thing wasn't about to collapse: the flames have spread, turning the way they'd come from into a death trap.

She's stuck here.

"Adora, *get out of here!*" Her voice cracks, and the rest of the words are lost in a coughing fit. The heat is making her eyes water, the smell of burning overpowering enough to make her head spin.

On the other side of the flames, through the smoke and rock dust that are now clouding her vision, she sees Adora, a shadow standing immobile.

And then the silhouette turns, and *runs*. It vanishes almost immediately.

Relief and confusion and a whole mess of emotions Catra simply does not have the oxygen to parse at the moment explode into her chest. Another burst of flames sends her staggering to the side, and she loses her balance, falling to her knees on the unforgiving metal. Her field of vision is narrowing, and every breath feels like it's dragging more soot and smoke into her lungs than oxygen. She's no expert, but she's pretty sure she doesn't have long before she's going to lose consciousness altogether–

The ceiling explodes.

It's what it feels like, at least. For one disorientated moment, she thinks the cavern has broken down, but then the debris hits her and it's *cold* and it's *light* and it's–

Water?

The shock of it is enough to snap her out of her haze and *yep*, that is water, water and something chemical she breathes and tastes as she accidentally swallows some of the unrelentingly falling liquid. It's coming down in *sheets*, the weight of it nearly enough to press her to the floor and soaking her in seconds, but mostly, smothering the flames.

Fire extinguishers.

Catra's dazed, oxygen-starved brain takes a second to even process what's just happened. The track had some kind of fire safety system, which, *of course it would*, but it hadn't kickstarted when everything had gone to hell which means it would have needed to be activated manually, which *means*–

With a sense of timing only she has ever managed to pull off, Adora suddenly bursts into her field of vision, absolutely soaked through, looking like a drowned ghost in the orangey glow of the dying flames. For one dazed, out of time moment, Catra wonders if she's hallucinating.

But no; in a few seconds, Adora is by her side, reassuringly solid, taking a hold of her arm, trying to help her sit, then stand. "Catra! Are you alright?"

It's like all her strength's been zapped out of her; she somehow manages to stand with Adora's help, but her legs feel shaky and unsure, leaving her completely reliant on Adora to stay up. "I'm–" Her reassurance is interrupted by a coughing fit, which worsens when she accidentally inhales some of the water that is still pouring from the safety conduits in the ceiling.

The ground below them shakes again, much more noticeably than before, and, in the distance, Catra hears the rumble of collapsing rocks. Apparently, the cave is *not* a fan of the abrupt cooling either.

"We have to get out of here," Adora says, urgent and yet barely audible under the sound of water and flame and rock. "This whole place is coming down."

Deciding to save her strength, or whatever is left of it, Catra simply nods, and starts forward with Adora's help. The temperature is still insanely high, and the air is filled with steam and smoke and water, making breathing a challenge. It takes them a few seconds to get to a rhythm they can sustain, though

Catra can *feel* Adora's restraint, and the way she wants to drag them *out* of here.

Pushing past protesting muscles and screaming lungs, Catra manages to break into a run alongside Adora, and they sprint under the torrents of seemingly endless water and progressively collapsing rock.

It feels hopeless. So much so, in fact, that the sudden shock of daylight after a sharp turn to the right almost has her stumbling in surprise. But Adora has a good hold on her and keeps her upright, and, with renewed hope, Catra puts all her strength into crossing the last stretch of tunnel separating them from the outside.

Just as they cross the miraculously open massive metal doors marking the end of the cave, the cavern finally gives up. With an ear-splitting crack, it collapses into a heap of rock and metal, and they crash in a tangle of limbs onto the grass right outside the tunnel. It's less than a second before the entrance they just went through is completely sealed off, collapsed onto itself.

Soaked, completely out of breath, and her lungs on literal fire, Catra flops down onto her back next to Adora, staring up at the bright blue sky above her head, obscured only by a few green leaves from a nearby tree branch. For a moment, all is quiet save for a few birds and the two of them pulling in shaky, ragged breaths.

They made it out.

Slowly, Catra's breathing evens out. The cool, clean air soothes the ragged, painful mess of her throat and, after a few moments, she feels herself start to be able to *think* again, the confusion and panic abating.

Still, she takes a few more seconds before she speaks, wincing at how cracked and wrecked her voice sounds. "So." She clears her throat, which is painful, but at least gives her some voice back. "What the *fuck* was that, Adora?"

Adora's voice comes in a flat, carefully neutral tone that tells Catra the girl is biting back a smile. "Fire safety systems."

"Right."

Adora hums, and Catra can hear the smile in that, too.

"You activated the fire safety systems?"

"Well, you could say that."

Catra raises an eyebrow, even though she knows the gesture is lost on Adora. "You stabbed the fire safety systems with your sword, didn't you?"

Another hum, this time distinctly amused. "The fire extinguisher system deactivates all the traps and opens all the remaining doors when activated. Weren't you paying attention when the instructors covered fire safety protocols?" Her tone is innocence incarnate, and Catra bites back a smile that is threatening to overtake her entire face.

"Guess it slipped my mind." She pauses for a moment. "You realize that's cheating, right, Adora?"

"Well, you know. I learned from the best."

This time, Catra sits up, all the better to gape at her, despite the smile still tugging at her own lips.

Adora's lying on her back too, although her eyes are closed. She's not making any effort whatsoever to hide her smile, though, the happy grin obvious and blinding in the golden sunlight.

Catra must stay silent too long, because suddenly, Adora cracks one eye open, bright blue and clouded with a hint of concern. "You alright?"

Catra lets herself fall back down onto her back, staring up into the sky. "Well," she says eventually, because it's the only thing she can

think to say, "I think we *definitely* beat the speed record."

There's a short silence, and then Adora *breaks*.

She starts laughing, short, breathless bursts of it that Catra can't help but echo. Before she can do a thing about it, they're both gasping for air as they laugh together, happy and relieved and maybe just the slightest bit hysterical, and bringing tears to her eyes, but honestly, who can blame them? They're alive –they made it out.

And just like that, as she turns her head to find Adora with her features scrunched up in delight, it hits Catra.

Because this, *this*; stupid, gasping laughter with Adora, laughing until they're crying, until neither of them can breathe… It feels righter than anything has in days. In *weeks*. Or maybe even longer than that –because, for the first time since Catra can remember, they can just *be*. There's no instructor looming around to tell them off and order them to get up and fall in. There's no Shadow Weaver to snarl at them. They don't have to bite it back, they don't have to be quiet, they don't have to do *anything*. They're out of the Horde.

For the first time since she stole a skiff and dragged an unconscious Adora to the Whispering Woods, Catra realizes she's *free*.

She'd thought of leaving the Horde as losing everything; her life, everything she'd worked for. But this…

This doesn't feel like losing.

The Horde was never really home, after all. No, that was always Adora.

And Adora's *here*, and Catra's here, and, well. She's free now. She doesn't have to go anywhere. Not if she doesn't want to. Not this time.

Adora's laughter dies down slowly, as she seemingly realizes Catra's quieted down. She turns her head too, eyes wide and so, *so* blue as she blinks at Catra. "Are you okay?" she asks again.

Catra swallows hard. Yes, Adora is going to go back to the Rebellion, because that's her choice but… Catra can make her own choice, this time. She's free to do it, too. Maybe she was back then, as well – maybe she just hadn't realized it then.

She has now.

She looks up, away from Adora and into the endless blue of the sky. "It wasn't your fault."

"What are you–"

"Thaymor." Catra hears Adora take a sharp inhale, but continues: "It wasn't your fault. I mean, you *left*, but. I– I did, too. In a way."

The silence that follows her words is too much to bear –she risks a glance in her direction.

Bad plan; Adora is staring at her in complete, unmitigated shock. It's not an apology, it's not the apology Catra *should* give, but Adora is staring at her like she's just said sorry for every single mean thing she's said over the course of their entire lives and also maybe announced that she's the long lost queen of Bright Moon.

For a brief moment, Catra can't help but wish she were still inside that cave; literal metric tons of rocks sound like they'd be easier to breathe under than Adora's scrutiny.

She turns her face back towards the sky, swallowing hard against the constriction in her chest. "I guess my point is…We both made choices that– that could have been better."

It's not *right*, it's not good enough, and she *knows* it, but it's all she can manage, because even after all of this, she doesn't think she'll ever be able to forget the sharp, searing *twist* of betrayal when Adora had turned her back on her to help complete

strangers, when she'd thrown Catra to the damn *wolves* for them. She hopes to the *stars* Adora can hear what she's not saying. Usually, she can.

The seconds before Adora speaks again last a few centuries each. Catra feels each and every one of them, dizzyingly fast and endlessly slow.

"Yeah," Adora says eventually, and no way, *no way* is Catra even *thinking* about looking at her right now, but fuck if she can't picture the gentle smile on her face and the soft look in her eyes. "I guess we did."

For all her lack of subtlety sometimes, Adora has always been good at hearing what Catra can't say. And she's always been good at telling her things without saying them, too.

Catra breathes a long, slow breath of relief, closing her eyes and letting her face soak up the gentle warmth of the sun. "Yeah," she echoes, bordering on inaudible, and yet pouring all her gratitude into the word.

For a moment, they stay here –quiet. With all the time in the world.

Eventually, with a deep inhale, Catra forces herself to first sit, then stand. Every single muscle in her body protests, but she shakes it off, stretching quickly and shivering slightly in her soaked clothes. Hopefully the sunlight will help that dry a bit quicker. "Come on," she says once she feels a bit steadier on her own two feet. "Long way back."

Adora's already sat up, which means Catra gets a direct view of her expression *falling*, so hard and so fast that she feels her own heart drop alongside it.

"Right," Adora says, valiantly trying to get her expression under control and failing miserably –if anything, the complete devastation in her eyes is even starker in comparison with the wobbly smile she forces. She pushes herself to her feet, looking

down at the ground, up at the trees around them. Basically, anywhere but at Catra.

Catra feels her heart sink even lower. Of course, she can make her own choices; but Adora can too, and, well. If Adora doesn't feel like she can trust her, Catra can hardly begrudge her that.

She's about to say something flippant to cut off Adora's no doubt rambly and painful oncoming tirade, but she's not fast enough; Adora takes off with a stream of words so rapid it takes Catra a second to even catch them.

"Yeah, you're right, that's– I mean, yeah, bit of a long way back. For me? Probably for you, too, cause, well, you're. I don't know, but you're going? Somewhere? I think. I mean, of course you're going somewhere, you can't go *nowhere*, and it's like. Well, like you said, you know, you want to go our own separate ways, and that's cool, that's totally cool, that's fine, I get it. Yeah, you don't want to– Yeah, no, it's fine. Super fine."

Oh.

Catra blinks at her, taking in the way Adora's swinging back on her heels, then to the tip of her toes like she used to do as a kid, the way she's also swinging her hands in fists at her side, the way she's staring determinedly into the dirt at their feet, and the way her shoulders are drooping under the weight of her own misery.

Slowly, very slowly, Catra starts smiling.

Yeah. She's not leaving this moron.

Adora is still talking. "So, er, thank you? For helping me I mean. Not just today, although, *also* today but um. With the spell? And everything." She takes a sharp breath, closing her eyes briefly, before breathing out the next words at three times her already considerable speed. "And, uh. I'll miss you."

Adora trails off. It takes a few moments of the ensuing silence for her to risk a glance up, and whatever she sees on Catra's face has

her freezing in place.

Catra crosses her arms and tilts her head.

Adora stares, confusion and something a lot like hope warring in her gaze. "Um."

Catra lets the silence stretch a little, just because she can.

And then, she gestures towards the woods ahead of them. "Well, then?" She lifts an eyebrow. "Lead the way. *I* don't know how to get there."

The hope in Adora's gaze morphs into something Catra can't bear to look at for long. She rolls her eyes, instead, to hide the way she's avoiding Adora's gaze.

"Does that mean you're–" Adora's voice is hesitant, almost like she can't let herself believe what she's hearing, and warmth blooms in Catra's chest.

She masks it under a huff. "Be *normal* about it, Adora," she mumbles.

When she risks another glance up, Adora is definitely *not* being normal about it; in fact, Catra's fairly certain that she must be tapping into some kind of She-Ra magic, her grin is so bright.

To her credit though, she does attempt to rein it in. It fails miserably, excitement and pure glee radiating off of her in *waves*, but she takes a few seconds to compose herself, and even manages an approximation of casual with her next words. "Don't know what you're talking about." Her gaze flits over Catra a few times, like she can't *quite* believe what she's seeing, and it's so full of warmth Catra feels herself blushing a little.

Because she can't bear to stand still another second, Catra sets off into the woods, assuming Adora can steer them as they go. "You'd better not expect me to become all buddy buddy with

Sparkles," she warns over her shoulder. "*Or* start wearing pastel or glitter or *flowers*, or whatever."

Adora catches up to her, gently knocking her shoulder into hers. "But it would suit you so *well*," she teases, voice maybe just a little too breathy with relief, but Catra doesn't mind.

She's worried; of course she is. This is the complete unknown; the Rebellion didn't *seem* so bad, but, well, who knows what she's really walking into? But then again… Well. She's not *that* worried, either. How could she? She knows nothing truly bad can happen.

Not now that they have each other.

Chapter End Notes

> i want to give The most massive shout out ever to all the people who kept finding this fic (somehow??? how???) over the last year, and who left kudos and commented. y'all, those ao3 emails are the only reason i continued going back to this damn word document even though i was completely, utterly stuck, and therefore are the only reason this fic is now,,,,, complete (!)
>
> to everyone who's made it this far, thank you so much for taking the time to read this fic, and i hope you enjoyed! i had a fabulous time diving into those characters, their motivations, and everything that made them who they are, and i hope i managed to do them justice 💕
>
> there is,,,, an epilogue floating somewhere in my brain, but i'm in no state to make any promises about that atm, so this fic will for now be marked as complete (mostly so the wip ao3 icon can stop taunting me every time i log into this account lol); but who knows what the future shall hold ^^
>
> thank you again, and i'd love to hear what you thought! 💕
>
> come say hi on tumblr: @ariesnoctua

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!